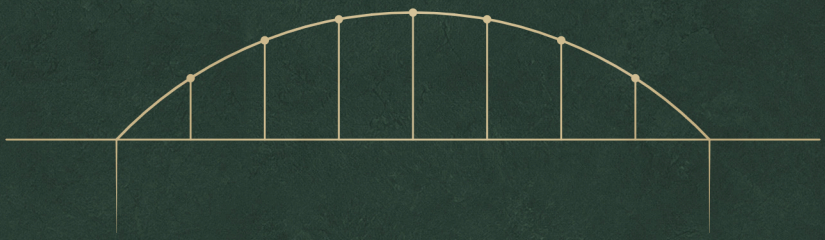
THE

SALES BIBLE

How to close clients without being salesy



JASON MOSS

THE SALES BIBLE

How to close clients without being salesy

JASON MOSS



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The ideas in this book are drawn from the author's own teaching and experience, and from the teachers credited in *Where this came from*. Results from selling depend on many factors; nothing here is a promise of specific outcomes.

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A note on how this book was made

"I am not attached to whether or not it is a yes or a no. But what I do want is to help someone get off the fence. Because the fence does not serve them."

MY FIRST SALES calls were horrible.

Since then, I've seen selling from three sides.

As the one selling, I've had more than 800 sales conversations of my own.

As the one leading, I was Director of Sales for a multi-seven-figure coaching business, with a team taking hundreds of calls a month. Listening to other people's calls teaches you things your own never will.

As the one buying, I've invested more than $200,000 in coaching, courses and mentorship. I know what it's like to sit on the other side of the table, wanting the change and deciding whether to say yes.

Along the way, I've generated millions of dollars in sales and helped more than a thousand entrepreneurs inside my programs. You won't find any of these numbers anywhere else in this book. I give them once, here, so you know nothing in it started on the page. It started on a call, with a real person on the other end, trying to decide.

What I learned on all those calls became what I teach, and this book is built from roughly the last five years of that teaching. It draws on more than 160 sources: trainings and workshops, live question-and-answer and

mastermind calls, call reviews, videos, my sales script and a written guide. That's well over a million words. Some of it I've said more times than I can count, and some of it I'd say differently now.

I used AI to read and synthesize all of it, to find where it repeated and where it changed, and to draft it into one book in my voice. The ideas, the method, the stories and the judgment calls are mine.

Where my views have shifted over the years, the book follows where I stand now. Where I'd left a question open, I answered it myself, point by point, or it stayed out of the book. Every rule and every script in these pages is one I teach.

And I didn't learn it all on my own. I had teachers, above all Cole Gordon, a sales trainer I worked with a while back, whose work really helped me. The core of my approach came from him, including much of how I structure a call and many of the lines I'll give you. So did the 1-to-10 temperature check, pacing the first objection, and the language I use around certainty and payment plans.

Keenan's book *Gap Selling* shaped how I think about the gap, the idea at the center of this book. I also learned from Taki Moore, Taylor Welch, Keith Rosen, Jeremy Miner, my mentor Scott Oldford and Alex Hormozi.

Some of what they taught me I use exactly as I learned it, and some I've reshaped on my own calls. The first time one of their ideas appears, I say whose it is. *Where this came from*, at the back, gives each of them full credit.

It took me a lot of calls to learn what's in these pages, and plenty went the way my first ones did. It's all here so that when someone brings you a change they want, you can help them decide.

How to use this book

PARTS ONE TO THREE are about why you sell the way you do, what people really pay for, and who you need to be on a call. Parts Four and Five are the call, with the exact words, from before you say hello to the days after you hang up. Part Six is how you keep getting better, and the seller you become.

The whole book is built around the seven things that really matter on a call. You'll meet them together in Chapter 2, and this is where each one is taught:

- **The frame:** Chapters 7 and 11
- **The gap:** Chapter 4
- **Discovery:** Chapters 12 and 13
- **The pitch:** Chapter 14
- **The offer:** Chapter 15
- **Objections:** Chapters 16 and 19
- **The next step:** Chapters 17 and 18

One call, with a physical therapist, runs through the book. In Chapter 1 you run it the way most of us would. In Chapters 10 to 17 you run it again, the way I would.

If you have a call tomorrow, start with Appendix A: the whole call, word for word. Then read the scenes from the physical therapist's call in Chapters 10 to 17, most of them under *On the call*. If your call is a few days off,

read Chapters 1, 4 and 5, then Chapters 10 to 18 and the pages on "I need to think about it" in Chapter 19. Other routes are at the back, in *After the call*.

In the panels, *Say it like this* gives you the words. In a swap, *Instead of* marks a line most of us reach for, and *say* puts a better one in its place. *The point* holds an idea to keep, and *Try this* is something to do before, on or after your next call.

Wherever I say *coach*, read whatever you do: consultant, advisor, therapist or service provider.

The prospects in the examples are invented. When I tell you about my own calls, or calls I've reviewed with coaches, I've left out anything that could identify the person. The timings and benchmarks I give you are rules of thumb, never promises.



PART ONE

The false choice

Why don’t my best conversations become clients?

CHAPTER ONE

Lovely conversations

YOU'VE PROBABLY HAD a call like this.

She left a clinic to open a one-person physical therapy practice. She's booked a free strategy session after watching your video on pricing. You coach practitioners on their businesses, and she's exactly the kind of person you love to help. I made her up, but you've met her.

She's warm and easy to talk to, and when she mentions her kids, you ask about them, because you want her to feel at home. You spend 20 minutes on them before you ask why she booked.

When you do, she tells you about her evenings. She's been booked solid for over a year, at the prices she set when she opened, so most nights her session notes wait until the kids are in bed. Then she tells you about dinner.

"My daughter asked me why I'm always on my laptop."

You can hear what it costs her to say that, and you don't want her carrying it alone. So you tell her, "Lots of practitioners feel this way. It isn't as bad as you think."

Half an hour in, you reach for the reframe that has helped your clients for years, because she came to you about pricing, and holding it back would feel almost unkind. It's a new way of seeing her prices and a simple way to raise them.

You take her through it one piece at a time, for well over an hour. She stops writing. She leans toward the screen and asks you to say the second part again. For the first time, raising her prices feels easy, like something she could do next month, on her own.

She goes quiet.

"Nobody's ever put it like that."

Then she starts to cry, and it's plainly relief. Something she has carried for a long time feels lighter. She apologizes, and you tell her there's nothing to apologize for.

You feel it too. This is why you do the work. It's the best moment of the call.

You want her to see everything she'd get by working with you, so you walk her through your six-month program, module by module, for 10 minutes. By the time you're done, the call has run to two hours.

Then she asks what it costs, and you want to make this part easy for her.

You say $9,000, a little too fast. Before she can answer, you mention the payment plan, so the number won't frighten her. You'd hate for her to feel sold to, the way you've felt sold to, so you tell her there's no pressure at all.

She tells you it all sounds wonderful, how much she loved talking with you, and how glad she is she booked.

"Let me think about it."

"Of course. Take all the time you need."

You hang up feeling warm. It was a lovely conversation.

You never hear from her.

The call you're proud of

Say you told me about that call afterward. You'd tell it proudly.

"We had a two-hour sales call. She cried on the call and told me how much she loved it."

I'd ask you one question. "Did you get the credit card?"

"No."

Bring nothing but heart to your sales calls, with no structure and no ask, and you'll have beautiful conversations that last for hours. Nobody will buy. I call it flailing around in relational land.

A call like that feels like a near miss, a lovely conversation that almost turned into a client. It failed the person you most wanted to help.

None of us sets out to fail anyone. I know what sends us into calls like that, because I used to feel it too: icky, uncomfortable feelings around sales, and underneath them, the fear of coming across as sleazy.

When I first pitched on webinars, I was terrible. I didn't understand how to pitch, and I felt awkward and weird about it. It took me a long time to get over that.

If you've ever felt that fear, you know the promise you make yourself. Whatever happens on your calls, you will never be sleazy.

Great conversations, but not enough clients?

When your calls feel good but people don't sign up, the problem might be on the call, or it might start before it, in who's booking and what they've seen first. That's hard to tell from the inside. If you want help figuring out what's really going on, book a free 20-minute business assessment call with me, and we'll take a personal look at your business.

BOOK YOUR FREE ASSESSMENT CALL

Why we chose nice

We all know the seller we never want to become. He's the used-car salesman with the slick hair, the one who has to talk to his manager. He's also anyone who sells the way he does, with the fake deadline and the "only three spots left."

Almost everyone has been sold to like that. Maybe you said yes to make it stop, or said no and felt rude about it for days.

That's the pusher: the seller who pushes you toward a yes. Turning away from him was the right instinct, and most of us did it on purpose.

So we became his opposite. We give our best advice away for free, to show we're not in it for the money. We soothe every hard thing someone tells us, and we say the price quickly, to get it over with. And where he would tell you to decide today, we say the kindest thing we can think of: "Take all the time you need."

That's the pleaser, and the pleaser means every word. We care about the person on the call, and we'd rather lose a sale than make anyone feel the way the pusher made us feel. Most of us start here, and some of us stay for years. I've made pretty much every one of these mistakes myself.

Each of those moves comes from something good in you: generosity, gentleness, respect for someone's right to choose. That's what makes them so hard to see, and so hard to give up.

And nice feels safe. Nobody walks away from a pleaser feeling sold to.

When the pusher gets it wrong, everyone can see it. Someone signs and regrets it, or hangs up angry. When the pleaser gets it wrong, the call ends warmly, everyone says thank you, and the cost turns up later, somewhere you'll never see it.

Where it went wrong

The rushed price is the part that's easy to see. It's where most of us look, and where most sales advice looks too. You said the number too fast. If you'd only said it slowly, you think, she might have said yes.

That call was lost long before the price, in the middle, at the exact moment it felt best: the moment you made her feel better, when she went quiet and said, "Nobody's ever put it like that." What you'd given her was the how, and a good one: how to fix the very thing she'd come to you about.

Why would the best moment lose the call? She came to you carrying a distance she wanted to cross. On one side were the late nights of notes and the question at dinner. On the other was something she hadn't yet put into words, but wanted badly enough to book a call with someone she knew only from a video.

For an evening, your answer closed that distance, and she could breathe. Relief feels a lot like progress. That night, she couldn't have told them apart.

So by the time you named a price, she already felt better, and the six months you were offering had nothing to stand next to. Set against her relief, $9,000 was a big number and not much else.

Imagine saying the price as well as anyone has ever said it. Nothing changes. She still says she'd like to think about it, and she means it kindly, because as far as she can tell, she already has what she came for.

No number said slowly would have saved it.

What it cost her

You might be thinking that at least she left with something. She did. She left with an evening.

She hung up lighter than she'd felt in months, with a warm memory of you and exactly the same problem. Raising her prices still felt easy, so that's how she meant to do it: on her own, soon.

Picture her three months on, at the kitchen table after the kids are in bed, finishing the day's notes. Her prices haven't moved, and her daughter still asks at dinner why she's always on her laptop.

Your answer is still good, and she knows what to do. Month after month she doesn't do it, until not doing it starts to feel like something wrong with her.

That's what nice does to the person you care about. It leaves her stuck.

It cost you something too. After enough calls like hers, a private verdict starts to form: *I'm just bad at selling.* It feels honest, because you did everything you knew how to do, and you did it kindly.

The fix most of us reach for is more of the same: more free help, to prove we're worth it. Each round makes the next call a little lovelier, and a little less likely to help anyone.

It isn't a talent problem. You were very good at what you set out to do: you wanted her to feel better, and she did. People open up to you, and you'll need every bit of that. But a lovely conversation was never the job.

Not halfway

The obvious fix is to split the difference: a little less nice, a little more pushy. The way out is somewhere else entirely, and it has a name: leadership.

I'd never ask you to bring less heart to a call. Leadership keeps every bit of it and gives it a direction. Nice is about how the call feels tonight. Heart is about where she'll be in three months.

That direction comes from the two things her call never had: a structure and an ask. On your next call, notice the moment you most want to hand someone your answer. Hold it back, and ask the next question instead (Chapter 5).

There's also one line you can change the next time someone tells you they'd like to think about it. It wouldn't have saved her call, but it would have shown you why it was lost.

> INSTEAD OF "Take all the time you need."
>
> SAY "Totally cool. Just curious, what specifically are you wanting to think about?"

The first is meant kindly, and it sounds like respect. But it sends her off to think later, on her own, and that's where nothing gets decided.

The second keeps her thinking on the call, with you, while you can still help, and asks what's in the way without hurrying her. With her, it would probably have brought out what your reframe had left her believing: that she could do this on her own now.

It's the line I still use at that moment. Chapter 16 adds the step that comes just before it.

If the honest answer is that she needs more time, you'll know what the time is for, and you can put a day on it together before you hang up.

• • •

That call didn't go wrong because you were too pushy. It went wrong because you were too nice.

And she paid for it more than you did.

IN SHORT

- The lovely call that ends in "let me think about it" has failed.
- It went wrong in the middle, when you made her feel better.
- We refused the pusher and became the pleaser.
- Nice leaves the person you care about stuck.
- The way out isn't halfway between pushy and nice.

CHAPTER TWO

Yes, no or limbo

"When it comes to sales, I'm much more interested in calling somebody to a higher standard in themselves than I am in making a sale."

WHEN I STARTED OUT as a coach, I worked with musicians, helping them learn to mix and record their own music. I poured months into my flagship mixing course, and all my best material went into it. I was so excited about it. I knew how much it could change people's lives.

Just before launch, I decided the landing page needed testimonials. A few of those, I thought, and more people would buy. I had what felt like a great idea. I'd go to my best clients and my friends, the people I knew best, the people I believed in my heart this course could change, and I'd give it to them.

I sent a bunch of texts and emails telling them I'd spent months on something really good, and that it was going to make their lives so much better. "I'm going to give it to you for free. All I want is a testimonial in return."

The replies came back. "Wow, that's so generous. Thank you so much." I sent everyone their link and felt very good about myself. These people were going to love it, I'd have my testimonials, and everybody would win.

About two weeks later, I still hadn't heard from anyone, so I wrote to ask how the course was going. A couple of people replied. "Thanks for checking in. I've been busy, but I'm going to get to it next week."

A week later I asked again. Thanks for the reminder, they said. They hadn't gotten around to it yet, but they were excited to go through it.

After about six weeks of this, I stepped back, and I was so frustrated. I had given these people gold.

They hadn't even opened it.

A moment they never had

My intentions were good. I wanted to help those people, and I'd handed them the best of what I knew. What I hadn't done was create a moment where they committed to themselves. Without one, nothing happened, and their lives were exactly the same.

THE POINT

People don't commit to what they don't buy, and no commitment means no change.

A sale is that moment of commitment: someone deciding to back themselves with money. Commitment is what creates change, and the decision is already part of the change. It's why people who have paid turn up to the first session and keep doing the work when it gets uncomfortable.

Most of us know this from the other side. The program we paid for, we showed up to. The free one somebody kindly sent us is still sitting there, unopened.

I thought giving the course away was the generous thing to do. It was the opposite. Free didn't spare those people anything. It kept that moment from them, and without it, the course was one more link they'd get to next week.

What a call is for

My job in sales is to help someone make a decision. Once you see that as your role, a lot falls into place. You stop judging a call by how warm it felt and start judging it by where the person stands when it ends.

Notice that the job is a decision, not a yes. Yes is a good ending to a call, and so is no. Most of us treat a no as a failure. I celebrate a clean one, because someone who says no knows where they stand, and so do you.

The real failure is the ending that isn't an ending at all, and it's where so many lovely calls finish. "Let me think about it," with nothing on the calendar. The friendly promise to get back to you, and the reply that never comes.

When a call ends like that, I think of the person as sitting on the fence. With my course, the fence sounded like this: "Thanks for checking in. I've been busy, but I'm going to get to it next week." Week after week, nobody said no, and nobody started.

Someone on the fence has a foot on each side, one in the life they have and one in the change they came for. I call it limbo land, and limbo land doesn't serve anyone. The problem that brought them onto the call is still there next week, and the life they wanted is no closer.

A decision is when things move, and a yes isn't one until money is down. Even "I'm in, I'll sort out the payment next week" is still limbo, however good it sounds.

Every call, then, has three good endings: paid on the call, a follow-up booked before you hang up, or a clean no (Chapter 18). A booked call is right when someone genuinely needs time: a partner they want to talk it through with, or a past experience that has made them careful. It isn't the decision yet, but it gives the decision a day. Limbo never does.

The kindness is on the other side of the decision. When someone decides, what they usually feel is relief, and a kind of safety: *I've actually made a decision to address this.*

My goal on a call isn't to hard-close every single person. I don't believe in that. My goal is to help someone get to clarity, because clarity serves.

So when someone is in limbo land, I get curious. There's a reason they're there: some tension, doubt, fear or concern, often one they haven't said out loud yet. When they tell me they need to think about it, I first check whether they're sure it's right for them (Chapter 16), and if they're not, I ask what specifically they want to think about, the question from the end of the last chapter. I ask because I want to understand what's holding them, not because I want the sale.

TRY THIS

Take your last lovely call, the one that ended in "let me think about it." Write down what that person was unsure about. If you don't know, that's the question you didn't ask. Then write the last line you said before you hung up, and what it asked of them.

Holding back isn't humility

Nobody can decide about an offer they never heard, and on plenty of good calls, nobody hears one. Someone spends an hour telling you what they're struggling with and what they want instead, and you know you can help. You tell them a little about your framework, and the call ends with "I'd love to support you in whatever way feels right." No program, no timeframe, no price.

We hold back for good reasons. We don't want to impose, or to be one more person turning a good conversation into a pitch. I had good reasons for giving my course away, too. But holding back an offer from someone you can help is the selfish move, and they pay for it by staying exactly where they are.

Making an offer isn't imposing. When I pitch, I'm laying out a path for someone: here's what this is, here's who it's for, here's how it can help you, and here's what to do if you want it. There's no convincing in that. People enjoy being sold to when it feels like a collaboration, not like being strong-armed.

Make the offer, as plainly as this: “I’ve got an offer that’s built for someone in exactly the same position as you, to help you solve this.” For someone who’s ready, that sentence is the deepest act of service you can give in that moment. Then name the price, and trust them to decide.

Leave the offer out, and people fill the space with questions about scope: whether there’s one-to-one time, whether you cover their problem, whether it’s even for them. They don’t need a polished offer, only one clear thing to say yes to.

None of this means selling to anyone who’ll pay. The offer is for the people you know you can help. If you’ve ever worried that selling might make you a scammer, the worry is the proof you’re not one. Either people who care, like you, claim their place in sales, or the only people left selling will be the scammers.

When you have something that genuinely helps people, staying quiet about it isn’t humility. It’s a disservice.

What I hold every call to

If a call’s job is a decision, it needs certain things to get there. These are the seven I look at in every call I review, mine or anyone else’s, and the rest of this book is built around them.

1. **The frame:** the coach leads the call from start to finish: curious, detached, never coaching or chasing.
2. **The gap:** surfaced clearly and felt emotionally.
3. **Discovery:** surfaces the core beliefs and connects the prospect to them emotionally, not just intellectually.
4. **The pitch:** simple, brief and compelling, presenting the offer as the bridge to what they want.
5. **The offer:** one clear offer, with the price stated.

6. **Objections:** explored, not just accepted.
7. **The next step:** a clear one, either a close with payment on the call, a booked follow-up, or a no.

The frame is who you are on the call: the one leading it. The gap is the distance between where someone is and where they want to be.

Discovery is the questions that take up the biggest part of a call. They surface the core beliefs, the handful of things someone has to feel are true before they'll buy: how much where they are hurts, what they want instead, that they need help, that they can trust you, why now, and that waiting costs them. The beliefs are my own version of a framework I learned from Cole Gordon.

There's an order to the seven. The frame holds the whole call, the gap and discovery are the heart of it, the pitch and the offer are the way across, objections are the edge, and the seventh is the decision, the reason for all the others. My course had plenty of value in it, but when I gave it away, it had no price and no next step.

One test sits underneath all seven, and you can put it to any call you've ever had: *did this person leave with a clear decision, or a day booked to make one?*

When a call fails that test, it shows in the seventh, often in one gentle line at the very end, when the decision is still open and you're about to say goodbye.

> INSTEAD OF "Let me know what you think."
>
> SAY "What's your honest reaction?"

The first is polite, and its default answer is no, because no requires no action. The second invites the truth, whatever it is: a yes, a worry, a clean no. Whichever you hear, you can get curious about it.

Every one of the people I sent that course to said yes.

Not one of them decided anything.

IN SHORT

- A call's job is a decision.
- Yes is good, no is good, and limbo helps nobody.
- Commitment is what creates change.
- Holding back an offer isn't humility.
- The seven are the standard every call is held to.

CHAPTER THREE

It isn't about you

"I don't need them to like me. I'm not here for that. I want to be their advocate."

WHEN I LIVED IN LOS ANGELES, I was part of Toastmasters, a public speaking club in Burbank. Every week I'd walk into the American Cancer Society building, into a room of people I barely knew, and we'd spend an hour practicing.

I was president there for a while, and going every week was one of my favorite things to do. It was also very uncomfortable. I'm an introvert, and I'm not a natural public speaker.

A Toastmasters meeting has two parts. In one, people give speeches. In the other, called evaluations, you get up and evaluate a speaker from earlier in the meeting. You have about three minutes: here's what you did well, and here's what you could have done better.

Giving speeches always felt uncomfortable. My hands would get sweaty, and I wouldn't know what to say next. The whole time, I'd be thinking, *what are people going to think of me?*

Evaluations felt completely natural. I'd go up there and be in flow for three minutes, and I'd have so much fun. When they gave out the awards at the end of the meeting, I'd often win best evaluator.

For months I wondered why. It was the same thing: me at the front of the room, speaking. Why did one feel so natural and the other so awkward?

Then one day it hit me. When I gave an evaluation, my mindset was, *I have three minutes to change this person's life.* I wasn't thinking about myself. I was thinking about the person I was there to serve.

When I gave a speech, my focus was on me: how I was coming across, and whether I was giving a great speech. When my focus moved to the other person, all my resistance melted away. Speaking became easy.

The number one reason you feel resistance around sales is that you think it's about you.

If you've never pressured anyone in your life, you might read that and think of someone else, the seller who wants the sale so badly it shows. Most of us who struggle to sell have settled on a comfortable story about ourselves: *I'm not pushy, so I'm not the problem.*

But it's about the rest of us too. Think again about the things we do on calls because we're nice, from the advice we give away to the "take all the time you need" at the end. Each of those feels like it's for them. Look closer, and each one spares us something.

Take the silence after the price. Someone has just heard a big number, and before they've said a word, we're filling the quiet with a payment plan and a reassurance. It's our own discomfort we're sparing, not theirs.

That's why the free help and the soft maybes keep coming. They're kind to us.

It's easy to slip into that self-focused place on a call. I've been caught there before, and I still struggle with it sometimes.

Pushy and nice are the same mistake, made from opposite ends. Both make the call about you, and about what you need from it.

Leadership is what's left when the need goes.

One mistake, from two ends

Sales is a hard dance. I do it best when I'm detached, which is easier said than done. When I really don't care whether someone signs up, I can be bold in a conversation without coming across as pushy, because there's no attachment in it.

The attachment is what creates the pushiness.

Say someone told me early in the call that they've been stuck for two years, and at the end they say they need to think about it. If part of me really wants the sale, I'll show up needy.

If I don't need it, and I still want what's best for them, I can be playful about it: "What do you need to think about? Tell me what's on your mind. You've been waiting the last two years. What's up?"

That conversation can stay light. From someone who needs the sale, the same words would land as pressure.

The pusher grips the yes, and underneath the grip there's usually fear: of an empty calendar, of not making rent this month. People can feel that, however confident the words sound.

The pleaser grips something just as tightly, and it's the one most of us hold: being liked, and never being seen to want the yes. So the rapport runs long, the offer waits for a better moment that never comes, and we let someone leave feeling good instead of leaving with a decision.

Rapport built to be liked is people-pleasing. It does the other person a disservice, because it puts the good feeling between you ahead of what they told you they want.

Hiding the want doesn't make it go away, either. It only means the person never gets a clear invitation, and without one, they can't make a clear decision.

The less you need something in a conversation, the more likely someone is to lean in and want to say yes. Dating works the same way.

Picture a date with someone who badly wants to be in a relationship. They ask all about your hobbies and your life, and whatever you mention,

they love too: "Oh, I like that too. Oh, I love that. That's so cool, I love that about you." You can feel the neediness in it.

Now picture a date with someone who's had five dates that week. They're happy with who they are and where they are in life. They don't need a relationship, so they're free to be honest: "Oh, you like sushi? I don't like sushi." And you're more likely to want to date them, because you don't feel them needing something from you.

So often we walk around with that need in every conversation, and everyone has their guard up against it: *what does this person want from me?* When someone gets on a sales call and doesn't feel it, it's refreshing. It's magnetic.

The person with five dates that week isn't playing it cool. They simply don't need anything from you. Performed detachment is neediness in disguise. It has to be real, and it comes from caring about the person more than the outcome, never from holding back.

Pushing, pleasing or leading

At the first hesitation, the pusher talks faster and the pleaser says, "Of course."

The leader needs neither the yes nor the approval. That's what *detached* means: free of both needs. You met the word in the first of the seven. Without either, a leader can be curious about an answer that might end the sale, clear about what they see, and bold enough to ask for a decision.

Remember the person who'd been stuck for two years. The leader can ask, lightly, what they need to think about, and be fine with whatever comes back: a worry the two of you can look at together, or a clean no.

Go back to that room in Burbank. The pusher and the pleaser are both giving a speech. One is trying to win the room, the other to be liked by it, and underneath, both are wondering what people think of them. The leader is giving an evaluation.

That's why leading isn't a point somewhere between pushing and pleasing. The two share a root, and anywhere between them, you're still giving a speech.

So carry this question onto every call, and ask it most in the moments that feel hardest: *am I pushing, pleasing or leading right now?* Asked honestly, it shows you whose need is running the conversation while there's still time to change what you say next.

If the answer is pushing, slow down and ask a question instead of making another point. If it's pleasing, ask the question you've been saving for a better moment.

High intention, no attachment

The need usually walks in before you do. If you join a call planning to close it, you'll hurry the questions to get to the offer, and mention a payment plan before anyone has asked about money. The person on the other end feels it and pulls back.

You can hear it in what you tell yourself beforehand. *I'm going to close this one* puts you at the center of the call. *I want to understand this person* puts them there.

Go in to help instead. Before every call, my intention is the same: I'm going to help them. I don't know what they need, but I'm going to do my absolute best to figure that out and point them in the right direction, even if that means turning away the business.

That's the high intention. I'll pull out all the stops to create a path for someone to get what they need. But at the end of the day, I'm not attached to whether they take it, and I won't chase them down.

Inside, it sounds like this: *you want to work together? Great. You don't? Great.*

None of this means pretending you don't want the sale. What if it's okay to want to make money and get clients? Part of me wants to make a sale and part of me wants to help people, and both get to be in the conversation. The

line is between wanting the sale and gripping it, and gripping is what reads as need.

You might be thinking this is easy to say when your calendar is full. You're right. When you haven't signed a client in a while, every call carries the weight of *I really want this one*, and it's hard not to be attached to the outcome. It was harder for me when I started, because there weren't many clients coming in the door.

It gets easier as more conversations come in, because with lots of open threads, no single call has to carry the weight. Until then, ground yourself in the five minutes before each call (Chapter 10). And on the call, the moment *I really want this one* gets loud, take it as your cue to ask whether you're pushing, pleasing or leading.

Detached isn't distant, and it isn't timid. Some of us hear the word and go cool, firing one question after another with no warmth in it, and that's a mistake of its own (Chapter 6).

Letting go of the outcome is what I call leaning out, and it never means skipping the hard question. Inside a genuine win-win, where you can help and they want the help, a leader is assertive and asks clearly. Outside one, a leader doesn't pitch at all.

How need leaks

Need is visible. People feel it even when they can't name it, and it tends to push the best of them away, the way the date who loved everything did.

It rarely looks like a hard close. It leaks out in small moves, most of which feel like kindness from the inside, and some like enthusiasm.

HOW NEED LEAKS	WHOSE NEED
Rapport that runs on, so they'll like you	The pleaser's
Listing your credentials before anyone asks	The pleaser's
More excitement about the offer than they have	The pusher's
Agreeing with everything to keep the mood warm	The pleaser's
Solving their problem on the call to show how good you are	The pleaser's
Rushing to fill the silence after the price	The pleaser's
Taking money off the price the moment they wince	The pleaser's
A little off the price if they sign by Friday	The pusher's
"Just checking in" after the call	The pleaser's

The pusher's rows are easier to spot, because they look like selling. Most of the rows are the pleaser's, and none of them looks like pressure. That's what makes them so hard to catch in the moment, and why the question is worth putting somewhere you'll see it.

TRY THIS

For your next three calls, write *Am I pushing, pleasing or leading right now?* at the bottom of the page you take notes on. Once in the middle of each call, look up and answer it honestly. Afterward, write down what you were doing whenever the answer wasn't leading, and find it in the table.

When you find a leak, the fix is almost never something to add. Getting good at leading a call is mostly taking away the ways we sabotage ourselves when we're in scarcity, need and fear. It's an act of subtraction, not addition.

• • •

That room in Burbank is why, when I speak in front of people today, the voice asking *what do you think of me?* is so much quieter than it was. It still speaks up at times, and I'm still learning to let it go. When it does, I turn my attention back to the person I'm there to serve.

Three minutes at the front of that room, and not one of them about me.

IN SHORT

- Pushy and nice are one mistake, made from opposite ends: both make the call about you.
- The pusher needs the yes, the pleaser needs to be liked, and the leader needs neither.
- Carry this question onto every call: *am I pushing, pleasing or leading right now?*
- High intention, no attachment; leaning out never means skipping the hard question.
- Getting good is subtraction.



PART TWO

The gap

If I'm not helping on the call, what am I doing?

CHAPTER FOUR

What people really pay for

"Your new job in sales is to be a gap finder."

NOBODY WAKES UP thinking, *what I really want is to spend thousands of dollars on a coach.* I don't know anybody who says that.

What people say is, *I'm burned out. I miss how I felt in my twenties.* Or, *I'm struggling to get clients, and I don't know what to do.* Or, *if we don't deal with the problems in our marriage, I think we're headed for divorce.*

What they're thinking about is their life: something they're living with, and something they want instead. That's a gap, and it's what they bring onto your call.

If the job is a decision and the call isn't about you, what is the decision about?

Their gap: whether to cross it, and whether to cross it with you. Nobody makes a real decision about a gap they can't see, so your part is to help them see it, and feel it, more clearly than they ever have, then offer a way across. It isn't to close the gap for them for free, however much you'd like to.

We all have gaps of our own.

• • •

For years I went for walks in the same pair of slippers, long after they'd gone scuffed and ratty and the soles had started coming away underneath. My wife used to ask me, "Why don't you just buy a new pair of slippers?"

It wasn't that I couldn't. I could. I just didn't care enough. There wasn't enough pain in that gap.

And it was a gap. On one side was the pair on my feet, on the other a new pair that would feel and look better, and I could see the distance between them perfectly well. It wasn't that big a problem, or at least I didn't see it as one. So I kept walking.

Gaps like that are *nice* to close. They're not gaps you *need* to close.

Every sale rests on a gap, and help crossing it is the only thing anyone pays for, not your sessions or your program. But people act only on a gap they feel, one that hurts or one that pulls. A gap they can merely see, they'll live with for years. I know, because I walked around in mine.

Two mechanics

The clearest picture I know of how a gap works comes from the book *Gap Selling*.

Imagine you're driving somewhere and your car breaks down. You pull onto the shoulder, put your flashers on and call for help. About an hour later a tow truck appears in your rearview mirror. It pulls up, a big burly mechanic climbs out, and you roll down your window.

"What's the problem?"

"My car won't start."

He looks at you, looks at the car and says, "Okay, I can fix that. It's going to be $50."

Now run it again: same car, same shoulder, same hour of waiting. The mechanic asks the same question, and you give the same answer. This time he says he's sorry to hear it and asks how long you've been sitting on the side of the road.

"About an hour."

"That sounds like a long time."

Then he asks something that has nothing to do with the car: where were you going before it broke down?

"My best friend's wedding."

"How long have you two been friends?"

"Twenty years."

"Can I ask an honest question? How do you think your friend might feel when you don't show up to his wedding?"

"Honestly? It's probably going to be a difficult conversation."

He asks how far away the wedding is, and when it starts. Thirty minutes away, in about an hour.

Then he says, "Here's what I'm hearing. We've got to get you to your friend's wedding as quickly as possible. Here's the good news. I can fix your car in about 20 minutes and get you there on time. It's going to be $500."

You'd pay it, happily.

Same car, same problem, same person in the car. What changed was simply the perception of the gap.

The first mechanic didn't ask the right questions. To him, and to you, it was a car that wouldn't start, and that's a small gap.

The second let you feel what was really at stake: *if this car doesn't move, I miss my best friend's wedding.* You wouldn't be paying $500 for 20 minutes under the hood. You'd be paying to get to the wedding.

How big the gap looks controls whether someone wants to talk to you at all, how urgently they want to change and how much they'll invest. How big it looks comes from the questions you ask. Before a call, most people see their problem through a pinhole. A good call widens the view, and only then does a price have somewhere to live.

What a gap is

I call the gap the keys to the kingdom. It's the most important thing I've learned about sales. Everything else on a call is a way of surfacing it, holding it or offering the way across: the questions, the recap, the pitch, the price.



THE SEVEN · 2 OF 7

The gap: surfaced clearly and felt emotionally.

A gap is some distance between point A, where someone is now, and point B, where they want to be. On a call, you have a gap when a clear problem or challenge has been surfaced, or a clear, compelling desire established, or both. Either way, it has to be established clearly, because the whole conversation stands on it.

Clear means specific. Say someone tells you they're not getting enough clients. That's a gap, but a vague one, and it would be easy to nod and move on.

So you ask, "What do you mean?" Then how many clients they're getting now, and how many they'd need. You might hear two a month, and eight to replace their income and go full-time. Now you both know where point A is, where point B is, and how far apart they sit.

When someone hands you the vague version, keep asking until you have the specific one, in their words. Not every gap comes in clients or dollars, but every gap can be made specific: hours, how often, how long it's been going on, energy on a scale of 1 to 10. Write it down the way they said it, because those are the words you'll hand back to them later in the call.

The first thing I establish in any conversation, in a message or on the phone, is whether there's a gap, and whether it's one I can close. Then I listen for how much they want to close it. A gap that's only nice to close, like my slippers, won't carry a sale, so I'm looking for someone with a high desire to close theirs.

Only once I've found a real one do I think about next steps. If there isn't one, there's no sale, and no reason to invite them anywhere.

When the gap is a pull

Most of us hear the word *gap* and think of pain. Pain is often where it starts, but it's only one side of it. Someone also has to believe there's something on the other side, a future better than where they are today.

Say someone's making $10,000 a month. Feeling that where they are is hard isn't enough. They also have to believe that $50,000 a month is far more desirable, and that life would be better there. So much of selling is connecting someone to that vision.

When someone tells me they want to make $50,000 a month, that's only the surface goal, so I ask, "How would that change things for you?"

And they tell me. They'd take more time off, a couple of vacations a year. They'd pay off their partner's student loans. They'd take their mom on a vacation, provide for their kids in a deeper way, send them to summer camp.

Now they're looking past the number to how good life would look and feel on the other side. Whenever someone hands you a number, ask what it would change.

I think of pain and desire as the two wings of the gap: pain at point A, where someone is today, and desire at point B, where they want to be. When someone feels connected to both, they feel the gap, and they naturally want to close it. Pain with nothing pulling on the other side has its own cost: people come away feeling stuck (Chapter 6).

Some people, often the ones already doing well, will tell you things are "pretty good, actually," and they mean it. Talk to them as if their life is falling apart and it goes straight over their heads: *that's not me.*

So don't go digging for a wound. Turn to the other wing, and still ask what's at stake if nothing changes. If there's a real pull, that's your gap.

Sometimes you ask about both wings and find little on either. You can't take somebody who's a 2 out of 10 in wanting to change and bring them to a 10 if it isn't already in them.

So name it plainly, with a line I learned from Keith Rosen: "Can I be honest with you? I'm sensing this might not be a high priority right now. Is there any truth to that?" It puts what you've noticed on the table between

you, and the last line leaves room for you to be wrong (Chapter 13). Sometimes that breaks through a wall and the real conversation starts.

Sometimes the want to change isn't there. Then let them go kindly, without a pitch, because a pitch on top of that is only pressure. If calls like that keep turning up, look at who books with you, or at the offer. A gap too small for the offer can't be questioned into a big one.

Felt, not understood

I understood my slipper gap completely. I could have described it to you in detail. I didn't feel it.

When someone buys from you, they feel their gap. They don't just understand it intellectually. They feel it in their body: the tension of resting in the middle, between the problem they have and the life they can see but aren't living yet.

A gap can be specific and still not be felt. Two clients a month when you need eight is a clear gap, and someone can tell you all about it without feeling a thing. An understood gap sounds like a problem, well described. A felt gap sounds like someone's life.

I think of it like a rubber band. One end is where someone is today, and the other is where they want to be. Every question that helps them see and feel the distance stretches it a little further, and there's tension in that stretch. The more real the gap becomes, the tighter it gets.

That tension is where the desire for change comes from, and it's what leaves someone open to hearing about a way across. Because the tension is theirs, they build their own leverage, and nobody has to push them.

THE POINT

No tension, no gap, no sale.

That's why, underneath every question I ask out loud on a call, there's one I'm asking myself: *does this person actually feel the gap?*

Go back to my slippers, and imagine a slipper salesperson got me on the phone. They ask about my biggest challenge with slippers, and I tell them I've got this old pair. Then they follow up.

"How is it impacting your life to have this ratty pair of slippers you're walking around in?"

I'd have to think about that. Then, to be honest, I might say I feel a little embarrassed by them.

When people come over and I'm wearing them, I'm afraid they'll judge me. What are they going to think of me? Maybe it's even affecting things at home, because my wife looks at me and says I'm always wearing those old slippers.

Nothing about the slippers would have changed. One good question would have taken a gap I understood and made it a gap I felt.

That question wouldn't have invented anything. Anything it turned up, a little embarrassment or what my wife thought of them, would already have been there. All it would have done is help me see what I hadn't seen clearly, and connect to my own desire to close the gap. If it had found nothing, the slippers would have stayed nice to close, and the honest thing would have been to believe me.

With the people on your calls, it's the same question without the slippers: "How's that been impacting you?" It asks about impact, so it works even with people who will never name a feeling. If the answer stays small, follow the problem out into the rest of their life, the way mine went from the slippers to my guests and my wife. Sometimes one question gets someone there, and sometimes it takes two or three.

On a call, the gap is surfaced by your questions, felt in the silences you leave after them, and established when you hand it back in their own words and they answer, emphatically, "Yes, you get me." Until you hear that, there's nothing for an offer to stand on, however clearly you see the gap yourself. A flat yes, or a correction, means there's more to ask, so go back and ask it.

When someone tells you at the end of a call that they need to think about it, what they usually mean is, *I don't feel the gap* (Chapter 19).

TRY THIS

Think of the last three people you spoke to on a sales call. For each one, write their point A and point B in their own words. Then mark which gaps they felt and which they only understood, and which pulled as well as hurt. Where a gap stayed understood, write down the question you could have asked to help them feel it.

Illuminate, never invent

What we're doing in sales is not creating a gap. We're illuminating it. That's the line between selling and manipulation: manipulation is trying to create something that doesn't exist.

The second mechanic is what illuminating looks like. He asked where you were going, named his price plainly and let you decide what getting to the wedding was worth. Done with care, illuminating never uses someone's pain to push them into buying, and never makes anyone feel bad for the sake of it. It helps someone find their own reason to change.

That difference also answers the fear so many of us bring to selling, the one I carried myself when I first started pitching: that selling will make us sleazy.

Illuminating is part of the help, because before anyone can close a gap, they have to become aware of it. That's the first step of any change. A call that leaves someone aware of their gap, and feeling it, has given them that step, whether they say yes or no. When I see selling that way, there's nothing sleazy left in it.

And it has to be their gap.

When I first started coaching business owners, I thought I was going to be an alignment coach. Then I got on market-research calls and asked the people I wanted to serve about their number one biggest challenge. Nobody said alignment. Almost everyone said they needed help getting clients.

So I built my program around getting clients instead, because that's what people wanted. I couldn't create a desire that wasn't there. All I could do was meet the one they already had.

Losing sight of that has been behind many of my business failures. I do a lot of inner work with the people I help, and when all my messaging was about that work, it didn't produce clients.

It works the same way on a call. You might see that, underneath everything, someone has never learned to love themselves. They'll tell you their biggest challenge is that they can't attract the relationship they want. Build on the gap they name: sell what they want, a tangible outcome, and deliver what they need.

None of that is a bait and switch. The work is aimed at what they came for, and inside it you can help with what's underneath. You're meeting someone where they are, because if you speak to them from three steps ahead, you'll lose them.

Does your message name the gap your clients feel?

The same gap that decides your sales calls decides your marketing. When my messaging was all about the inner work, it didn't bring in clients. If you're talking about your program instead of what people want, the right clients won't book in the first place.

If you want help getting your message right, book a free 20-minute business assessment call with me. We'll take a personal look at how you talk about your work and what needs to shift so the right people reach out.

BOOK YOUR FREE ASSESSMENT CALL

Inventing a gap is the pusher's mistake. It's the seller who hears that things are pretty good and keeps digging until something hurts, supplying pain the

person never mentioned (“But don’t you feel stuck?”) and urgency they never felt.

The pleaser’s mistake runs the other way, and it’s the one most of us make, me included: someone finally says the hard thing out loud, and out of real kindness we rush to make it smaller (Chapter 6).

The leader holds the gap open, honestly, until the person decides. When the hard thing is said, the leader lets it sit for a moment and asks about it, and when the time comes, offers a way across and asks for a decision.

Honestly means you don’t make the gap bigger than it is, and you don’t shrink it to spare anyone’s feelings, your own included.

• • •

I did buy new slippers in the end. It took me years.

Somebody on your next call is wearing their slippers.

IN SHORT

- People pay to cross a gap, not for your program.
- A gap can hurt or pull: pain at point A, desire at point B.
- It has to be felt, not just understood.
- Illuminate, never invent: it has to be their gap.

CHAPTER FIVE

Why helping hurts

"Twenty minutes of coaching is not going to take somebody from where they are today all the way to the result they want."

SOMEONE ON YOUR CALL is halfway through telling you what's been going wrong, and you can already see the answer.

Some people will tell you that's exactly the moment to give it to them. Coach them for free. Spend two hours with someone, create a real transformation, and at the end they'll say, "Wow, I want more."

I've coached people who were taught in other programs to sign clients with two-hour coaching calls, and I've found the exact opposite. Coach someone on a sales call and it feels to them as if you've solved their problem, and that feeling releases the very tension they need to change, and to buy.

They get to the end of the call and think, *cool, now I've got everything I need.* There's no reason left to hire you.

There's a quieter cost too. Give your coaching away and you train people not to value it. Without meaning to, you've told them it's worth $0. After all that free coaching, it's hard to turn to the same person and say, "You want to sign up for my coaching program for $5,000?"

Helping on a sales call closes the gap for free. It costs you the sale and them the change. They feel better and go home with the same problem.

Coaching solves, selling magnifies

Most of us came to selling from the coaching side, so a sales call can look like a coaching session on a shorter clock: the same care, the same good questions, a smaller dose. But they're two different conversations, and their jobs work against each other.

Selling is everything you do before someone becomes a client. Coaching is everything you do after. Coaching is about solving people's problems. Selling is about magnifying them, until there's enough tension that someone wants to make a change in their life and work with you.

Magnifying sounds harsher than it is. It means helping someone see what's already there at its real size, the way the second mechanic helped you see the wedding behind a car that wouldn't start.

That's why a sales call is not a coaching call, and why the frame, the first of the seven, ends on *never coaching or chasing*. You can't do both jobs at once. While you're coaching, you're not doing the work the call is for: connecting someone to what their problem is costing them and what they want instead.

Most of us slip from one into the other without noticing. Listen for it in your own voice: *here's what I'd do*, or a framework you've explained a hundred times. And listen for it in theirs at the end of the call: it was so helpful, they have so much clarity now. Then they don't buy.

Coaching questions are harder to catch. "Where do you think that comes from?" is a great question for a coaching call, and not a great one for a sales call. It sends you both hunting for a cause, and once you've found one, the natural next move is to fix it.

A sales question keeps the gap in view: "What would the dream look like for you?" It asks someone to look toward where they want to be, and it leaves the distance open.

The balloon

The urge to help is strongest at the exact moment a call starts to work. Say you ask, "Tell me, what's the biggest challenge you have in your business right now?"

"I'll be honest with you. Things have been slow lately. I've been showing up, I've been doing the work, but I feel like I'm at the ceiling, and it's been like this for the last couple of years. It's been hard on me and my family."

If you care about people, everything in you wants to do something with that. So we help. Out comes a tip, or the reframe that has worked for our clients for years. At its plainest, someone says they're 20 pounds overweight, and the answer comes straight back: "Have you tried keto?"

Surfacing someone's gap is like blowing up a balloon. Just bringing it to the surface creates tension. The moment you start coaching, you let the air out.

Something lifts, and they think, *great, why should I hire you? I feel better now.*

THE POINT

The whole point of a sales call is to blow up the balloon. Every bit of coaching or free advice lets the air out.

So in discovery, your job is to uncover, not to solve. When the hard thing comes out, leave the answer where it is and ask the next question: "How long has that been going on for?" It keeps them with what they've just said, and the balloon keeps filling. (A short assessment call, which Appendix A covers, can leave someone with one clear insight, as long as the problem isn't fully resolved.)

Advice on a sales call feels like service. It's a disservice: a few seconds of advice won't solve a problem like theirs, and if it could, they'd probably have solved it already. All it does is spend the tension they needed for the change.

Explaining does the same on a smaller scale, and so does reflecting back after every answer (Chapter 13).

Underneath the advice, more often than we'd like to admit, is the wish to show someone how good we are at what we do. Paradoxically, it pushes people away. Let your questions show them how good you are.

The what, not the how

The same thing happens wherever we try to sell by giving. Most of us have been told to give value, but information alone doesn't make anyone buy. Give and give, and you close the gap. Pretty much every entrepreneur makes this mistake with live events, and I've made it many times.

On a webinar, if I walk people through step one and how to do it, then step two and how to do it, by the end they say, "Great, thanks. I have everything I need." So I teach the what, not the how: the roadmap, and at each step a mistake I often see people make, or a common myth. That leaves them with one obvious question (*how?*), and it leads straight to the offer.

None of this means giving less. A masterclass, a piece of content or a free call needs both: the value and the gap. Give generously, and always leave people seeing what they're still missing and the next step across.

On a call, the value is what your questions help someone see.

The pamphlet

A resource is not a recommendation. A coach I was working with once booked an hour for a call with a man who had reached out because he wanted help. The coach made no offer. The plan was to send him an e-guide and touch base in a week.

He didn't need an e-guide: when someone reaches out to say they need help and want a conversation, they're asking you to help them. It's as if I'd walked in bleeding and someone threw me a pamphlet. *I want you to fix it. That's why I'm here.*

The e-guide was a pamphlet. “Let me send you some resources” is one too, and so is the promise to touch base next week. They feel generous, but they hand the problem back to someone who came to you because they couldn’t solve it on their own.

What he needed was a leader, someone to step in and say: here’s what you need, I know I can help you, and here’s what this would look like. So I suggested the coach step into that role, with a message like this.

> SAY IT LIKE THIS
>
> “Hey, I’ve been thinking about our conversation. I know I can help you. Based on what you shared with me, I think working together would be a great next step for you, and would give you the missing piece you need to [what they told you they want].”

If a call has ended without an offer, don’t wait a week to put it right. Send something like this, with their own words in the brackets, and ask for a time to talk it through. Its job is to get you both back on a call to decide, because a call always converts better than an offer by text.

Something specific and genuinely useful can follow a conversation, but it can’t take the place of an offer or a decision. More information mostly gives someone new things to object to. Send them a page of it, and they’ll find the one sentence that makes them uneasy.

TRY THIS

Listen back to a recent sales call and mark every place you taught, advised or offered to send something. Next to each mark, write what the person said just before it. Often it’s the moment something painful came out. Then write the question you could have asked instead.

When they ask for advice

Sometimes someone asks you straight out what they should do. The pleaser answers. It feels generous, and the instinct behind it is a good one: they've asked for help, and helping is what you're for.

At that moment, remember something I was told once: someone's best thinking got them to this call. It isn't the most empowering frame, but it's a useful one. They're on the call with you because their best thinking isn't working.

So don't feed it, and don't solve the problem for them. Challenge it lovingly, with questions. "What do you feel has been stopping you from solving this on your own?" asks someone to look at the thinking that brought them here.

The leader holds the gap open, without answering and without refusing. Name the purpose of the call, warmly, and move on to your next question.

> SAY IT LIKE THIS
>
> "That's not the purpose of this call. It's definitely what we do inside the coaching work."

The line says the answer exists and where it lives, and the question that follows keeps the conversation on their gap.

Said warmly, it tells someone they've come to the right place.

You don't keep what you see to yourself, though. Once discovery is over and they've confirmed your recap, you'll name it (Chapter 14): what's in the way and why, never that they're broken. Naming what's in the way is the diagnosis. What you hold back is the how.

Take the person who's been stuck at the same ceiling for a couple of years. The diagnosis sounds like this: "You don't have a steady way of bringing in new clients, so every month starts from zero." The how you hold back sounds like this: "Here's the three-step referral system to build it." The first shows them what's in the way, and the second is the work itself, the part they hire you for.

Holding the answer back can feel stingy, as if you're withholding the very thing they came for. But the people on your calls don't need more coaching from you. They need a conversation that connects them to their own desire to make a change, and then a way across. Everything you know will still be there once they've decided, and it will be worth far more to someone who has committed to using it.

• • •

Half an hour into that lovely call in Chapter 1, you gave her your best reframe. She said, "Nobody's ever put it like that," and cried with relief.

That was the moment the air went out.

IN SHORT

- A sales call is not a coaching call.
- Coaching on the call lets the air out of the balloon.
- Give the what, not the how.
- A resource is not a recommendation.
- Ask in discovery, name what's in the way after the recap, and never give away the how.

CHAPTER SIX

Compassion that doesn't soften

"I'm willing to make you feel uncomfortable because I care."

WHEN I WAS A KID, I used to watch a show on A&E called *Intervention*. I'm one of the three weird people in the world who loved that show. Each episode followed someone struggling with addiction, to drugs or alcohol, and the toll it was taking on the people around them.

At some point in every episode, the family held an intervention. Everyone who loved that person most sat down with them in one room, and one by one they read out letters they'd written. The letters were blunt and very specific: here are all the ways your addiction has affected me, here's how you haven't been there for me. They told stories.

Then each letter said what would happen if things didn't change: *I'm going to have to cut you out of my life. You won't be part of my kids' lives anymore. This is the last straw.*

It was uncomfortable to watch. I can only imagine how painful it would be to sit in the hot seat and hear the people who love me most describe what my addiction has done to them.

And nobody softened it. Nobody said, oh, it's not that bad, maybe it'll get better. That would have been shooting the person in the foot.

More often than not, by the end, the person decided to go to rehab. Seeing the impact clearly, and the cost of not changing, gave them the

leverage to say: okay, I'm willing to change, and I'm willing to go through the discomfort to do it. What a gift.

Look at what those letters did. They named the impact in detail. They named what would happen if nothing changed. And every word came from someone who loved them.

Most of us aren't doing this on our sales calls.

A sales call is a kind of intervention. It's an extreme comparison, I know. But someone is on a call with you because a pattern has kept them stuck, and that pattern has momentum behind it.

I think of it as a compassionate intervention. I care about the person so much that I'm willing to get uncomfortable and ask the hard questions. I know that in facing their own answers, they'll find the leverage to change.

You don't write the letters, though, and you never deliver an ultimatum. You ask a question instead: "What happens if things don't change?" That question is the last line of every letter in that room, turned around so they can say it themselves.

So if you can't help them on the call, and you can't soothe them either, what's left of kindness? The same thing that was left in that room.

Kindness on a sales call isn't making someone feel better. It's caring enough to let them feel what's true, and staying with them while they do. None of that is cold. Everyone in that room was there out of love.

If you care about the people on your calls, keep every bit of that care. Just stop spending it on comfort.

What softening sounds like

A while back, I worked with a coach who couldn't understand why her calls weren't clicking. She did great work with her clients, and she knew it. What she couldn't do was move someone through a sales conversation. We listened to her recorded calls together, the way I do with some of my one-to-one clients.

She was empathetic and she cared, like most of the people I work with. That's who I am too. On her calls, that care came out as a lot of validating.

Someone would start telling her what they were struggling with, and she'd hop straight in: "Oh, well, there are so many other people out there experiencing that too. You're not alone with that. And it's not as bad as you think it is. You're doing such a good job in this area and that one."

It happened again and again and again. We'd hear someone share a problem and start to step into the feeling of it, the place where it begins to hurt, and then we'd hear her come in and rescue them with validation.

This comes from a really good place.

Most of us, me included, have the same reflex: the moment someone is hurting, part of us wants to swoop in and soften it. But it's misguided care.

Usually it's a single line, ready on your tongue the moment someone tells you what's wrong.

> INSTEAD OF "Oh, that's totally normal."
>
> SAY "Yeah, that's a real challenge."

Totally normal tells them their struggle is ordinary, which makes it smaller. *A real challenge* agrees that it's hard, and trusts them to sit with it.

Every line like hers lifts a little of the weight off the person, and the weight is what would have moved them. They hang up thinking, *well, it's not that bad. Maybe I'll stay where I am.*

THE POINT

The most generous thing you can do, if you really care about people, is to not soften.

The pain was there long before they booked the call. You aren't adding any. You're only declining to take it away, and sitting with them in it long enough to say, yes, this is real.

That's what lets someone face it safely, and reach the end of the conversation saying, "You know what? This is a big deal. And I'm ready."

Feeling the weight with them

If softening costs so much, why is it so hard to stop? Because most of the time, the discomfort we're rescuing is our own. The quiet feels heavy, and we want out, with comfort or with a question that changes the subject.

I feel it too. On a call, my heart is in the conversation, and I'm feeling with the person. At the same time, part of my awareness is holding the frame: where I want to go next, which question comes after this one, and why. Both are there at once. There's a craft to it.

When I ask someone what happens if things don't change, I feel the weight of their answer with them. It's uncomfortable. It's hard to do, because I don't want them in pain.

And I ask it anyway, because I know there's a part of them that wants to change, and a part that has been playing out the pattern that brought them to this call. If I don't help people face the reality of where they are, a lot of them won't change. I've seen it on plenty of calls.

I see it as my responsibility. I'm an advocate for their future, and that means helping them feel the full weight of where they are now. I care more about someone getting what they want than about making them feel good, because almost all change takes some discomfort.

That doesn't mean going cold. Some people hear "don't soften" and stop acknowledging anything at all. They fire the next question on their list straight at a painful answer, and the call starts to feel clinical. The person on the other end stays on the surface, because nobody opens up to someone who isn't with them.

Be with them, then, briefly and for real. One plain acknowledgment is enough. Then let it sit, or ask a question that stays with what they just said, like how long it's been going on, or how it's been affecting them.

You can hear the difference between an acknowledgment and softening. Softening reassures, minimizes or explains. An acknowledgment says it's hard, and stops. It comes once, not after every answer, or it slides back into softening.

TRY THIS

On your next call, each time you feel the pull to reassure, make a small mark on your notes instead. Afterward, count the marks, notice which answers pulled hardest, and decide what you'll do there next time: one plain acknowledgment, then quiet.

When they cry

People cry on my calls quite often, and not because I'm hard on them. When someone comes face to face with their situation, with what they really want and what's at stake, they feel it. If you're doing a good job selling, people are going to get emotional.

Sometimes the tears come after that same question: "What happens if things don't change?" People talk about having to go back to a corporate job that feels like a prison. They talk about lying on their deathbed with regret.

In those moments, my job is to sit with them without softening anything. I'm holding compassion for them, and compassion isn't jumping in to make them feel better. I'll say something like, "I see you. I see how hard this is. I see how much you're holding. How much you want this to work."

Notice what those words do. They acknowledge everything the person is feeling, and they take none of it away.

Then I go quiet. Silence is one of the best things you can give someone on a sales call: room to sit with what they've just felt. It has a craft of its own (Chapter 13). Here, all it asks of you is not to fill it, and to go on only when they're ready.

Not all tears mean the same thing. Tears that come as someone feels the weight of their own gap mean it's working, so stay quiet. Tears of relief, after you've solved the problem for them, like the ones on that lovely call at the start of this book, mean the air has gone out.

Those are the calls that feel most connected. People cry, open up, tell you how much the conversation meant to them, and don't buy.

Pain needs possibility

There's a limit to all this. With too much pain and nothing else, people feel stuck. The problem starts to look daunting, their life feels like a mess, and they lose any sense of possibility.

Say a call is all pain. Every question digs a little further into what's wrong, and not one asks where they want to be. At the end, they tell you they need to think about it. There was nothing pulling them along.

So as soon as someone has felt what's wrong, ask about the other side: "Where do you ultimately want to be?" Then let them describe it until they can see it.

Never soften the pain, and never leave someone alone in it.

Their life, their decision

There's a quieter way to soften, one that never leaves your head: deciding things for people. It happens when someone mentions that money has been tight and, without a word, you shrink the offer to what you guess they can afford (Chapter 15).

It's the same reflex as "it's not that bad," aimed at a price instead of a feeling. But the person on your call is a sovereign adult, capable of making good decisions. You don't have to protect them from the truth about where they are, or from their own choices.

Let them make an empowered decision, whichever way it goes. That same respect is what lets you leave the hard thing with them, where it belongs.

Even in that room, nobody could decide for the person in the hot seat. All the letters could do was make sure they saw clearly when they did.

You don't own their outcome, and you don't own their yes either. If you ever catch yourself wanting to drag someone up the mountain, or carry them around the hard part, ask yourself:

Whose discomfort am I rescuing?

• • •

Nice is comfort.

Kind is advocacy for the life they told you they want.

IN SHORT

- Softening is misguided care.
- Let them feel what's true, and stay with them while they do.
- Tears at the weight of the gap mean it's working; tears of relief mean you've solved it for free.
- Pain needs possibility.
- Their life, their decision.



PART THREE

The leader

Who do I have to be?

CHAPTER SEVEN

If they knew what they needed

"What most people really want is a leader."

PICTURE YOURSELF on the crinkly paper in a doctor's office, waiting for the door to open.

You know something isn't right, but you don't know what you need. That's why you came. You're hoping whoever walks through that door does.

The doctor comes in and says, "Well, we've got this whole cabinet full of pills. Which one looks good to you?"

You'd say, "That's not what I'm paying you for. I don't know. I can't even pronounce half of these things. I just want to feel better. You tell me what to do."

If they knew what they needed, they wouldn't be on the sales call with you.

The person on your call came to you because you're the expert. Your job is to prescribe: to tell them what you think they need and how you'll get them there.

But not before you know what's wrong. The opposite failure is just as real. A doctor who walks in with a pill in his back pocket, and asks questions only to get it into your mouth, is committing malpractice. On a sales call, that's discovery that was only ever a run-up to the pitch.

A good doctor asks questions too, but to find out what's wrong: your symptoms, how long it's been going on, what you've tried. Then she makes a diagnosis and tells you what to do.

That's the job on a sales call: diagnose, then prescribe. Seeing it that way changed selling for me, and it started to melt away the sleazy feeling. Once the purpose of my calls moved from closing to diagnosis, I wasn't trying to get a pill into anyone's mouth anymore. I was trying to figure out what they needed.

Most of us who care about the people on our calls are good at the first half. It's the second we hesitate over.

Prescribe

On a sales call, the cabinet rarely looks like one. Sometimes it's a menu of packages. More often it sounds kinder still. We ask, "What do you think you need?"

It comes from a good place. We don't want to presume, and letting someone choose feels respectful. But it hands the lead to the one person on the call who doesn't know the way.

They know where they want to go, and that part is theirs, in their own words. What they don't know is what it will take to get there. That's the part you prescribe.

So say it plainly: "Based on what you've shared with me, here's what I think you need to solve this, and here's how we're going to do it." The *how* in that line is your offer and the path it takes, not the answer to their problem. That comes in the work, once they've said yes.

Make it one prescription, because a menu is only the cabinet again. And make it after the diagnosis, or it's the pill in the pocket. The full moment, on a real call, comes later (Chapter 14).

If you don't lead, they will, and they'll build the whole thing around what they think they need. There's a cost later, too: how you sell sets how

someone expects to be coached. If they steer the sales call, they'll expect to steer the work.

The same goes for the practical steps around the decision: when you'll speak again, when the first session is, how you'll get started. I don't ask permission for those. I make a suggestion or an invitation, because I'm the one leading and a question opens the door to a no.

Some questions I ask on purpose, because their yes is the point: "Would you like me to show you how it works?" and, at the end, the decision itself. Those are theirs to answer, so I ask and I wait. Everything else, I lead.



THE SEVEN · 1 OF 7

The frame: the coach leads the call from start to finish: curious, detached, never coaching or chasing.

It's a stance before it's a technique, and the words only hold once you're standing in it.

TRY THIS

Go back through your last sales call, on the recording or in your notes, and find every place you handed back the lead: a "What do you think you need?" or a "Would you like to …?" about a practical step you could simply have suggested. Write each one down. Then rewrite it as a suggestion, in words you'd be willing to say on your next call.

Clear leadership creates safety

It's easy to believe people feel safe when you're soft with them: when you give them room, let them choose and never press. That's only half of it.

When the doctor walks in and says, "Here's what you need to do," you can breathe. You're not flailing around anymore. Someone actually knows what they're doing, and that gives you clarity and a path. Being led, by someone who listened first, is a relief.

There are two kinds of safety on a call. One comes from warmth: making someone feel seen, heard and understood, so that instead of feeling shoved toward a yes, they feel you're on their team. That part doesn't come from a script.

The other comes from structure: leading the conversation, asking the right questions and saying plainly what you think they need. It's the safety of the doctor's office.

You need both. All warmth, and you get the lovely call from the start of this book: two hours, tears of relief, and no client. All structure, and people feel you're cold.

I've been on both sides of this, all structure and all warmth, and both have problems. Most of the coaches I work with have plenty of warmth. A lot of them need a little more structure.

You can see structure at work in small things. A clear offer lets someone's mind relax a little. So does a first session booked before you hang up, because it gives them certainty.

It matters most when someone wobbles. Say you've told them what you see, and they go quiet, then ask, "What do you think I should do?"

The kind-sounding thing is to hand it straight back and tell them to do whatever feels right. It loosens the structure at the very moment they reach for it.

Stay steady and answer them: "Here's what I recommend, and here's what it'll take." That doesn't take the decision away from them. It gives them something solid to decide about.

Assess, don't impress

A good doctor doesn't audition for her patients. Most of us do, me included. When I went back through my own content, I kept finding the part where I was trying to prove how good I am.

On a sales call, the audition looks like this: we open grateful, mention our credentials before anyone asks, and spend the hour trying to show we're worth the money.

It's understandable: you want them to see you're good at this. But someone who booked a call with you already believes you might be, or they wouldn't be there. My colleague Kim Argetsinger puts it this way: "They're showing up to the call hoping you're the real deal."

They're hoping you're the last person they'll need to talk to. Who do you know who gets really excited about shopping for six different options?

Trying to prove you're the real deal works against you. What someone hears underneath it is that you aren't sure. People match you at the level of your own self-belief.

A phrase I learned from Taki Moore turns this around: assess, don't impress. His picture of it is Simon Cowell on *American Idol*, sitting in the judge's chair, listening and evaluating. He already knows how good he is. His job is to decide whether this person is good enough to be on the show.

Simon Cowell is not trying to impress anyone.

Assessing isn't cold. Be warm and friendly. But underneath the warmth, you're the doctor, not the contestant.

There are two decisions on every call. They decide whether to buy. I decide whether to make an offer, and I decide before I say a word about it.

I generally don't put that decision in someone else's hands. When we're unsure about someone, we sometimes push it off onto them: "Why don't you think about it? Why don't you decide?" That's handing back the lead too.

My sales calls are evaluative. When I get on the phone with someone, I'm asking myself whether I want to work with them and whether I can help them. I'm also asking whether they're a good fit for me, whether I'll enjoy

spending time with them, and whether they'll be an asset to the community my clients are part of.

Two of those matter most, and they're the two you're on every call to answer: *can I help this person, and do I want to?*

I've been on plenty of calls where, somewhere in the conversation, I realized this person probably wasn't going to be a great fit. So I drew the line and said it: "I don't think this is going to be a good fit." That community is as good as it is because of all the times I've said it.

You can turn clients away, and you should. Even if you don't have many clients yet, you get to be picky.

Want an honest assessment of your business?

Assessing is exactly what I do on a business assessment call. I'm not there to impress you. I take a personal look at your business and tell you plainly what I think is getting in the way of more clients.

If you'd like that kind of clarity, book a free 20-minute business assessment call with me. You'll leave knowing what needs to shift, whether or not we work together.

BOOK YOUR FREE ASSESSMENT CALL

Under my care

The way I see it, selling is the act of putting someone under my care: putting what's best for them above my own needs. People come to a sales call wanting a shepherd, and that's my role. The map I hold on every call is simple: here's where you are, here's where you want to go, here's what you need to get there, and here's how I can help you do it.

Measured against that map, "What do you think you need?" isn't as humble as it feels. Look at what it protects. If they choose, I can't get it wrong, and nobody can call me pushy.

Handing someone the cabinet is the pleaser's move. The pill in the pocket is the pusher's, and what it protects is the sale. Neither doctor has the patient under his care.

The leader does.

Most days, the difference between leading and stepping back comes down to a few small words.

> INSTEAD OF "Would you like to book your first session?"
>
> SAY "How about we do this? Let's get your first session on the calendar for Tuesday at ten."

The first is well meant: it gives them the choice. But it comes off a little needy, and it puts you in a submissive place, asking permission to keep helping. The second leads, with a day and a time already in it. They can still move it, but they no longer have to work out the next step alone.

• • •

The door opens again, and the person on the crinkly paper looks up.

They've told you everything. Now they're waiting for you to tell them what to do.

IN SHORT

- **The frame:** the coach leads the call from start to finish: curious, detached, never coaching or chasing.
- They came because they don't know what they need: diagnose, then prescribe.
- Clear leadership makes people feel safe too.
- Assess, don't impress: can I help this person, and do I want to?
- Suggest the practical next steps; ask only for what's theirs to decide.

CHAPTER EIGHT

Challenging, not pushing

"Sometimes people need to be challenged.
And sometimes people need to feel safe."

I'VE GOTTEN OFF SALES calls and thought, *Oh my God. Who was I on that call?*

There have been a lot of them. Calls where I got caught in neediness. Calls where I said exactly the wrong thing. Calls where I was way too pushy, stopped listening to my own intuition, bulldozed straight through and probably upset the person on the other end.

Afterward I'd step back and think, *Yikes. That didn't feel right.* I'd tell myself I wouldn't do that next time. Then I'd get it wrong again, because I was worried about paying the rent that month.

On some of those calls, I didn't like the person I was.

Learning to sell with integrity, in a way that feels good for both people, takes a lot of practice. You step over the edge a little to find out where the edge is. I've gotten better at these conversations over time, and I still make mistakes.

Integrity isn't a state you reach once. It's working with our own humanity, call by call. The lines stay where they are. I get better at staying inside them.

If you're worried that leading a call will turn you into the person I was on those calls, I understand. Now and then, it might. When it does, don't beat yourself up. Ask yourself what you learned.

The difference between pushing and challenging isn't how gently you go. It's where you're trying to take someone, and whether you stop at their boundary.

Pushy or challenging

Here's where I draw the line. Challenging someone's beliefs and patterns, and getting curious about their concerns or objections, is useful when it's in service to them and helps them come to clarity on a decision. I don't want to lean out so far that the hard conversation never happens.

THE POINT

Pushing is overriding boundaries. Pushy is pushing someone to a yes. Challenging, which is leadership, is helping them create commitment and make a decision, whether that's a yes or a no.

Pushing has only one acceptable answer, so whatever stands in its way gets overridden. A concern gets argued for the fourth time, a plain "I can't afford this" is brushed aside, and someone with no savings is talked into putting it on a card. It ends in a small, flat yes.

A yes like that isn't a decision. The doubt hasn't gone anywhere. It's only gone quiet, and it comes back after you hang up. When the honest answer is no, or not now, that's the one you honor.

Challenging can afford to be direct because both answers count. You can question a belief or a pattern openly when all you want is for someone to see clearly enough to choose.

And sometimes it has to be direct. The thinking that kept someone stuck follows them onto the call, and when it's time to decide, it's often the first thing to speak up. If you never question it, you leave them alone with it.

Some people only need a little nudge. Stop short of even that and you're the rollover, the pleaser who agrees with everything and says "take all the time you need." Push past someone's boundary and you're the pusher, dragging them through the fire to enroll until they no longer feel safe.

Far more of us roll over than push, and it feels like kindness. Often it comes across as needy instead, because under the politeness, someone can sense how much you want the sale. And it leaves them exactly where they were.

How to challenge someone

Most of us picture a challenge as a statement, the hard thing said to someone's face. The challenges that work on a call almost always end in a question. At their best they're asked with permission and built from someone's own words, so the person you're talking to stays in control of the answer.

People resist when they feel you're taking that control away. Each challenge that follows leaves it with them.

The first is for the moment someone has told you what they need and then starts to back away from it. Say that on your first call, the person explains in their own words why running their website themselves isn't working. They hired someone to take it off their plate, he wasn't a good fit, and now they're back managing it instead of selling.

You both agreed it isn't the best use of their time, and you booked a follow-up call for them to decide. On that call they waver and start talking about fixing it on their own. You say something like this:

> SAY IT LIKE THIS
>
> "Hey, can I share an honest observation?"
>
> *When they say yes:*
>
> "I want what's best for you at the end of the day. But in our last conversation, you mentioned that you hired this guy and he wasn't a good fit. Now you're back in the seat managing your website, when you should be out there selling. And we both agreed this probably isn't the best use of your time. So help me understand this. Something hasn't fully clicked in my mind. Is there something I'm missing?"

It asks permission before it says anything. Everything in the middle is what they told you, and what the two of you agreed. There's no diagnosis in it, and nothing they didn't say.

Then it makes the confusion yours, and the last question lets you be the one who's missing something. Sometimes you are, and you learn what you needed to know. Or they hear their own words and remember what they wanted.

Now say it as a verdict: "You said you wanted this, so what's the problem?" It points at the same facts, and people close up. What's gone is the permission, the curiosity and the room to be wrong.

The second version sounds like the person I didn't like on those calls.

The same shape works on a first call, from discovery to the last minute. In discovery, the moment for a challenge comes right after someone tells you what happens if nothing changes. It's tempting to sum that up for them: "So you're going to resign yourself to not getting what you want." Statements like that feel pushy and spoon-fed.

The question does the same work: "Are you willing to settle for that?" They're the one who answers it, and when they say no, they've said it themselves. Ask it once, then let it sit.

I keep the last challenge for one moment. Someone who has the means has spent the call describing a pattern they want out of, and now, at the very end, they're about to repeat it. I ask permission, then hand them back the first part of the call and check whether they see it too.

> SAY IT LIKE THIS
>
> "Can I share something I'm noticing?"
>
> *Once they've said yes:*
>
> "For the first 20 minutes of this call, you told me how much you want [the change they want, in their words]. And now, at the end of it, it looks like the same pattern you described is showing up here. Do you see that too?"

That's a direct thing to say, and one sentence in it, that the pattern is showing up here, is my own read of them. It's fair only because everything around it is theirs: the permission they gave, 20 minutes of their own words, and a question that asks what they see. Then I let them answer. Without the permission, or before the pattern is on the record in their words, don't say it.

None of this is a license to challenge everyone. Every line here is said from their side of the table, as their advocate.

TRY THIS

Think back to the last time you told someone to take all the time they needed. Write down what they said just before it, as close to word for word as you can remember. Then write the one question their advocate would have asked instead, built from their words and asked with permission.

Challenge or safety

Not every hesitation needs a challenge. Part of leading is reading which one the person in front of you needs right now: a challenge or safety. A challenge is for a pattern, the same surface answer or the same story that's kept them stuck.

A boundary sounds different. It's a plain no, or a condition they can't change, like no money and no way to get it (Chapter 16 sorts a story from a condition).

Anxiety is easy to misread. Someone who's nervous or overwhelmed can sound unsure, which looks like a sign they aren't ready, or aren't a fit. Often it's a need for safety. Challenge someone who needs safety and they close off, however good the question.

What creates safety differs from person to person. Some people need facts and figures, and some just need to know you've got their back. Either way, when someone pulls back, I make it safe before I explore anything, so the question that follows reads as interest, not pressure.

With someone anxious, I name what we're doing at the start of the call and keep it simple: "We're going to get clear together on what you need in this conversation, so you walk away with clarity. My goal here is to help simplify things for you." It tells them where the conversation is going, which is its own kind of safety.

When someone needs a challenge, some discomfort comes with it, and I accept that. I'm aiming for clarity, and that's how I know when to stop. I go right up to the edge, and I back off at their boundary, or the moment a challenge stops serving clarity.

On the calls I'm not proud of, that's the moment I bulldozed through.

• • •

When I've had to ask myself who I was on a call, the answer I wanted was always the same: their advocate.

Very few people in our lives really tell us the truth. An advocate is one of them, someone willing to say the uncomfortable thing that anyone worried about the sale would keep to themselves. On your call, for an hour, that can be you.

When I see someone getting in their own way, I ask if I can share what I'm seeing, and I say I don't mind whether we work together or not. Then I tell them why: "I'd rather you get off this call knowing what I see."

IN SHORT

- Pushy pushes someone to a yes; leadership helps them decide, yes or no.
- Challenging can be direct because both answers count.
- Ask permission, use their words, and ask rather than tell.
- Read whether someone needs a challenge or safety.
- Challenge a pattern, and stop at a boundary.

CHAPTER NINE

The lines you don't cross

"The goal isn't 100 percent close rate.
The goal is 100 percent integrity rate."

A MAN I'D SPOKEN to three or four months earlier got in touch to say he was ready to sign up. I knew in my heart I shouldn't work with him. I could feel it. I took his money anyway, because I was in scarcity.

For more than two years, I'd worked almost entirely with brand-new coaches, helping them launch. I'd finally decided to work with coaches who were further along, and letting go of the work that felt safe had been really hard. Even once I went all in, part of me was still hanging on to the old.

He was a pretty new coach, and not right for the new work. But when someone's ready to pay you, it's hard to say no.

I sat with it for a week after signing him. Then one night at nine-thirty, lying in bed and staring at the ceiling, I knew I had to let him go. I felt so much resistance. Part of me said I couldn't, that it would be the worst thing ever.

People think decisions are complicated. They're not. They get complicated because we spend so much time in our heads. I had two choices, keep him or let him go, so I checked in with my body instead.

When I imagined keeping him, something in me tightened. It felt smaller. When I imagined letting him go, there was more room.

Nobody had pushed anybody. He came back to me, ready to pay. The line I'd crossed was about who I said yes to.

Most of us who care about the people on our calls think of integrity as a way of selling: gently, with nothing anyone could call pushy. But you can sell gently to the wrong person. Integrity isn't selling softly. It's selling only where you can help, and then selling fully, inside a few lines you never cross.

I knew on the call

Most bad client relationships are decided on the sales call.

When I look back at the handful of mine that went badly, almost every time I knew on the call that something wasn't right, and I made the sale anyway. Usually I was in scarcity or fear, and I chose not to trust myself.

Now, when I sense something on a call, I listen to it. I turn more people away than I ever have, and it's made the client experience smooth in the vast majority of cases. When I see something that could cause trouble later, I say it up front. I name the thing before it becomes the thing.

A mentor once asked me, "If you had $5 million in the bank, are these the clients that you'd be serving?" I've since turned it into a question about one person at a time, to ask before you pitch someone or invite a client to sign up again: *if I weren't worried about money, would I be working with this person?*

It's the second of the two questions on every call, with the money taken out: *do I want to?* Answer it the way I finally answered mine, with your body and not just your head. If picturing this person as your client makes something in you tighten, listen to it before you start making the case for the money.

If the answer is no, don't pitch. This is hardest when you need the client, which is exactly when the question matters, because that's when scarcity starts choosing for you. It's how I came to take that man's money.

Their own reasons

Once you know you can help someone, the rest of the lines are about how you sell. None of them asks you to hold back. They're what make it safe to lead: to make the offer clearly, ask for a decision and challenge where it serves.

The first test often comes at the end of a good call. The pitch has landed, you've said the price, and they tell you they need to think about it. You feel the pull to make it easier: a little off the price if they sign by Friday.

It feels generous. It's also the need for a yes, the same need that had me signing a man I knew I shouldn't work with.

Don't offer it. On a one-to-one call, urgency comes only from inside the person. That means no discounts, no deadlines, no price that holds only if they sign today, and no "get back to me within 48 hours." (A live launch has its own rule, in Appendix D.)

A deadline in that moment is lazy selling. We reach for outside pressure when we haven't drawn out someone's own reasons to change.

Scott Oldford, one of my business coaches, helped me see why it backfires. A countdown or a fast-action bonus might tip someone who buys on reflex, but thoughtful buyers, who think a decision through or check it with their gut, feel their arm being twisted and pull away.

The real fix comes earlier, at the end of discovery, with a question like "What happens if things don't change?" Someone who has answered that in their own words, and felt the answer, doesn't need your Friday. If you still end up there, get curious about what they want to think about, and leave Friday out of it.

None of that means leaving the decision open. Asking for one on the call is still the job. If they genuinely need time once you've explored it, book a short call two or three days out to decide together, with nothing riding on the date.

Limited spots work the same way. "There's only three spots left" is outside pressure too, and it creates distrust. If your spots really are limited, say so plainly and once, with no deadline attached, or not at all.

Even the question that replaces a deadline is service only when there's real care behind it. Without the care, it's manipulation. Craft your words anyway, because saying something well helps someone hear it. But the care, the claims and the fit have to be real.

The whole truth

I never make promises when I sell to people. Ever. There are a million things I can't control, and it wouldn't be honest to tell someone that if they do this, they'll get that result.

I can give ten coaches exactly the same training, resources and tools. Some won't watch the trainings, won't take action or will show up halfway, and they won't get results. Others will take the same thing and get great results.

That difference isn't mine to control. My job is to give someone the best possible path and support them in taking it. So what you sell is the path and what's realistically possible: what you'll map out and do together, and why it gives them their best chance of getting there (Chapter 14).

A guarantee is different from a promised result. It's a tool, not a blanket. I use one only to answer a real, specific risk someone has raised, such as *what if I do the work and it doesn't work for me?*

Never volunteer one before there's a concern, or use one to cover a gap that never landed (Chapter 19).

You can't promise the result, but you can tell the whole truth about everything else. Start with why you're there. Say early on that if you think you can help, you'll talk about working together. People trust you far more when they know what you intend.

Be as honest about the work itself, and never make it sound easier than it is. Time is one of the things I name before it becomes the thing. If someone needs results faster than the work can realistically deliver, I say so, even if it costs me the sale:

"It's going to take at least a couple of months for us to start to see some traction in your business. So if you're looking for something where we can flip a switch and get clients tomorrow, I don't think it's the right time to do this."

Sometimes the best thing to do is leave money on the table.

The last of these lines is my own story turned around. I took a man's money out of scarcity, and the person on your call can hand you theirs out of scarcity too. When I sense a yes coming from that tight place, I'd rather they didn't decide from there.

A stretch can be healthy. A reckless one isn't. Part of your job, as their leader, is to tell the two apart, and you do it by asking, with permission, about their real numbers once they're sure they want this and the money has come up from their side, never by guessing what they can afford.

If paying would leave someone somewhere that isn't good for them, it isn't a yes I want. There still has to be a responsible path.

A free yes

Every one of these lines protects the same thing: a yes someone gives freely.

A pressured yes becomes a refund, a no-show or a client who resents you. A free yes becomes a committed client who does the work.

Nobody pressured that man, and it still ended in a refund, because the yes that wasn't free was mine.

On their side, a free yes starts with genuine permission to say no. That makes a yes easier, because when nobody feels trapped, the decision is theirs, and it holds.

That permission belongs in the frame at the start of a call, and again when you ask where someone stands: "Are you in a place where you want to make this happen, or is this more of a someday thing? Genuinely, either one is fine." Never tack it onto the price or the ask as a "no pressure," where all it does is soften the offer.

Sometimes the no is yours to say. When you know on the call that you're not the right person for someone, say so plainly and point them somewhere better. The kindest no comes early, before any pitch, when all it costs you is a sale that was going to go wrong. (Chapter 18 gives you the words for it.)

• • •

So I let him go. After a week of knowing, it came down to a few short lines on my phone.

"Hey man, I'm really sorry. I've got to give you a refund. I made a mistake."

He took it well.

IN SHORT

- Sell only where you can help, and then sell fully.
- Urgency comes from them, never from a deadline.
- No fake scarcity, no promised results.
- A guarantee only answers a real risk.
- A pressured yes becomes a refund.



PART FOUR

Leading the call

What does it sound like?

CHAPTER TEN

Before you say hello

"The number one thing that influences your close rate isn't anything you say on the sales call itself. It's everything that person sees before they get on the phone with you."

IN THE EARLY DAYS of my business, my application was everywhere, even at the bottom of the first emails someone got when they joined my list. Applications came in, and I thought it was great: all these people wanted to work with us.

Then I'd get on the calls.

"Uh, who are you? I've never seen a video of you. I don't even know who you are."

Some of them had clicked one of my ads two days earlier. Those were really hard sales calls.

I don't want to get on a sales call with someone who has never seen my material and doesn't know who I am. So I moved the application to the end of a masterclass. Fewer people applied, and the ones who did were better.

When people have seen my work before we talk, I hear something else: "I watched three of your trainings, and I can already see you're someone who knows their stuff." They're pre-sold. That's how I want my sales calls.

The difference was everything they'd seen before we spoke. When that has done its job, someone is far more likely to buy, even if your calls are a little wonky. When it hasn't, you could have the best sales skills in the world and it would still be a million times harder.

Much of the sale is decided before hello: by who reaches your call, how warm they are when they arrive, and who you are when you join.

The rest is decided in the hour itself, and the hour has a shape. For the first 25 minutes of a good sales call, you're on a roller coaster, going up and up, the tension building. Then comes the pitch, the first big drop: the release. Then the track climbs again, toward the decision.

Everything from hello to the pitch is that first climb and its release. The edge comes after. Laid over the call, the seven look like this.

THE PART	ROUGHLY HOW LONG	WHICH OF THE SEVEN
The whole call	45 to 60 minutes, never over an hour	*the frame*, held from start to finish
The opening	2 to 5 minutes	sets *the frame*
Discovery	20 to 25 minutes, done by about minute 25	surfaces *the gap*, through *discovery*
The recap	brief	*the gap*, established
The pitch	a minute or two, inside a conversation	*the pitch*
The investment	one sentence, then silence	*the offer*
What they say after it	as long as it takes	*objections*
The end of the call	before you hang up	*the next step*

The solution isn't predetermined, but the flow is. I learned much of this structure from Cole Gordon.

Now run the physical therapist's call from the start of this book again, the one that ran two hours and ended in "Let me think about it." This time you lead, and you start before either of you says hello.

Warmth decides more than words

Warmth is why some coaches tell me they "used to be so good at sales" and now feel as if they can't close. Usually their first clients already knew them, and they've run out of warm network. Strangers are just harder to close.

It's also why close rates, the share of your calls that end in a sale, vary so much. If you're established and your calls are warm and well qualified, 60 to 70 percent is strong. A rate that high may mean it's time to raise your price, or simply that you qualify heavily before the call.

While you still need every call, you qualify less, so a lower rate is normal. And when nobody is reaching your calls at all, that's a marketing problem.

You don't need a gate like mine to have warmer calls. When someone books knowing little about you, warm them before you meet. I send a training before we talk, and I sell them on watching it. A short note with examples of your work and words from people you've helped does the same job.

"Hey, before our call on Thursday, I want you to watch this masterclass in full. It'll help lay the foundation so we can make the most of our time together."

By the time we talk, nobody's asking who I am.

Are the right people reaching your calls?

If the people booking calls with you are cold, or not a good fit, even great sales skills won't close them, and that's one of the hardest things to see in your own business. If you want help bringing warmer, better-fit people to your calls, book a free 20-minute business assessment call with me, and we'll take a personal look at your business.

BOOK YOUR FREE ASSESSMENT CALL

Don’t hide the door

If warmth matters this much, when do you invite someone to work with you? Most of us are so afraid of being pushy or salesy that we don’t open the door at all. It’s a kind instinct, and it means the people who most need your help never hear that they can have it.

Don’t hide the door. Invite people to work with you from the day they find you. Just don’t send a stranger straight to a sales call. That’s like inviting someone back to your apartment 20 minutes into a first date: the right message at the wrong time. Give them something useful first, like a free training, and ask for the call later.

How much friction you put in front of the call comes down to one question: do I have a lead-flow problem, or a protect-my-time problem? While you need more calls, keep it low and take nearly every call. Gates like mine come once calls are eating your week.

The name you give the call tells someone what they’re booking: time with an expert who’ll lead them, or an hour of free help. In the lovely version, she booked a free strategy session. It was a generous name. It promised her free help, and that’s exactly what she got.

One of my first sales coaches taught me this: nobody wants to book a call with you. They want what the call gets them. So name the call for that.

> INSTEAD OF “Book a free discovery call.”
>
> SAY “Book a business breakthrough call.”

A discovery call names your process. A business breakthrough call names their result. Whatever you call it, if the people you serve arrive in pain and wanting answers, say plainly at booking that this is a conversation about how you can help them, not free advice.

Invite them in their own words

Often the door opens in a message. There I open the gap on desire rather than on the challenge, because the obvious question, about someone's biggest challenge, can put their guard up. So I ask, "What's up ahead for you? Where do you ultimately want to be?" Then, "Where are you at right now?"

Two to four questions are enough. Say they want to reach $10,000 a month so they can quit their job and have more freedom, and they're struggling to get clients. Invite them in the words they've just used:

"Why don't we hop on a call this week and take a closer look at exactly why that's happening, and figure out what you need to shift to get on track to that 10K-a-month mark, so you can quit your job and have the freedom you want?"

Everything in that line is theirs: the problem they named, the number they want and the reason it matters. That's how I think about inviting anyone to anything. Open a gap, then offer the next step as the way to relieve the tension it creates.

Book it right there in the thread. Sending them off to your website or an application only breaks the momentum. Offer two times, the way someone with a full calendar would: "I've got Tuesday at 12 p.m. or Wednesday at 4 p.m. Which of those works best for you?"

Keep the sale itself for the call, on video if you can. In my business we've tried selling by text, and we close a lot less.

When you're not sure someone is ready to give you an hour, a short assessment call of 15 to 20 minutes, or a masterclass, can come first. The short call uncovers what's going on without solving it, and if they want help, it books the full hour. Appendix A has its flow, Appendix D the other lead-flow cases, and Appendix E the texts I send when someone applies.

Sometimes the first thing someone asks in a message is what it costs. My rule is simple: give the number up front when you're protecting your time, and after discovery when you need every call.

While you need every call, a number sent in a message lands in a vacuum. Nothing is standing next to it yet, so it feels too big or too small. Don't quote it, and don't refuse. Invite them.

> SAY IT LIKE THIS
>
> "Great question. The truth is, it depends. It depends on where you are and what you need. Why don't we do this? Let's hop on a call next week and take a closer look, and map out what you'd need. Then I'm happy to share the details on what the investment would be."

It's honest, because it does depend, and it tells them plainly they'll get the number. It turns the question into the call, where the price can sit next to what it's for.

Your number, before hello

Whenever someone hears it, your price is a belief before it's a number. Settle it before the call, not in the second after you've said it.

People ask me how I set my prices, and I tell them I just make it up. There's no formula, but there is a test: what is this change worth to the person in front of me?

Say you help coaches grow, and someone is at $5,000 a month and wants $10,000. If it takes six months to get there, by the end of the year that's an extra $30,000 they wouldn't otherwise have had, and more every year after. Set $9,000 against that, and it's a fraction of what the first year alone gives back.

If you sell a fixed program at one price, that test is how you check it before the call. Run it against the kind of person who usually books with you. If the change is worth many times your number to them, your price is settled before you join.

Pricing each person separately goes with designing the offer with them (Chapter 14): someone at $50,000 a month gets far more from doubling than someone at $5,000, so the same work is worth more to them. It suits a one-to-one business bringing in under about $10,000 a month, and Appendix D has the stages.

When you price this way, what you settle before hello is a floor. Work out the least you'd want to be paid for an hour of your time, the minimum that feels like a fair exchange, and double it. That's the line you won't go below, not your price.

The figure itself comes together between the recap and the price. By then they've told you, in their own numbers, what the change is worth to them, and you know roughly how many hours the work will take. Choose a number that's a fraction of what the change is worth, divide it by those hours, and if the answer comes in under your floor, charge more.

Still, pricing is far more about your commitment, and your certainty in the value of the change you help people make, than about the number. Go into a call thinking, *oh, I'm charging a lot*, and the person on the other end will feel it. But if your work changes people's lives, whatever you charge is a drop in the bucket next to what they get in return.

When your price feels like that to you, there's no tension in saying it, and people match your belief, whichever way it runs.

A new price won't feel that way at first. It will feel edgy for a while, and no magic hack makes the edge go away. It's just a thought, a feeling and a sensation in your body. Notice it and say the number anyway, until a client or two has said yes and it starts to feel normal.

The five minutes before

Of everything someone sees before the call, the last thing is you, in the moment you join. So arrive as the person you want them to meet.

Someone booking a call with you doesn't need to prepare answers or bring anything. If they came in cold, the one thing I ask is that they watch

the training first. Beyond that, when they ask if they should prepare anything, I tell them, "No, I'll take it from there. Don't worry about it. Just show up and be ready to answer some questions."

The preparation is yours. Give it five minutes. Read what they told you when they booked, and imagine for a moment what it's like to be them. Reconnect with what your work does in people's lives, then set your intention to help, not to close (Chapter 3), and ground yourself: if this call doesn't end in a sale, that's okay.

Ask yourself, too, how you'd show up if people were lining up to work with you. Then close your eyes for a minute and imagine that it's true, even if it isn't.

That's an inner state. It changes how you sit in the conversation, but you never tell anyone you're fully booked when you aren't.

Then take a fresh page. At the top of every page of sales-call notes, I write six beliefs, in this order: PAIN · DESIRE · HELP · TRUST · WHY NOW · COST. They're what matters most before someone buys: their problem hurts, they want something better, they can't close the gap on their own, they trust you to help them close it, this is the moment to act, and staying put will cost them.

The order is deliberate. Together they stretch the gap, and cost comes last, just before the recap, because it hits hardest. I tick each one only when it lands.

I take my notes by hand, and I write down their exact words, because so much of a call is handing someone their own language back, in the recap and in the pitch. Make the page tonight and print a stack.

TRY THIS

Look at your last five sales calls. For each person, write down what they'd seen of your work before they booked, and mark who bought. Then decide what you'll send the next person who books knowing little about you.

• • •

She books. This time it's a business breakthrough call, named for what she'll get.

She isn't a stranger. Her booking note says she's watched your video about pricing.

Five minutes before, you read it again and take a fresh page, six beliefs across the top. You join on time.

She's already there, a minute early.

IN SHORT

- Much of the sale is decided before hello.
- Warmth beats technique, and close rates depend on who reaches the call.
- Don't hide the door, and name the call by its outcome.
- Know your number, and believe it, before you join.
- Arrive grounded, with the six beliefs at the top of the page.

CHAPTER ELEVEN

Taking the lead

"They need someone who can be the anchor in the storm.
That's how you serve someone: by holding that anchor."

BEFORE YOU'VE SAID MUCH, she mentions her kids.

In the lovely version of this hour, you asked about them. Twenty minutes went by before you asked why she'd booked. Underneath all that warmth was one quiet wish: *I really want her to like me.*

Sometimes we get on a sales call and feel a need to prove ourselves, or to make someone like us. It comes out as a lot of extra friendliness, and it brings a rule with it: don't say anything that might rock the boat.

The cost showed up at the end. When she said she'd like to think about it, the friend you'd become had no way to ask her what about.

The first few minutes of a call set the tone for the whole relationship. Spend them in the friend zone and you lose the chance to lead. Once someone sees you as a friend, it's very hard to challenge the beliefs that might be keeping them stuck, or to call them to their highest.

THE POINT

Your job on a sales call is not to be someone's friend. It's to be the leader.

People come to your call with a problem, a challenge or something they want, and your job is to help them. Sometimes that takes a difficult conversation, and a friend who won't rock the boat can't have one.

She's still telling you about her kids. What you do in the next two minutes decides who leads the hour.

A minute or two of real warmth

Leading from the first minute doesn't mean going in cold. Diving straight into the deep end is a mistake too. You don't need a ton of warmth, but you need some.

Rapport, as I see it, is about safety. Its job is to help someone soften enough to open up a little, and that doesn't take long.

It starts with what I leave out. I never thank people for taking the time to chat with me, because the call is a gift to them. You're the professional, and they're there because they need help. I don't mean that to sound arrogant.

The grateful opening is well meant. It comes from good manners, and often from nerves. But "Thanks so much, I know you're really busy" tells someone, before you've asked a single question, that the favor runs from them to you. It's hard to lead from there.

> INSTEAD OF "Thanks so much for taking the time."
>
> SAY "I'm glad we had a chance to chat. I'm excited that we get to talk about how we can help you."

It's every bit as warm, and it looks ahead to the work instead of apologizing for the call.

There is a moment for appreciation on a good call. It comes later, at the recap, once someone has told you hard things, and it's for their honesty, not their time: "I appreciate you being so honest with me."

I don't plan the small talk. I do my calls over Zoom, so I'll comment on something interesting I can see behind them, like a photo, or ask where

they're located. I make a lot of jokes about people's hair, because I have none, and joking about being bald helps people soften up.

Sometimes what I see tells me the call can't happen yet. Someone has joined from the car, or while out walking, and I don't carry on: "Why don't we reschedule? I know this call is important for you, and I want to make sure we can focus 100 percent."

It's the same in a coaching session. A coach once asked me about a session she'd run with a client who was driving. She'd gone ahead, against her own instinct. I told her I'd have rescheduled, and I'd have told the client why: "Look, I want you to get the most out of this session, and I'm not going to be able to deliver that in this kind of environment."

The reason I give is about them. The decision is mine, and I don't leave it in their hands. I'd rather step into that leadership place, where it's simple: I'm going to make the call.

When the setting is right, a minute or two of back and forth is all it takes. Then I'll say something like, "Cool, so you ready to dive in and get started?" It's a small question with one job: it moves you both from chatting to working, with their yes.

The frame, and the words that set it

Once they've said they're ready, you tell them how the call is going to go. This is where you take the lead out loud.

The agenda is the frame, the first of the seven, put into words. It's only a few sentences, and what sits behind them is plain: you're the expert, you've done this many times, and you have a flow they need to follow so you can serve them.

> SAY IT LIKE THIS
>
> "So my goal here is to help you get clear on what you need. And from there, if I think I can help, we can talk through what that looks like, and you can decide whether or not you want to move forward with that. Or if I think there's someone else out there who'd be better for you, I can do my best to point you in the right direction instead. Sound good?"

The agenda puts them in your care: the goal it names is their clarity. It gives every question that follows a purpose they've already agreed to, so a hard one later makes sense. It says out loud that you're there to find out whether you can help, which answers the fear most people bring, that you'll get them on the phone and sell them. And it honestly allows a no.

Mean that last part. I do point people elsewhere, sometimes partway through a call, because my calls are evaluative: I'm deciding too (Chapter 7). Said as a formality, the referral line is one more sales line. Meant, it takes the pressure off you both.

Then stop, and wait for the yes. Don't ask your first question until you've heard some version of "Sounds good," because that yes is them handing you the lead.

On video, once you have it, it's worth adding one line: "By the way, I'm going to be taking notes."

When they reach for the lead

Sometimes someone reaches for the lead before you've finished taking it. I never fight them for it. I agree, set their question aside for later, and bring them back to their biggest challenge.

Often the reach is the price. Two minutes in, someone asks, "So how much is it?" Not answering can feel evasive.

But a number this early has nowhere to live. Neither of you knows yet what they need, so there's nothing to set it against.

Defer it. Don't refuse it.

I'll say, "Awesome, we'll definitely get into that in a couple of minutes. But I guess before we get there, what I want to do here is get clear on what you need." It says yes to the question and no to the timing.

There are three exceptions: a full calendar, a real money red flag early on, and someone who's already sold, such as a past buyer or a referral. Appendix D covers all three. What I never give, on any call, is a ballpark. A vague range is still a number, said before it can mean anything.

Sometimes the reach is about you: how you're different from other coaches, or how you work. On a sales call my job is to assess fit, to find out whether I can actually help someone. If someone starts asking a bunch of questions about you and you jump in to answer them, now they have the frame, and you've lost the lead.

> SAY IT LIKE THIS
>
> "Cool, those are great questions, and I'm happy to answer them. What I want to do first is learn a little more about where you are, and see if I can help you and what you need. Let's start there, and then if it feels like a fit, I'm happy to talk through the details and answer any questions you have. Sound good?"

You haven't dodged anything. You've agreed the questions are good, promised to answer them once you know whether you can help, and asked for their yes. You're leading again.

Holding it to the end

It's easy to believe the frame is done once they've said "Sounds good." It has only been set. Each part of it is tested later in the call, at a moment when handing back the lead would feel kinder.

Curious and never coaching are tested the first time someone asks what you'd do in their place, and Chapter 5 gave you the line for it. Say it, go on to

your next question, and the agenda has kept its word. You told them this call was for getting clear on what they need, and that's what they said yes to.

Detached means high intention and no attachment: you do everything you can to create a path for this person, and you're genuinely fine if they don't take it. That's easy two minutes in. It's hardest at the end, where the money is: after you've said the number, when the first objection comes, when you ask for a decision. That's where wanting the yes starts to grip, and you've seen where that leads.

Never chasing is tested after you hang up. A decision call already on the calendar is leading. A trail of messages hoping for a reply is chasing.

Later in this hour, you'll say a number to her and then nothing, for about forty seconds. You'll want to fill the quiet. That will be the frame at its hardest.

Every call has moments when the person in front of you loses their footing. Whoever stays steady when the other person can't is the one leading.

TRY THIS

Listen back to the first three minutes of your last recorded call. Notice how long it took you to ask your first real question, whether you thanked them for their time, and whether you heard a yes before you started asking. Say the agenda out loud until you could say it half asleep, and once more before your next call.

On the call

"I'm glad we had a chance to chat. I'm excited that we get to talk about how we can help you."

Then her kids come up. This time you say something warm about them, and you leave it there.

Behind her, on the wall, there's an anatomy poster. You tell her you like it, and she laughs. For a minute or so you go back and forth.

"Cool, so you ready to dive in and get started?"

"Yeah, let's do it."

You give her the agenda, and you mean the referral line. Before she answers, she has a question of her own.

"So roughly how much is it?"

You tell her you'll get to it in a couple of minutes.

"Just a ballpark?"

It would be easy to give her one. She's asked twice, nicely, and a number would make the next minute easier for you both.

"Honestly, at this point, I don't know what you need or whether I can help you. So why don't we start there, and we can figure that out together. And if it makes sense, I'm happy to share all the details with you."

A pause. "Sounds good."

You tell her you'll be taking notes, and look down at a fresh page with the six beliefs across the top. She's said yes to your questions.

Setting the frame takes two minutes. Holding it takes the whole call.

IN SHORT

- A minute or two of real warmth, then lead. Never thank them for their time.
- The agenda sets the frame. Mean the referral line, and wait for the yes.
- When they reach for the lead, agree, and bring them back.
- Set the frame in two minutes, then hold it for the whole call.

CHAPTER TWELVE

Where the sale is made

"The sale is made in the first 25 minutes of the call."

A COACH I WAS working with once told me a lot of the discovery questions didn't apply to the people on her calls. She knew what the problem was, and the big picture was clear from the start. Why ask about something she already knew?

It was a fair question. If you're good at your work, you'll often see someone's problem long before they can.

So I asked one back. "Clear to you, or clear to them?"

We're all very good at what we do. I can get on a call with a coach and work out exactly what's going on in their business in about thirty-two seconds, and you can probably do the same with your clients. I still ask, even when I already know the answer.

The questions aren't only there to collect information. They walk someone through a series of realizations, the shifts they need to make before they'll be open to changing anything.

When I ask someone about their biggest challenge and they start telling me, they reconnect to how it feels. Suddenly it isn't an intellectual thing anymore. It's *I'm actually feeling this, and what it's been doing to me.* Then I ask what impact it's been having on their life, and they start to open up.

Discovery is how someone comes to feel their own gap and say what they need. Ask the right questions, and they sell themselves by answering.

The beliefs to land

People resist what they hear. But when they're telling you, they're also telling themselves. Someone who answers "What happens if things don't change?" may be admitting the stakes to themselves for the first time.

That's why most of a sale happens here, long before you say a word about your offer. When a call ends in "let me think about it," I look back here first, and most of the time a belief never landed. The back half of a call is helping someone through the fear at the edge of a decision. Whether there's a real decision to be afraid of is settled in the first half.

Skip the questions because the answer looks obvious, and the next step is usually to say it for them. That's the pusher's version of discovery.

He can see the gap, so he names it: "So basically, your problem is that you're not charging enough." He does the math out loud and brings the urgency himself. It feels efficient, and it usually gets a nod.

But a gap someone has only been told about is one they agree with in their head and never feel. When they say it, they believe it.



THE SEVEN · 3 OF 7

Discovery: surfaces the core beliefs and connects the prospect to them emotionally, not just intellectually.

Each belief has a sound once it lands, and that sound is what you're listening for.

WHAT LANDS	WHAT YOU ASK ABOUT	LANDED SOUNDS LIKE
Pain, with its impact	Their biggest challenge, and its impact	Feeling and real stakes, not a tidy problem
Desire, with the why	Where they want to be, and why	A future they step into, not a bare number
The number (where the outcome can be measured)	What the gap is worth	The size of the gap, in their numbers
Help	Why they haven't solved it alone	A first-person *I need help*
Trust (where the sale needs it)	Why you	Their own reasons for choosing you
Why now (almost always)	What makes this the moment	Their own reason to act now
The cost of inaction	Where the road they're on leads	The stakes, in their own words

Pain, desire, help and the cost of inaction are required on every full sales call. Helping someone feel all of it is mostly a matter of how you ask and how little you say (Chapter 13).

Pain and desire are where most calls stay in the head. Someone tells you they've been stuck at the same income for two years, and it's tempting to tick *pain* and move on.

That's not pain. That's a problem. Pain is what the problem is doing to their life, so after every fact, ask about its impact.

Desire works the same way. Someone wants to make $20,000 a month. That's not desire. That's a goal, until you ask why it matters to them and what it would change.

Land the beliefs, not the labels. A tick beside *pain* is only a label. Hearing what the problem has been doing to their life is how you know the belief has landed.

Score each one landed, half-landed or missing. Skip a question only once they've said that belief themselves. Until they have, ask.

The questions, in order

People often ask me for the questions. I find it more useful to know what each one is aiming at. These are the ones I use, in the order that lets someone walk themselves to the gap.

> SAY IT LIKE THIS
>
> 1. "What's your number one biggest challenge when it comes to [X]?"
> 2. "How's that been impacting you?"
> 3. "Where do you ultimately want to be?" *Then:* "Why is that so important to you?"
> 4. *Where the outcome can be measured:* "What's a new client worth for you in your business?"
> 5. "What do you feel has been stopping you from solving this on your own?"
> 6. *Where the sale needs it:* "What was it that made you feel like I was the right person to help you with this?"
> 7. *Unless they've already told you:* "What's making you feel like now is the right moment to solve this?"
> 8. "Before I move on, anything else you feel would be helpful for me to know?"
> 9. "What happens if things don't change?"

I open on the biggest challenge because it's the best question I've found to start a call. It takes someone straight to what's live for them today. "What motivated you to book this call?" sounds friendlier and gets you a five-minute backstory.

The exception is someone for whom pain isn't the way in: a buyer who's already doing well and wants to go from good to great, a high-end buyer, or someone who can't name a problem at all. With them, open on desire. Ask

what they really want, then back into what's in the way, and still ask what's at stake.

Straight after they tell you where they want to be, ask where they are today, and name the distance in their words: "So today you're at [A]. Obviously there's a bit of a gap between that and [B]." It sets both ends side by side, so they can see the distance for themselves.

The fifth question is where a switch has to click. There's no reason for anyone to hire a coach if they think they can solve the problem on their own, so somewhere in discovery they have to realize one of two things.

Either *I've been trying to figure this out on my own, and I haven't been getting anywhere.* Or *it just doesn't make sense to do this alone. I'd get there faster and easier, and save myself a lot of time, money and frustration.*

That's the help belief. I first learned it from Cole Gordon, who taught it to me as doubt, and I started calling it help because it's a little more empowering.

It's also the easiest belief to skip, because the need so often seems obvious. Skip it, and they never say it out loud. It comes back at the end of the call: *maybe I'll give it a go on my own first.*

One question doesn't always get someone there, so you ask another. With coaches who have been at it a while and still aren't getting clients, I'll often ask, "You've been doing this for a couple of years. What's been stopping you from figuring this out on your own?" As they answer, they realize it for themselves: they've been at this a long time without results, and what they're doing isn't working.

If it still half-lands, I'll say something like, "Typically what I find is when people reach out to me, they know something needs to shift, they don't quite know what it is, and they recognize they need some help. Does that feel like it describes where you're at?" It hands them the words and lets them say yes, or correct me.

The trust question is for the calls that need it: someone who found you only recently, or who is weighing other coaches. Their answer sells them on you in a way your credentials never could, so never argue your expertise. A thin answer tells you something too: they may be colder than you thought.

The eighth question is a last sweep. It gives them one more chance to put something on the table, and sometimes it brings out a whole new layer of what they want. When it does, ask about it before you move on. Then cost closes discovery, with nothing between it and the recap.

For your first 30 to 50 calls, keep this order. After that, you can follow someone's thread, as long as every belief lands before you pitch, and the numbers still come early and cost last. Expect one to three questions for each belief; a warmer buyer often needs fewer (Appendix D).

On a full call, all of it takes 20 to 25 minutes, and the usual mistake is too little: one surface answer at minute five, then "I can totally help with that."

Notice what isn't on the list. There's no insight of yours in it, no story about you and nothing about your program. The leader leaves all of that out of discovery. When the insight does come, later in the call, it lands, because by then they've said most of it themselves.

You may well see the answer in thirty-two seconds. Keep it to yourself, and ask anyway.

The number, why now and cost

A number makes a gap real.

A while back, I played out an Instagram conversation live in front of a group, with someone playing the man I was messaging. I complimented a post of his about setting stronger boundaries and asked what he did. Most of his work, he told me, was in person.

I thought I'd found a thread. Ideally, he said, he'd like half his work online, so he could save time and travel more. I invited him to set aside some time the next week to look at making that shift, and he said yes.

Then I stopped and graded myself: a B-minus. Did he really care that much about going from mostly in person to half online? It felt like I was trying to manufacture a desire.

So I ran it again. This time I asked about the biggest challenge in his business right now. Not enough clients, he said.

I asked how many he was signing a month, how many he wanted to sign, and what the difference would bring in. Three or four thousand euros a month, he said, which came to an extra 40,000 euros a year.

When we'd finished, I asked which version made him more likely to say yes. The second, he said, because it gave him a number.

The first version got a yes to a gap he didn't much care about. The second found the one he did, and put his own number on it.

On a call, the number does the same job. Ask for it early, while you're getting clear on pain and desire. Questions about clients, revenue and hours carry no emotion, so they belong here, never after help, trust, why now or cost.

It works best when they do the math. Ask what a new client is worth to them, then work it out with them from what they're signing now and what they want to sign: what the difference comes to in a month, and in a year. For someone whose calendar is already full, it's what their prices have been leaving on the table.

Count it as what they're missing out on right now, not what they could gain. People are more likely to move when they feel they're losing something than when they see something to gain, and the upside already lives in the vision they gave you earlier.

If you sum it up, make the summary a question: "Does that sound right to you?" Numbers you present get a nod. Numbers they work out themselves get felt.

Not every outcome has a price. Say a woman comes to you with back pain, and you ask how it's been impacting her. She can't pick up her grandson. She used to go on three- and four-hour hikes with her friends, and now she manages about 20 minutes before she has to head home.

There's no dollar figure in that, and you may not need one: four-hour hikes against 20 minutes is a number she can feel. Where the outcome has no price, other things stand in for the number: the time already lost, their body, their relationships, who they'll become if nothing changes. Let them say it.

Why now and cost are the questions most of us want to skip. By the time you reach them, someone has told you what they want and the call feels warm. Asking why they haven't acted sooner can sound like an accusation, and asking what happens if nothing changes feels like spoiling it. So we ask softly, or apologize first, or leave them out.

This is the pleaser's discovery, and it's kindly meant. We don't want anyone to feel uncomfortable, so when someone hands us a tidy answer, we take it gratefully and move on. But skip why now and cost to keep someone comfortable, and they come back at the end of the call as "it's not the right time." Nothing in the conversation ever gave them a reason it was.

Why now sometimes comes out before you ask. If it doesn't, ask it, and put their own timeline in front of it so it sounds curious rather than blaming: "You mentioned earlier, you've been running this business for three years, and you're just now reaching out to get some real help with this. So what's making you feel like now is the right moment to solve this?"

Then listen for what changed. People act when something tips: the pain gets worse, or a deadline arrives. When they name that moment themselves, the urgency is theirs.

Cost comes last, just before you recap and pitch, because it lands hardest. I hate the phrase *twisting the knife*. It sounds abusive. What I'm asking about is the cost of inaction, which helps someone tell the truth about the road they're on.

Most people have never had anyone ask them these questions with real presence and curiosity. Asking them is an act of service. The stakes are theirs, and so is the leverage that comes from saying them out loud.

So ask it plainly: "What happens if things don't change?" Then let them answer.

If the answer stays close to today, stretch it across time. "Where are you going to be one year, three years, five years down the line, if you continue going down the path you're on today?"

Ask it in discovery, never after the pitch, and write the answer down word for word. You'll need it when the fear comes up.

The buying pocket, then the fit gate

By the end of a good discovery, I'm listening for a particular place. I call it the buying pocket.

Someone in it is feeling the gap, something like this: *Okay. I feel this problem. I feel what I want. I feel how much I need help. I feel what it's costing me to do nothing, and I want to change.*

The rubber band is at full stretch, pulled there by their own answers. Pitch before someone gets there, and you're answering a question they haven't asked yet.

The buying pocket says they're ready. Whether you should pitch is a separate question, and it's yours. I think of it as the fit gate, the two questions you're on every call to answer: *can I help this person, and do I want to?*

Some things should stop you: a priority that turns out to be low once you've named it, or no real desire to change at all, the kind I caught myself trying to manufacture in my B-minus version. So should a gap too small for your offer, a real red flag such as no runway at all, or a quiet no in your gut.

Pitch past any of them and you may even get a yes. The cost comes later, in refunds and in clients you can't help, like the man I signed and then refunded in Chapter 9.

Other things only look like reasons. Nerves aren't one, because anxiety on a call is often a need for safety. Not knowing what they need isn't one either; if they knew, they wouldn't be on the call. And a flinch at a price they heard before the call often looks very different after a full conversation.

If the answer is no, exit kindly before any pitch: plainly, briefly, and pointing them somewhere better (Chapter 18).

TRY THIS

On your next call, tick a word across the top of your page only when you'd score that belief landed. Afterward, write beside each tick what the person said. Over a few calls, notice the one you keep half-landing, and write the question you'll ask next time to finish it.

On the call

"So, what's your number one biggest challenge when it comes to your practice?"

"I've been booked solid for over a year, but I can't get ahead," she says. "I set my prices when I opened and I've never touched them. I just need to raise them."

You could have told her that in thirty-two seconds. You write down her words and ask how it's been impacting her, and the real answer takes more than one question to reach.

Then you ask where she ultimately wants to be. A practice that pays her properly in four days a week, she says, with her evenings back.

"Why is that so important to you?"

"I didn't leave the clinic to feel like this."

You ask where she is today. About thirty sessions a week, and notes most evenings.

"So today it's about thirty sessions a week, with notes most evenings. Obviously there's a bit of a gap between that and four days, with your evenings back."

You ask where she'd set her price if she were setting it today. About $25 more a session, she says. You ask what that's been leaving on the table each year, across the clients she already has, and she works it out aloud.

"That's more than $30,000."

Help takes longer. You let it, and she gets there in her own words.

Asked why you, she mentions your video about pricing.

"What's making you feel like now is the right moment to solve this?"

The lease on her treatment room is up in two months.

"Before I move on, anything else you feel would be helpful for me to know?"

"No. I think that's everything."

Cost takes longer still.

You look down at your page. Every word across the top has a tick beside it, and the margin is full of her words.

You put the pen down. You can help her, and you want to.

IN SHORT

- **Discovery:** surfaces the core beliefs and connects the prospect to them emotionally, not just intellectually.
- Ask even when you already know the answer; when they say it, they believe it.
- Land the beliefs, not the labels.
- Open on the biggest challenge, except with high-end, good-to-great and vague buyers.
- Pitch only after the buying pocket and the fit gate.

CHAPTER THIRTEEN

Ask, then be quiet

"When you're talking, you're not listening,
and you're not asking questions."

I ONCE RECORDED a practice call with a coach playing the part of someone new to coaching. At one point I asked her, "So where is this headed if nothing changes?"

She told me. She'd burn out. She'd stay stuck at the same income. She'd keep feeling the strain in her relationship.

Then I left space.

Later I played the recording to a group of coaches, and that silence was one of the places I stopped it.

"Notice the space here," I told them. "Why am I leaving space? I want her to feel this."

Everything she told me had been there all along, under the rug, with the other inconvenient truths she'd been avoiding.

The question brought it to the surface, and the silence gave it room to be aired out, so she could feel it. Once she'd said it out loud, it was real.

I asked, and then I got out of the way.

Someone can answer every question you ask and feel none of it, often because we never go quiet long enough for them to. What moves someone from understood to felt is fewer words, not more.

From head to heart

Another time, I demonstrated discovery live at a training, with a participant talking about his own business. I got what I'd call good intellectual answers.

Afterward, I told the group that on a real call I'd have gone deeper. When someone talks about missed potential, I want them to sit with it for a moment, because that's real.

I'm not looking for someone to tell me, intellectually, here's the gap. I want to help them drop into their body, where they can feel it, emotionally and physically.

That demo surfaced the beliefs. What it missed was the second half of the line from the last chapter: discovery *connects the prospect to them emotionally, not just intellectually.*

That's the question I carry onto every call: *does this person actually feel the gap?* Move on when they feel it, not when they've answered.

For some people the gap is right on the surface, and one question brings the challenge, the impact and the cost pouring out. Others need two or three. For me, it's a feel thing: I can feel where the tension is, and the moment someone is really feeling it. That gets clearer the more conversations you have.

Until it does, listen for what's missing. An answer full of facts, with no word for what it's been like, is still in the head. A short follow-up takes it one level down.

> SAY IT LIKE THIS
>
> "Tell me more about that."
>
> "What do you mean?"
>
> "How long has that been going on for?"
>
> "Why is that so important to you?"
>
> "Are you willing to settle for that?"

None of these adds anything of yours. Each sends someone back into their own answer, a little further in. Listen, too, for "but honestly." Whatever comes after it is the thread, so follow it.

Some people will never use a feeling word, and pushing them for one is like pushing a boulder up a hill. With them, ask about impact. It does the same work.

When you're not sure, it doesn't hurt to go a little deeper. Once a belief has landed, though, check it off and move to the next. Circling it only makes someone repeat themselves, and the call runs long.

Short questions, then silence

It's easy to let a question grow. "Yeah, that makes total sense, and I'm curious how that shows up in your relationships, and maybe your work too?" Someone can answer only one part of that, so they pick one or wander off.

The short version is: "I'm sorry to hear that. What impact has that been having on your life?" Long questions get rambling answers.

If someone rambles anyway, interrupt kindly and narrow it: "I appreciate you sharing that. And I guess what I'm curious about is this one specific piece." If you expect a talker, ask permission to interrupt when you set the agenda (Appendix A).

What you do after the answer matters even more. Say you ask, "What happens if things don't change?" and someone tells you they'll have to go back to a nine-to-five and give up on their dream.

The difference between someone who's decent at sales and someone who's really good is how they respond. The decent seller feels their own discomfort and hops in to save them: "I hear you, and you're not alone in that." Every version of that line says the same thing: *I'm not willing to sit in the discomfort of this moment with you.*

The other says, "Yeah, that's really tough," and sits in the silence with them.

THE POINT

The biggest tool you have is silence.

After a weighty answer, let it sit for four or five seconds. In the quiet, someone comes to experience what they've said, and once they feel it in their body, they have a completely different relationship to it. Sometimes they keep going on their own.

Sometimes they laugh instead, because what they've just said is uncomfortable. Don't laugh along. Let the laugh pass in silence, then ask one short question that takes them further in.

The pause before an answer is theirs too, so leave it alone. Some discomfort comes with the quiet, but it's never the point.

Four seconds feels long from your chair, and everything in you wants to say something. A lot of sales, for me, is just noticing, *huh, I'm feeling really uncomfortable*, and not saying things because of it.

If you have to make a sound, make it "Hmm," then stay quiet. It does more work than any sentence.

TRY THIS

On your next call, after every weighty answer, count silently to five before you speak. If they start talking before you get there, let them. Afterward, write down anything they said in the quiet that you never asked for.

Don't reflect, don't mention yourself

Earlier on that same recording, I'd stopped it once her pain had landed. I told the group why it had worked: I'd left a lot of space. I wasn't hopping in and reflecting back. It was ask a question and then shut up.

Most of what we say between questions is meant kindly: a little summary after each answer to show we're listening, a steady murmur of agreement while they talk, a story of our own so they know we understand. Each one

moves the focus off them and onto us, and pulls them out of the flow of saying what's on their heart.

The summary is the hardest to give up, because it feels like good listening. "So what I'm hearing is, there's a lot of frustration there." Mid-discovery, it spends minutes you'll need for the beliefs that haven't landed yet. Save it for once, right before the pitch, when you hand everything back together.

Keep yourself and your offer out of it too. Two questions in, someone describes exactly the problem you solve, and it's tempting to tell them it's something you work with a lot. That puts you three steps ahead of them, and it raises their resistance. For the first 25 minutes of a call, I'm not saying anything about me, what I do, or whether I think I can help.

Call out the elephant

Sometimes someone's words and the way they say them don't match. They tell you they're totally committed, in a flat voice. That's the elephant in the room: something you can both feel and neither of you has said.

It's there whether you name it or not. Left alone, it becomes a barrier at the end of the call, just as they're deciding.

Calling out the elephant took me a long time to learn, and it's one of the best ways I know to build trust. The line I use is one Keith Rosen taught me.

> SAY IT LIKE THIS
>
> "I'm sensing that there might be a little bit of [X] here. Is there any truth to that?"

The line pins nothing on the person. Make it "I'm sensing you might be a little uncomfortable," and it's aimed at them, so their instant reaction is to defend themselves. Once their walls go up, you're not in a dialogue anymore.

Keep it as "I'm sensing there might be a little discomfort here," and you're both looking at something on the table between you.

The question at the end matters just as much, because it lets them tell you you're wrong. Sometimes I'll add, "I might be misreading this." If they tell you there's nothing there, believe them and ask your next question.

One elephant you'll meet often is the tidy answer. You ask why something matters and, however you ask, the same neat reply comes back. The honest observation from Chapter 8 works here too, with the confusion made yours: "Help me understand, because I feel like there's something I'm missing."

How it lands depends on whose side you're on. I go into every call thinking: I'm on your team. I want what's best for you.

From there, naming the elephant is curiosity, not accusation, and it doesn't backfire. People tell you.

On the call

Back to the physical therapist. Three moments of her discovery took longer than the last chapter showed.

You've asked how being booked solid has been impacting her.

"It's fine. It's just busy."

"Tell me more about that."

A pause.

"Honestly? I'm tired."

There's the thread. She does her notes most evenings, she says, and she's been short with her kids. Then she tells you about dinner, and her daughter asking why she's always on her laptop.

"Wow, that's really tough."

Nothing more.

A few minutes later, you ask what's been stopping her from solving this on her own. She tells you she's twice drafted an email raising her prices and never sent it.

"I keep telling myself next quarter. I've been saying that for a year."

She laughs. You don't. Her words and her laugh don't match, and once the laugh has passed, you name it.

"I'm sensing there might be a bit of embarrassment around that. Is there any truth to that?"

"… Yeah."

You wait.

"I don't think I can do this on my own."

You write it down, word for word, and let it sit.

Later, you ask, "What happens if things don't change?"

She doesn't answer straight away. The silence stretches, you feel it tighten in your chest, and you hear yourself start to fill it.

"And look, a lot of practitioners feel …"

You stop.

"Sorry. Go on."

She tells you her partner has started asking whether she should go back to the clinic. Another year of this, she says, and she might.

"Are you willing to settle for that?"

"No."

This time, you leave the silence alone.

• • •

You'll slip like that on your own calls, more than once.

What matters is that you hear yourself, stop, and hand the silence back.

IN SHORT

- Understood isn't felt, and the way from one to the other is fewer words.
- Move on when they feel it, not when they've answered.
- One short question, then silence.
- Don't reflect, don't rescue, don't mention yourself.
- Name the elephant with "I'm sensing … is there any truth to that?"

CHAPTER FOURTEEN

The bridge

"What people want is what's on the other side."

NO ONE CARES about your program.

That isn't a judgment of your work. It's a fact about what people buy.

I've forgotten to tell people how long my program was, or how many calls it included, and they've signed up without knowing. All they cared about was whether they believed *this is going to help me get from where I am today to where I want to be.*

You've built something you're proud of, and you should be. You know why the first month comes before the second, and why the calls are weekly. When the moment comes to pitch, it's natural to want the person in front of you to see all of that care.

But your offer is a bridge from where they are to where they want to be, and nobody buys the bridge. They buy the other side.

So once someone has felt their gap, what do you say? Less than you'd think. The pitch is short, built from their own words, and shows one clear way across. You say it with calm certainty and without a promise.

Appreciate them, then recap

Most of us get this moment wrong in one of two ways. We slide straight from discovery into "So, I have this program …," which makes everything

before it feel like a setup. Or we wait, hoping they'll ask what we offer. That question almost never comes.

Take the turn yourself, out loud, and open it by appreciating their honesty: "I appreciate you being so honest with me." It's appreciation, not thanks. They're here because they want help.

Then recap. This is where the gap is established as the basis of the call: you hand someone back their point A, their point B, what's in the way and what it's costing them, in the words they used.

> SAY IT LIKE THIS
>
> "Here's what I'm hearing. It sounds like your biggest challenge today is [their challenge]. And what you want is [where they want to be], but [what's in the way], and it's costing you [what's at stake]. And that's what made you want to reach out and ask for help. Did I get that right?"

Fill every blank from the margin of your notes page, so the decision ahead of them rests on what they said.

Then listen to the yes. You're waiting for an emphatic one, the kind that sounds like *yes, you get me.* A flat yes means discovery missed something, so don't pitch on it. Ask, "Anything I missed there?" and let them fill it in.

Diagnosis, certainty, permission

With that yes, tell them what you see, the way a doctor does when the symptoms are in: "Here's what I think is going on, and here's why." Name the root cause in a sentence or two, built only from what they've told you, and stop before the how.

Stopping there keeps the gap open. In the lovely version of her call, your reframe handed her the how, and closed it (Chapter 1).

Check the diagnosis straight away, because a pitch is a dialogue: "How does that land for you?" If it doesn't land, ask what you've missed before you build anything on it.

Once it lands, give them the good news and ask: "That's definitely something that I can help you with. Would you like me to show you how it works?" I ask rather than suggest, because I want someone to feel they're re-enrolling in the conversation as we go.

Say it plainly, as a professional's view of the fit. You're the cool, calm, collected one on this call, and the person on the other end should be more excited than you are.

The pusher can't wait that long. "You're the perfect fit for my program," he says, before they've heard a word about it. Their guard goes up, because they're thinking, *I don't even know what this is yet.*

Then comes the promise: fully booked in three months, the money made back for certain. Every piece of it is the seller wanting the yes, and people feel that more than they hear any of it.

Your certainty is about the fit and the path, not the outcome. I can't promise the people in my programs that they'll have clients at the end, because so many factors influence that. If I said I could, I'd be lying.

What I can do is show someone what's possible and connect my work to it as a pathway. Say you help people with chronic pain.

> SAY IT LIKE THIS
>
> "My work is a pathway to reducing your pain, so it doesn't control you anymore. I can't promise you'll be pain-free at the end of this. But I can say that if you show up and do the work and apply what we talk about, there's a pretty good shot you'll feel a lot better on the other side than when we started."

It names the outcome they want and claims no control you don't have. You can talk about the outcome without promising it.

Designing it with them

Sometimes the right offer doesn't exist until the call. For many one-to-one sellers, it's built with the person.

On a full call, most of that building happens in your head as you listen: where this person is now, where they want to be, and what vehicle will get them there. Out loud, it's no more than a preference check or two inside a pitch that stays short. Sometimes a short assessment call comes first, and the offer takes shape on the full call after it.

Not long ago, a woman reached out to me, and we started with a short assessment call, about 20 minutes. I took a look at her business and said, "Here's what I think is going on. Would you like some more help with this?" She said yes, so we booked a second conversation to design that help together.

In that conversation, it was clear she didn't need a six-month coaching offer. What she needed was focused attention, and help getting clear on who she was serving and on her message. She had a lot of experience in business, and I could see that two one-to-one sessions, with support from me between them, would be enough. So I built her that offer on the spot.

In the past, I sold everyone the same thing, until I realized it worked for some people and not for others.

I learned much of this design conversation from Cole Gordon, and it suits a particular stage. If you sell one-to-one and your business is under about $10,000 a month, design the offer with the person. Past about $20,000 to $30,000 a month, the custom offer becomes a bottleneck, so sell a fixed one and fit it to each person by what you leave out.

Before the call, make a one-sheet: what you can deliver, the channels you deliver it through, the lowest hourly rate you'll take and your non-negotiables. As you build on the call, check how they'd like the help to reach them: "I'm curious how you feel about in-person work." You're assembling the offer from ingredients you already know how to deliver. Because they've watched you fit it to them, they feel you're on their team.

How much help they need stays your call. It's still one prescription, said with the same calm certainty as any fixed offer: "Based on what you've shared with me, here's what I think you need to solve this."

Is your offer easy to say yes to?

If your offer is hard to explain simply, the problem often isn't your pitch. It's the offer itself, and that's hard to see when you're the one selling it.

If you want help shaping an offer people want to say yes to, book a free 20-minute business assessment call with me. We'll take a personal look at what you're selling and figure out what needs to shift.

BOOK YOUR FREE ASSESSMENT CALL

Short wins

Discovery stretched the rubber band. The pitch is the release, and a release is quick.



THE SEVEN · 4 OF 7

The pitch: simple, brief and compelling, presenting the offer as the bridge to what they want.

Keeping it short is hardest for the pleaser, for the kindest of reasons. After all that holding back, you're finally allowed to help, and the relief comes out as a tour of how each piece works. In the lovely version, it ran 10 minutes, module by module.

It's generous. It also hands over part of the crossing for free, and buries the bridge under its parts.

One of the biggest mistakes I've made over the years is spending too long on the pitch. Pitch for five minutes and someone stops seeing a pathway to what they want, and starts seeing a pile of pieces: the bridge's color, what it's made of, the view from the middle. When I'm on the receiving end, I'm thinking, *I just want to get to the other side.*

Before the call, build three or four steps. I call them pillars. They're only scaffolding: enough structure for someone's rational mind to relax, and a little more for someone who loves detail. Any step discovery gave you nothing for stays out, because without their words in it, it sounds like your program, not their path.

Name each step where they are, not ten steps ahead, and give it a *so that*, because features tell and benefits sell. It's the difference between saying "I'm going to teach you marketing" and talking about clients who can pay you thousands of dollars. You sell the outcome they want and deliver what they need inside it.

Say where a step will be hard, too. That honesty is part of why they'll believe the rest: "This is maybe going to bring you into areas that might feel a little bit uncomfortable for you."

Said aloud, the whole thing takes a minute or two, and each step is a sandwich: what they told you, what you'll do about it, what changes for them.

> INSTEAD OF "You get twelve sessions, a workbook and …"
>
> SAY "Remember how you told me [X]? In step one, we …"

The first could be handed to anyone. The second is built from one person's words.

After a step, ask, “What difference would that make for you?” When they tell you why it matters, they’re selling themselves, which is always the best way to sell.

Keep most of it on their A to B and a little on how, because the more you tell people about your process, the more objections you create. The logistics need so little room that I forgot them on the practice call from the last chapter, too, and the pitch still landed. Drop them in once, mid-pitch: “Over twelve weekly calls together, we’re going to be focusing on this.” Then get back to their future self before they start thinking about calls and worksheets and homework.

Keep the money out of the pitch: no price, plan, guarantee or bonus. Pitch live, too, never in a deck or a proposal, because more information is the last thing they need.

Then hand it back: “I’m happy to answer any questions you have about how that all works.” From here, your answers get shorter, not longer, with no selling inside them, because every extra detail is one more thing to worry about.

When a question seems to stand for a bigger one, ask, “Just curious, is there a specific reason you asked that?” or note it and come back to it before the number. If their first question is the price, ask for their process questions first.

By the end, you’ve left out the weeds of how, the modules, the excitement, the promise and the money. What’s left is one diagnosis, one prescription and their own words.

TRY THIS

From your notes on the last person you pitched, write your pitch as three steps, each beginning “Remember how you told me …,” with what you’ll do and what will change for them. Read it aloud against a timer, and if it runs past two minutes, cut the how first.

On the call

You tell her, "I appreciate you being so honest with me," and recap from the margin of your page.

"Here's what I'm hearing. It sounds like your biggest challenge today is that you're booked solid but you can't get ahead, because your prices haven't moved since you opened. You're doing notes most evenings, you're tired, and you're short with your kids. And what you want is a practice that pays you properly in four days a week, with your evenings back. You worked out that $25 more a session is more than $30,000 a year. But twice you've drafted the email to raise your prices, and never sent it. The lease is up in two months, and if another year goes like this, you might end up back at the clinic. That's what made you want to reach out and ask for help. Did I get that right?"

"Yeah … I guess."

"Anything I missed there?"

A pause. "It's not just the money. If I put my prices up, I'm scared they'll all leave."

You add it, in her words, and ask again.

"Yes. That's exactly it."

"Okay. Here's what I think is going on, and here's why. It isn't your skill, and it isn't demand: you've been booked solid for over a year. Your prices haven't moved because raising them feels like risking everyone, so the email stays a draft. How does that land for you?"

"That's it."

"That's definitely something that I can help you with. Would you like me to show you how it works?"

"Yes, please."

Unlike the woman who needed two sessions, she has three things to change, and her new price has to hold through her clients' replies, so you prescribe six months.

"Okay. Remember how you told me you set your prices when you opened and you've never touched them? In step one, we work out what your work is worth and set your new price from that, so that you know exactly what

you're raising your prices to, and why. What difference would that make for you?"

"It would be a relief."

"Remember the email you've drafted twice, and the fear that they'll all leave? In step two, we plan the conversation with your current clients, what you'll say and how you'll answer whatever comes back, so that the email finally goes out. Some of those replies won't be easy to read, and you won't be reading them on your own. I'm curious how you feel about being able to message me while they're coming in."

"That would help."

"We'd work together for six months, with weekly calls to begin with and messages in between.

"And remember how you said you want a practice that pays you properly in four days a week? In step three, we rebuild your week around those four days, so that your evenings are yours again.

"I'm happy to answer any questions you have about how that all works."

"So what does it cost?"

"Yeah, I'm happy to answer that in a moment. Before we get there, do you have any questions about the process and how it all works?"

She thinks. "How much time does it take each week?"

"Our call, and some time between calls to put what we've agreed into practice."

You notice the question. It may stand for a bigger one, and you'll come back to it before the number.

"And is it all on video?"

"The calls are, yes."

She has no more questions. She's already asked about the price.

She doesn't need to know what the bridge is made of. She needs to believe it reaches her evenings.

IN SHORT

- **The pitch:** simple, brief and compelling, presenting the offer as the bridge to what they want.
- Recap in their words until you hear an emphatic yes.
- Diagnose without the how. Be calmly certain, and name the outcome without promising it.
- Design it with them where that fits; it's still one prescription.
- Short wins: their A to B, not your process.



PART FIVE

The edge of the decision

What do I do when they hesitate?

CHAPTER FIFTEEN

One offer, one number

"You don't let people buy more than they need, but you also don't let them buy less than they need."

AFTER THE PITCH, the first big drop, the track climbs again, and this climb has a number on it. This is where people need you most.

The last three of the seven live here: the offer, objections and the next step. They come in an order, and it helps to know it before you're standing in it.

You make one offer and say its number. Unless the first thing they say is yes, you don't take it at face value. You set it to one side and ask whether they're sure this is right for them, and when they say yes, you check once more.

Only then, and only if money or a payment plan has come up from their side, do you talk through the logistics. You don't raise a plan yourself. Then you ask for the decision, take the payment while you're both still on the call, and book their first session before you say goodbye.

Not every call ends there. When the decision genuinely can't happen on the call, it ends with a call booked to make it, before you hang up. And sometimes it ends in a clean no. Whatever someone says at the edge, those are the only three endings worth having.

It starts the moment a number has to come out of your mouth.

• • •

Her questions have run out, and most of the work of this call is done. She's told you what she's living with and what she wants instead, she's heard it handed back in her own words, and she's seen a way across. But she's asked one question you still haven't answered.

For most of us, it's the moment we've been dreading since hello: the number.

In the lovely version of this hour, the number had nothing to stand next to. This time it has everything she's told you.

The dread makes it feel bigger than it is. This moment asks for one clear offer, one plain number, and then silence. None of that is complicated. What's hard is staying steady through all three while the person across from you looks uneasy, and that steadiness is what lets her trust the number.

She asks again. "So what does it cost?"

Before the number, if it helps

Once the number is on the table, the dynamic on a call shifts, and an honest, open conversation about how it's all feeling gets much harder. So when someone asks about the investment, or their questions run out, I often check first where they are, with a question I learned from Cole Gordon, called a temperature check.

It's a tool, not a rule, and I use it when it helps. In full, it sounds like this.

> SAY IT LIKE THIS
>
> "Money aside, how's the process feeling for you on a scale of 1 to 10, 10 being, this is exactly what I need to get to where I want to be, and 1 being, screw you, I want to hang up the phone?"

Ask it in a neutral tone. Most people laugh at the last part, and the laugh is part of how it works: it keeps a heavy moment light enough to answer honestly.

Below 7, it isn't a fit, so there's no price, only a kind exit (Chapter 18). From 7 to 9, curiosity is the move: find out what's holding them back, address it, sweep for anything else, then ask for their score again. Even a 10 gets one question, because a 10 with nothing said can hide something: "Any concerns you have?"

With her, you use the short form.

"Yeah, we can definitely talk about the investment. I guess before we get there, in terms of the process itself, how is this all feeling for you on a scale of 1 to 10?"

"Probably an 8."

An 8 sounds close enough, and it's tempting to take it and say the number. That's how so many calls turn weird and uncomfortable at the end: someone was a 7 out of 10, and we bulldozed through to the investment.

"What's holding you back from feeling more like a 10?"

"Honestly? The time. I'm already doing thirty sessions a week, and notes most evenings. I don't know where I'd fit it."

"So it's whether there's room for one more thing. Is that what it is?"

"Yeah."

The reflection is right. It's the question she asked during the pitch, now standing between her and a 10. A practical worry gets a straight answer first: the real hours, with nothing shaved off to make them sound easier.

"That makes sense. Realistically, it's about an hour on our call each week, and an hour or two between calls putting it into practice. And step three is about giving you your evenings back."

What you don't do is start rearranging her calendar. That would be coaching, and it belongs inside the work, not before the number. With the facts in front of her, you ask one question, built from something she told you earlier.

"You told me most of your evenings already go to notes. What happens to them if nothing changes?"

A pause.

"They stay gone."

"How does that land for you?"

"That's why I'm here, I suppose."

You haven't found her the time. You've told her what it takes, and reminded her why she came.

Then the sweep, so nothing else is left under the surface.

"If we look at the process itself, the three steps we talked about, is there anything else that's feeling like, I'm not totally sure this is aligned for me?"

"Just nervous, I think."

"What specifically are you nervous about?"

"It's a big step."

A vague nerve can stand in for a specific fear, and she named one at the recap. So you check, once.

"Is that the fear of them leaving, or something else?"

She thinks about it. "No, I think step two covers that. For now, anyway. I just get nervous before big steps."

"Good. I'd expect you to. Everyone on the edge of a big leap feels that."

She smiles. Nerves like hers usually mean it matters, so you don't argue her out of them. You let them be normal.

"Cool. I'm glad we got to explore all of that. Just curious, how are you feeling now on a scale of 1 to 10?"

"A 10."

"Any concerns you have?"

"No."

You don't always need the scale. Once you've run a lot of calls, a plain question in your own words is fine, as long as it still asks for concerns.

The back half of a call has several checks like this, and more come after the number. Each has its own job, so one good answer here doesn't settle the rest.

One offer

Before you say the number, be sure what it's the price of. There should only ever be one answer.



THE SEVEN · 5 OF 7

The offer: one clear offer, with the price stated.

One clear offer means one prescription. You always want to pitch only one thing. Multiple options are like death on a sales call. The moment there's a menu, you stop being the person who diagnosed the problem and become someone trying to sell them something.

The menu usually comes from a kind place. Laying out three packages and asking, "Which one feels right to you?" feels respectful, the opposite of pushing. But someone came to you for a diagnosis, and a menu leaves them to write their own prescription.

The one offer you make is the one that gets someone where they told you they want to be, and that cuts both ways. When they need less than your biggest program, that's what you prescribe. When they ask for less than they need, a session or two, or a single piece, go back to their own words about the problem and the goal, and ask whether that's still true.

Someone who wants to drive from Los Angeles to New York needs four wheels on the car. So tell them plainly: "I'm not going to sell you a car with one wheel if you need four wheels to get to the destination." I'd rather not make the sale than sell someone something that won't get them there.

Sometimes nobody has to ask for less, because we've already shrunk the offer to whatever we guess someone can afford. Don't. Deciding that for them takes the choice away.

If a shorter option is on their mind, or on yours, be honest that it exists and still prescribe the one thing: "I do have shorter programs. But honestly, based on what you've shared with me, I don't think one would serve you. Here's what I think you need."

Reaching for the shorter program is usually more about us than about them. A smaller, different offer comes only after a clear no (Chapter 18).

For her, the offer is the six months you've just walked her through: one thing, sized to what she told you she needs to change.

Not sure your offer or your price is right?

Selling from a menu of options, or quietly shrinking your offer to what you guess people can afford, costs you clients and money. Both are easy to miss in your own business.

If you want help getting to one clear offer at the right price, book a free 20-minute business assessment call with me. We'll take a personal look at your offer and figure out what needs to shift to bring more clients in the door.

BOOK YOUR FREE ASSESSMENT CALL

One sentence

When you say the number, say it in one sentence.

> SAY IT LIKE THIS
>
> "Okay. So, the investment for everything we spoke about today is [X]."

"For everything we spoke about today" ties the number to the change they've just described, not to you or your sessions. By the time you say it, the number should already have somewhere to live, beside the numbers they gave you. For her, that's the more than $30,000 a year she worked out aloud in discovery, and the phrase points straight back to it.

Investment, never *cost*. A cost is a $3 latte: you drink it, and it's gone. An investment gives you something back, and the word moves someone's attention from what they're giving up to what they're getting.

Make it one exact number, never a range. Say it from the certainty you settled before hello (Chapter 10), in the tone you'd use to tell someone, "The meeting is at 2 p.m." How you sound when you say it is their first evidence of whether it's fair. If you flinch, they flinch.

TRY THIS

Say your price out loud, on your own, in that one sentence, with your real number in it. Then say it again, flatter. Keep going until it sounds like the time of a meeting, with no rise in your voice and no "but" waiting behind it.

When you've said it, stop.

The moment after the number is where both the pleaser and the pusher show themselves, because it's when the seller's need is loudest. Someone hears it, goes quiet, maybe winces, and something in us can't bear to leave them there.

The pleaser fills the quiet. Before the other person has said a word, we're mentioning the payment plan, listing everything that's included, apologizing for the number. Every word is meant to make the number easier, and every word tells them it's a problem.

I used to be that seller. When someone asked a question after my number, I'd want to hop in and save the sale. That convincing, needy tone is one of the things that has changed in the way I sell. Now I can notice the pull when it comes.

The pusher uses the moment instead: a deadline that wasn't there a minute ago, a guarantee nobody asked for, a little push toward yes while the person is still off balance. It can pass for confidence, but it comes from the same need as the pleaser's, only louder. A discount for deciding today is the same move, and I'm not a fan of it. I never frame anything as a discount.

The leader says the number and stops. Nothing is added, and nothing is decided for her: not what she can afford, not whether she'll need a plan, not how she ought to feel about it.

Everything the pleaser and the pusher add is a way of ending the discomfort sooner, their own as much as hers. The leader lets it run, which is harder. Once you've said it, you'll be sitting across from someone you've come to care about over the last hour, and she may look uneasy. Every instinct you have as a helper will tell you to do something.

Here, doing nothing is the help. It treats her as a capable adult who can look at a number and decide what it's worth to her.

"Cool, so you want to talk about the investment and what it looks like?"

"Yes."

You take a breath, and you say it.

"Okay. So, the investment for everything we spoke about today is $9,000."

The silence

The silence after the number isn't dead air. It's the person deciding.

I say the number, and then I shut up, because of what's happening on the other side. The moment someone hears the number, their amygdala fires up, that little lizard brain, and it goes, *Whoa, whoa, whoa. This is too expensive. I want to run away.* Fight or flight kicks in, cortisol spikes, and for a while the rational, logical part of them goes offline.

If you start talking then, you're not talking to them. You're talking to their lizard brain, and it just wants to run away.

If they react with "That's a lot," I stay quiet, or say only, "Yep, that's the investment." If all they say is "Okay," I still say nothing.

I leave them alone, and most of the time they solve their own problem. Someone tells me it's too expensive, I leave space, and after a while they say, "Well … I guess I could take money from my checking account." It's amazing how many times that's happened to me.

Getting there on their own takes time. I let someone have the whole spike, settle, and come back closer to baseline before we talk. That usually

takes 30 seconds to a minute, sometimes longer. I've sat in silence for two or three minutes while someone felt into it and thought it through.

What I'm waiting for is a question, or the words that mean go: "Okay, how do we get started?" A question means they're thinking again and pulling the call forward themselves.

If they ask whether you're still there, tell them: "Yep, I'm here, just letting you work it out."

This is the frame at its hardest. Getting good at leading is subtraction, and here it is at its plainest: the number, and then nothing.

She doesn't answer.

Neither do you.

She looks down. Ten seconds.

Your pen is still. Twenty.

There's a payment plan you could mention. You don't.

Thirty. She breathes out.

Forty.

Then she speaks.

IN SHORT

- **The offer:** one clear offer, with the price stated.
- A temperature check is a tool: below 7, no price; 7 to 9, get curious; a 10 still gets "Any concerns you have?"
- One prescription, sized to what they need, never a menu.
- One sentence, "investment," one number.
- Then silence until they speak.

CHAPTER SIXTEEN

A person asking for help

"The most effective way to handle an objection is to ask a question."

"I CAN'T COMMIT RIGHT NOW, but I can commit in three weeks."

I hear some version of that at the end of a lot of calls.

It sounds perfectly reasonable. But the decision is close now, and this is when status-quo thinking comes up: the part of someone that would rather everything stayed as it is. They get right up to the edge of the fence, and something in them says, *I'm afraid. I don't want to make a decision.*

It rarely comes out in those words. It shows up in subtle ways, and three weeks is one of them. If someone's not ready, there's a reason.

I've talked to a lot of people who got that close and let fear make the decision for them. More time doesn't solve that problem.

So I don't take three weeks as final, and I don't argue with it. I explore it with questions, from their side of the table, until they reach a real decision, whichever way it goes.

At the edge, I stay steady and get curious about what's underneath.

What an objection is

When I see an objection, I see someone who's split. Part of them wants to do this, another part of their mind is getting in the way, and they're asking you,

as the coach, to help. An objection is good news. Someone who wasn't interested wouldn't bother giving you one.

Underneath the words, an objection is usually saying:

I'm interested, but I'm stuck. I need help.



THE SEVEN · 6 OF 7

Objections: explored, not just accepted.

Most objections are fear in disguise, and they're loudest at the edge, which is why three weeks can sound so reasonable. Most also trace back to a belief that didn't land earlier in the call, so preventing them beats handling them (Chapter 21). Some mirror something in the seller (Chapter 22).

Sometimes the split shows up as questions, one after another: how long each session runs, what happens if they miss one, what exactly happens in month three. Every answer makes room for another.

Behind them is a mind at the edge of a big decision, hunting for certainty. Why does it want certainty so badly? So it can feel safe.

Underneath every question is a simpler sentence: *I don't feel safe.* No detail about month three can give them that. However good your answers are, that part of the mind is never going to get on board.

They can't feel month three. They can feel you, and whether you sound sure.

Sales is a transference of certainty.

Stay steady, and they can borrow your certainty. Speed up and pile on detail, and they borrow your doubt instead.

So answer a few, briefly and without hurry. Then name the pattern kindly, and ask what's really holding them back.

> SAY IT LIKE THIS
>
> "It makes sense that you have all these questions. Can I be honest with you? I've been on the other side of these conversations too, and my mind runs a million times a minute looking for certainty. It's normal. I want to get clear on one thing, though. What's holding you back from being 100 percent certain that this is the right next step for you?"

It tells them the questions are normal, then trades a dozen of them for the one that matters.

Questions, not rebuttals

I hate the phrase *overcoming objections*. It puts you in an adversarial relationship: they're over there, you're over here, and you need to overcome them.

It's easy to slip into. An objection lands, something in you tightens, and you jump straight to the rebuttal. That's one of the biggest things I've screwed up. Instead of feeling heard, people feel an opponent across the table, and they pull away fast.

So come around to their side of the table. Notice what happens in your body when it lands, take a breath, and agree with their view before you explore it: "Yeah, that makes sense." You're on the same team, working out what's best for them, including the possibility that this isn't it.

Exploring mostly means asking, and the question I lean on most is the shortest: "What do you mean?" Ask it, then stop talking. Often the objection unravels as they explain it, or the real one shows up underneath.

Agreeing with their view is fine. Stopping there isn't. Most of us agree with a line that sounds kind, and that line sends someone back to the edge alone.

> INSTEAD OF "I totally understand."
>
> SAY "What specifically concerns you about that?"

The first is meant kindly, and it leaves a vague worry vague. The second makes it specific, and a specific concern is one you can work on.

When someone says they need to feel into it, never tell them how to feel, however kindly. Make it safe, then ask: "That makes sense. It's a big decision, and it's important to me that it feels right for you. What specifically would you want to sit with?"

What someone told you before the number is usually their deepest truth. When what they say now doesn't fit, hand their words back as an honest observation and ask, "Is there something I'm missing?"

Sometimes a question isn't enough, and someone needs to see the barrier differently. My favorite reframe is one I learned, I think, from Taylor Welch: helping someone see that the thing they're treating as the reason to stop is the very reason to move.

Say someone asks, "How can I invest in a business before it's a business?" I'll say, "It's never going to become a business if you don't invest in it. That's the exact reason to invest in it now."

It doesn't work in every case, and I use it only when it's true for me. It lands only once someone has felt their gap, and only after you've asked about the concern, never as a comeback.

TRY THIS

Look back over your last few calls and write down the three objections you heard most, in the words people used. Beside each, write the belief that probably didn't land earlier, and the question you'll ask next time, before you answer anything.

Pacing the first objection

Certainty comes before logistics. Unless it's a yes, whatever someone says first after the price, don't answer it literally. This is a sequence I learned from Cole Gordon, who calls it pacing the first objection. It's the first thing I reach for once the number has landed, and most of the time it's the only tool I need.

On the practice call I recorded (Chapter 13), I named the number and let the silence run while she talked it out with herself. Then came her first question: "Do you have any payment plans?"

A lot of people ask that reflexively, and it's not actually real. What's really going on is *this feels uncomfortable for me*, and a practical question is a way to step out of it. Lay out the options, and most people hear the plan and say, "Okay, cool. I need to think about it."

I didn't know yet whether she needed a plan. First I needed to know whether she really wanted to do this, so I told her it depends, set the money aside and asked.

> SAY IT LIKE THIS
>
> "It depends. A lot of people take care of it up front. For some people it doesn't make sense based on where they are cash-flow-wise, so we'll look into splitting it up. But I guess the most important question I have is, financial logistics aside, do you feel 100 percent like this is the right next step for you, and that now's the right time to do it?"
>
> *If they're not sure:*
>
> "Okay. What's on your mind around that?"
>
> *If they say yes, the double check:*
>
> "So to be 100 percent clear, what I'm hearing is that you're in. There's nothing in you saying this isn't the right move. You just need a way to make it work financially."

She was in. Nothing was underneath, and the plan was just logistics. Most of the time, though, when I ask twice, something comes out.

You haven't dodged anything: plans exist, and now they know it. But the money waits behind the certainty question, so whatever comes out is the real objection. Explore it like any other, then ask again.

If they say yes, the double check sorts someone in a *should I do this* place, still going back and forth, from someone in a *how can I do this* place. Two yeses mean *how*. Only then do you turn to logistics.

Whatever they raise first, even "I can commit in three weeks," you agree, set it aside and ask the same question.

> SAY IT LIKE THIS
>
> "Yeah, that makes sense."
>
> *Then, for a partner:* "Partner aside, do you feel like this is the right thing for you, and that now's the right time?"
>
> *For a start date:* "Setting aside the date we get started, do you feel 100 percent certain that working together is the right thing to do?"
>
> *For* "It's too expensive"*:* "Money aside, are you 100 percent convinced the process is what you need to get to where you want to be?"

A yes straight after the number needs no pacing: stay calm and move to payment. A 10 earlier in the call doesn't excuse skipping it, because the price can bring up what the temperature check didn't. And if someone stalls after two yeses, name it: "You told me five minutes ago you were 100 percent in. What's coming up?"

Story or condition, and when to stop

Not everything at the edge is fear. Some of it is a wall, and you don't reframe a wall.

A story is something you can explore. A condition is something neither of you can change: genuinely no money and no access to credit, a decision truly shared with a partner, a deadline that can't be met whatever they do. A condition gets a kind exit or a booked decision call. Reframing it would only be pushing in better words.

Don't decide in advance which one you're hearing, and don't take a story at face value. If someone really doesn't have the resources, you can't create them. Most of the time, though, they do.

Pacing is how you find out. A real condition is still standing after two yeses: "I'm in. I just need to have that honest conversation with my partner." A story usually turns into not being sure, and you explore that.

How far to explore is the harder judgment. At the end of a call there's a dance between leaning in and leaning out, and it's tricky to feel. It took me a lot of calls to understand where the tension point is.

You don't want to keep badgering someone who's put up a boundary, but you don't want to say, "Okay, totally cool, let me know," at the first sign of resistance either. It's the line between challenging and pushing from Chapter 8, and it's never thinner than it is here.

Even when you do everything right, some calls end without a decision.

Stop at a real condition, at a clear no, or at the moment pressing on stops serving clarity. Short of those, when you're torn between honoring a boundary and exploring what's behind it, say so:

"Here's what I'm wrestling with right now. I want to honor your boundary, and I also know I've talked to a lot of people who get right up to the edge of the fence and let fear make the decision for them. I'm curious how that lands for you."

It names your dilemma, not their fear, and leaves the decision with them. Use it whenever you're not sure what to say next.

Sometimes I lean out on purpose. For someone who's been burned by a coach before, I'll say, "I don't want you to make a decision on this call, given what you've been through." We still book the decision call before we hang up, as on any call that ends undecided, because leaning out lets go of the outcome, never the hard question.

On the call

After the forty seconds, she's the one who breaks the quiet.

"Do you have a payment plan?"

You tell her it depends and ask the certainty question, financial logistics aside.

A long pause.

"Honestly? I'm not 100 percent."

"Okay. What's on your mind around that?"

"What if I put my prices up and everyone leaves?"

It's the fear she named at the recap, back now that the number is real.

"What do you mean?"

She tells you about the clients who've been with her since she opened, and how sure she is they'd go. You listen. You don't tell her it'll be fine.

"Can I share an honest observation?"

"Sure."

"You told me you've been booked solid for over a year. And you told me you've been saying 'next quarter' for a year. Is there something I'm missing?"

This quiet runs longer than the one after the number.

"It's the same fear, isn't it."

You don't answer it for her.

"Setting the money aside, where does that leave you?"

"I want to do this. I'm scared, but I want to."

"So to be 100 percent clear, what I'm hearing is that you're in. You just need a way to make it work financially."

"Yes."

She's been standing at the edge of that fence for a year, with the email in her drafts.

She wasn’t saying no. She was asking for help.

IN SHORT

- **Objections:** explored, not just accepted.
- An objection is interest asking for help.
- Ask, don’t argue: you’re on the same side of the table.
- Pace the first objection: certainty, then the double check, then logistics.
- Sort a story from a condition, and stop when it stops serving clarity.

CHAPTER SEVENTEEN

The ask

"After you ask for the decision, stop talking."

"SO, ABOUT THAT PAYMENT PLAN. Honestly, I'd need one. It's a stretch."

She has told you twice that she's in, and now she's back to the question she asked first. What's left is logistics, and logistics is where a lot of good calls come apart.

It's easy to stay steady through the number and the silence, then let go the moment the talk turns to how someone will pay. Money feels like the awkward, practical part, and nobody wants to be pushy about it. So out come the options, and the invoice to send tonight. Without meaning to, we hand back everything we've held for the last hour.

It isn't a decision until it's paid. So you sort the money honestly, ask plainly, and take payment on the call, while she's still connected to why she wants this.

Certainty first, then logistics

After two yeses, the plan someone asked about often turns out to have been a reflex. They tell you they can pay in full, and there's nothing to work out: "Cool, why don't we do this? Let's take care of it up front."

Sometimes, though, even after the double check, someone asks for a plan in the same breath as "I'm just worried it won't work for me." That's

fear dressed as logistics, and a split won't touch it. If I offer the split and someone starts the work still unsure they want it, I've done them a disservice.

So name it, as you would any stall after two yeses, and listen. Help with the fear before anything else.

Once you've talked it through, if the plan was only ever cover for the fear, offer a pay in full: "I don't think you need a payment plan. I don't think this is about payments at all, so I'm happy to do a pay in full." If a real stretch remains, that's a money question, and it gets a money answer.

THE POINT

A payment plan solves a money problem, never a commitment problem. It can make a yes easier to pay for. It can't make it a yes.

Her fear came out after the price, and she has said yes twice since. What's left is a real stretch, the kind a plan is for.

One plan, or none

In the lovely version of her call, you mentioned the plan before she'd said a word, so the number wouldn't frighten her. It was a kind thing to want. But it answered a question she hadn't asked, and skipped the one that mattered.

When she says the money is a stretch, that same kindness wants to make it easy for her: three plans to choose from, or money off the moment she winces. Both feel generous. But a menu hands back the leading she came to you for, and a lower price lowers the bar she was about to rise to.

What you're there to find is one plan chosen for this person, or none, or an honest no.

You get there through the money conversation: whatever follows when someone who's sure tells you they need a plan. It's either one simple split

that you name or, with permission, an open look at their numbers together. I learned the second from Cole Gordon, along with much of my payment-plan language.

If you're newer to selling, or you help people with personal change rather than business growth, keep it to one simple split. Once you have some calls behind you, and especially with business owners, the fuller conversation is open to you. Her call shows the fuller one, because she runs a business and the question is whether it can carry this.

If you're taking the split, it's one line, then one number.

> SAY IT LIKE THIS
>
> "Cool, we can split it up into three payments, to keep it simple."
>
> *Then the figure, once and flat, the way you said the price:*
>
> "Three payments of [X]."

That's one plan, named by you, for someone who's told you it's a stretch. If you hear instead that the money isn't there at all, don't name a split. That conversation starts with asking how they might make it work (Chapter 19).

Whichever way you go, paying in full stays the better deal. You're the one carrying the risk, so a plan typically costs 15 to 30 percent more, and it never runs past six months or past the end of the work itself. The terms are yours to set.

Reward paying in full in the same breath as the split: "If you wanted to do a pay in full, I'd love to include an extra bonus session for you." Or tell them paying in full gets your best rate. Never call it a discount.

Whatever you name, it has to be something they can carry. I don't want anyone stepping into my program from a place of scarcity. It doesn't set them up to succeed, and it makes good work together very hard. It's a lose-lose.

A closer look at the numbers

Some people find it invasive to ask about someone's money. I see it the other way around, as long as they've already said they're in. Someone who wants this but is tight on money is asking you to help them figure it out.

Looking at the numbers together is a form of care, and the clearest way to see whether there's a responsible path. It's a little more advanced, it takes a lot of leadership, and it starts with permission.

> SAY IT LIKE THIS
>
> "I appreciate you being honest with me about that. And there may be a pathway forward here with a payment plan, so we could split this up and make this a little easier on you. Since this is something you're wanting to do, how do you feel about having an open and honest conversation about where you're at financially? I'll ask you a couple of questions, we can crunch some numbers and see if we can create a pathway forward. And worst case, if it doesn't feel right, we could put together a game plan for you to do this down the line."

It asks before it pries, puts you on their side of the numbers, and makes the worst case safe to hear.

The questions are plain: what comes in each month and what goes out, what credit they can draw on, and what they have in savings. With a business owner, it's also what the business brings in and what they take home.

Listen for the number that doesn't fit. Now and then someone who says there's no money turns out to have savings they feel tense about touching, and that tension is the real conversation.

Then you prescribe one plan, or none. If the numbers say they can pay in full, tell them so, and let them step in all the way.

She says yes to looking at the numbers, and tells you what the practice brings in, what she takes home and what goes out each month. She has some credit available and some savings, which she calls her safety net.

"I don't want to touch that."

You don't ask her to. She hasn't told you there's no money, and the practice itself can carry three payments, priced 15 percent above paying in full. The credit is only a cushion. That's a stretch, not a reckless one.

"Based on where you're at, here's what I think we can do: three monthly payments of $3,450. Or if you'd rather pay in full, I'd love to include an extra bonus session."

You say it once, flat, and stop.

"Three payments. Okay."

Sometimes the numbers say no. If someone tells me they're making $2,500 a month, with $3,000 a month in expenses and no access to credit, I tell them plainly:

"Look, I don't see a pathway forward here right now. But I'd love to put together a game plan with you, so you can do this down the line."

A pause. "Okay. What would that look like?"

We talk through what would need to change and pick a date to look at the numbers again. The invite goes out before either of us hangs up.

Ask, then take payment

A lot of us have been taught that closing takes magic words. There aren't any. There's a plain question: "Hey, would you like to sign up and get started together?"

It sounds so simple, but there have been many conversations where I just didn't ask. Someone was ready and needed only a little nudge from me. Looking back over the years, I could have closed so many conversations simply by asking. Not asking usually sounds polite: "Well, let me know what you decide."

Once the double check has locked in their certainty, and the money is settled or there was nothing to settle, you ask.

The ask is a question, so there's no pressure in it: they can say yes, and they can say no. Then stop. Don't soften it, and don't tack on "but no pressure." Whatever silence follows is theirs to decide in.

The decision is the one thing you ask. Everything after it, you lead. Offering to send a link later only hands them a way to delay.

Taking payment is where a lot of us balk. Someone has just said yes, and asking for a card while they're still in front of you feels like grabbing. We'd rather give them the evening. I've messed this up myself.

> INSTEAD OF "I'll send you an invoice."
>
> SAY "Why don't we go ahead and run that first payment on the call here?"

The first is meant as a courtesy: time to think it over at home. But it moves the decision off the call and into an evening where the fear gets the last word. When someone has just said yes to themselves, there's a golden window before their ego comes back online and their fear talks them out of it.

If they've said yes, there's no pushing in it. Taking payment honors a decision they've already made, and lets them leave with a clear next step instead of limbo.

One morning, a woman on my call decided to sign up. Then she told me the credit limit on the card was smaller than the payment.

"That's cool," I said. "I've got about 15 minutes. Why don't you call your bank right now? Put me on hold, and we'll sort it out together."

So she put me on hold, and I waited while she called her bank.

It took about 10 minutes. Then she signed up, on the call.

If the card's in the car, it's the same move: "Okay, that's cool. Why don't you go grab that? I'll hang here."

Have the checkout page ready before the call, so the link is seconds away. Set it up with a proper card processor, not the app you'd use to pay someone for a secondhand couch. The money questions, firm terms, the line for terms you don't offer and local law on taking payment by phone are all in Appendix A.

And if reluctance shows up at the card, good: there's a reason for it, and now you can talk about it instead of pushing it off. Name it the way you'd

name an elephant in discovery: "Totally cool. I'm just curious, I'm sensing there might be something deeper holding you back from feeling 100 percent sure about this. Is there any truth to that?"

Someone who's in but wants to start in a few weeks puts down a deposit today: "You already know you're going to do this. So let's put down the deposit now." If an objection is hiding behind the later date, asking for the deposit brings it out.

With her, the money is settled.

"Hey, would you like to sign up and get started together?"

You don't add anything. You wait.

"Yes."

She's quiet for a moment.

"I want my evenings back."

You let that stand, then lead. "Why don't we go ahead and run that first payment on the call here, and get you on board?"

The link goes in the chat, and you stay on while she fills it in.

"It looks like it just went through. Congratulations."

After the yes

Meet a yes with a handshake, not a celebration: calm, certain, moving forward. The celebrating is theirs, and it's for tonight. Every word you say after a yes either steadies the decision or gives them something new to second-guess.

I know that second-guessing from the other side. I've felt it after investments of my own: you get off the call, and almost at once a voice says, *What did I just do? I've made a horrible mistake.* The ego flares up. What helps most is knowing exactly what happens next and where to reach the person you've hired.

I don't warn people the panic might come, though. Talking about it almost makes it more real, and whatever we focus on expands. I'd rather send them off to celebrate.

Sometimes it comes anyway. A new client gets in touch, scared, and asks to put it on hold. Call them fast, the same day if you can. A reply that leaves them waiting days, sent from somewhere defensive, lands like a subtle attack.

> SAY IT LIKE THIS
>
> "Maybe the best thing for us to do is pause, and if that's what's honestly best for you, then let's do that. And I also know you're here because on some level you want to create a change in your life, and it's normal for some stuff to be coming up as we take those next steps forward. So tell me a little more about what's been coming up for you."

The pause is offered for real. Then let them air it, and tell them it makes sense that this feels big before you say a word about the process. Most of the time, someone needs a little space to be heard, and then they're ready to go on.

What doesn't work is the rulebook, and I've reached for it myself at times: "This is the process. This is how you have to do it." It defends the process and never meets the part of them that's scared. Real hardship after signing is different from fear, and it gets a flexibility of its own: you can move a payment date without rolling over.

When remorse shows up at all, look first at the back half of the call. Usually it was rushed, so the yes came before someone was fully committed on the inside, and their fears never made it onto the table.

Hers did, every one of them. Even so, she laughs, a little shaky. "I'm nervous."

"I think it's totally normal. You're on the edge of making a big shift in your life. I'd be surprised if you weren't."

You book her first session for Tuesday while she's still on. You tell her what arrives from you later today: an email with everything she needs to start, and some homework before Tuesday. Tomorrow you'll text her to

make sure it all came through. Then you tell her to do something tonight to celebrate, and you stop selling.

• • •

Did you get the credit card?

This time, yes.

She decided.

IN SHORT

- A plan solves a money problem, never a commitment problem.
- One simple split if you're newer or sell personal change; the fuller money conversation, with permission, once you're experienced, best with business owners.
- One plan, six months or less, and paying in full rewarded with a bonus, never a "discount."
- Ask plainly, once, and let the silence after it be theirs.
- Take payment on the call, book the first session, and meet second thoughts with a fast, calm call.

CHAPTER EIGHTEEN

Paid, booked or no

"I'd rather come to clarity in this conversation, so we don't punt this down the line and waste your time and waste my time."

AT THE END of a live event, I'd just invited people into a group program of mine. In the questions afterward, a man said he'd be more inclined to invest if it had a roadmap for what he was building.

He was interested, and telling me what would make him more likely to buy. But I work with service-based business owners, and what he was building sat well outside that.

"I don't think I'm your guy for this," I told him.

I said there were better people to support him in what he was specifically doing, and that I didn't think the program would be the best next step for where he was heading. I wished I had a name to send him to.

At an event or on a call, that's the ending I want when the answer is no: clear, and kind.

A clear next step

Paid on the call, a decision call booked before you hang up, or a clean no: I'm fine with any of the three. I'm not fine with a call that ends in none of them.



THE SEVEN · 7 OF 7

The next step: a clear one, either a close with payment on the call, a booked follow-up, or a no.

The first is for a genuine fit who is certain: they decide and pay on the call (Chapter 17). The second is for someone who can't decide yet, for a real reason, and the third is for when the honest answer is no, whichever of you gives it. None of them needs a hard close. I don't believe in that, and a yes pressed out of someone tends to come back later, as second thoughts or a refund.

Before you hang up, you should be able to write one word in your notes: paid, booked or no.

The end of the call is where the old habits come back, because it's the one moment you have to ask for an answer, and the answer might be no.

For the pleaser in most of us, the habit is to hand the decision back. The hour has been warm, and a question that needs a yes or a no feels like it might spoil it. So instead of asking it, we say, "No pressure at all. Why don't you sleep on it and let me know?" It's meant kindly, and it ends the call without ending anything.

They never asked for more time. It's our own discomfort deciding how the call ends.

Booked call always wins

When someone says they need time, pace it first (Chapter 16), then find out what's in the way: "Just curious, what specifically are you wanting to think about?" Then talk through whatever comes back.

Sometimes what's left is real, and a decision genuinely can't happen on the call. There's a partner they make decisions with, or they've said everything on their mind and still need a day to sleep on it. And sometimes "I need time" is a polite no.

Telling the two apart is a judgment call, and a bit of an art. I explore until I start to feel someone putting up a barrier. If what's left is real, I book the call. If it feels like a smokescreen, I name it.

When it's genuine, I'm not the kind of person who's going to push and push and push beyond a certain point. But I don't let it go loose either. I've learned that one the hard way, many times.

A lot of us say, "Yeah, that's totally cool. Let's check in on Monday via email and see where things are." It sounds relaxed, even respectful.

And what happens? The deal drifts. One week turns into two. They don't get back to your email, and now you feel like you're chasing them.

Booked call always wins: get someone on the calendar before you leave the first call, or they drift.

Look at what each ending leaves you with. A no gives you both an answer. A booked call gives you both a date. Drift gives you neither.

A booked call has to mean something, though. A follow-up booked to get out of an awkward moment is only limbo with a date on it. Those are the calls people cancel or don't show up to, because the thing nobody named is still there.

So the words depend on which it is. For a polite no, offer two directions. For a real need, take out the "let me know" and the push, and what's left is a plain suggestion.

> SAY IT LIKE THIS
>
> *If what you're sensing is a polite no:*
>
> "Here's what I'm sensing. There are two directions we could go from here. We could book a follow-up and connect in a couple of days. Or, if in your heart of hearts this doesn't make sense, or it's not the right time, why don't we be direct with each other? That's totally okay too."
>
> *When a follow-up is right:*
>
> "So why don't we set aside some time to reconnect Thursday, and we can come to clarity on a decision. And if it feels like a yes, great, we can get you on board and get you enrolled. And if it doesn't feel like the right next step, totally cool, we can part as friends."

The two directions put the thing nobody has named on the table, and make a no as easy to say as a yes. The booking line gives Thursday one purpose, clarity, and names both answers out loud, so a no has somewhere to go.

Notice it never asks whether they'd like another call. Asking invites a no, and comes off a little needy. Naming a day and a time leads: "I've got Thursday at 2 p.m. available. Does that work for you?"

Send the calendar invite while you're both still on the call. Then: "Short of getting hit by a bus, will you let me know if anything comes up before that call?" It keeps things light and asks for a small, real promise to turn up.

One more line lets them off the hook: "Write down the rest of your questions, and we can knock them out on our next call." Nobody has to arrive with a final decision, only with what's still on their mind.

If a partner shares the decision, offer them a seat on that call too. Book it two or three days out where you can, and always within the week. Past that, it starts to drift.

TRY THIS

Your notes page has the six beliefs across the top. On your next call, however it goes, write one word at the bottom before you hang up: paid, booked or no. If you can't, go back to the last thing they said before it stalled and pick it up from there. Until you can write it, the call isn't finished.

The decision call

The decision call comes after a full first call, so it's short, about 20 minutes, and aimed at one thing: a decision. Not every second call is this one, because what a second call is for depends on how much discovery came before it. The others (after a market-research call, after a money hesitation or after a short assessment call) are in Appendix A, along with what to say if someone stalls again.

On Thursday, after a minute of warmth, recap where you left off and ask what's moved: "So last time we spoke, you mentioned you were having [this challenge], and [this] is what you wanted. And we talked about the roadmap to get there. Has anything changed since our last conversation?" If something has, you want to know it first.

The recap grounds them back in why this mattered, and that's all it needs to do. Then: "How are you feeling about things today?" Whatever they raise, ask what specifically, as you did the first time, and if the old hesitation is back, name it.

If it's a yes, ask plainly and take payment on the call. If it's a no, let it be a clean one. That's what I promise when I book it: "Even if that means no, we can at least walk away from that conversation clear together."

When a smaller offer is right

Sometimes the no is about money and only money: they want this, and the money conversation (Chapter 17) has found no responsible way into the full program today. Up to that point, I flex the payments, not the program.

Before you offer anything else, make sure money is all it is: "Okay. Finances aside, do you feel like working together is something you want to do?" A no means it was never the money. Don't shrink the offer to save the sale; let it be a clean no.

A yes leaves two honest answers: a dated plan to do the full program later or, if it genuinely makes sense, something smaller and different, like a shorter program or a one-month intensive. It's never a trial session to see if it works.

Offer it the way you offered the first: as one next step.

> SAY IT LIKE THIS
>
> "Okay. Here's what I think would be a better next step for you, based on where you are."
>
> *If it can't take them all the way, say so:*
>
> "I'm going to be honest with you. I think we can make some real progress. I don't think we're going to be able to get all the way to the goal you talked about earlier, but I'd love to support you in this next step."

It's a prescription, not a menu, and the second line names what it can't do, so it's never sold as the whole way there.

If someone says no to a deeper program and I know in my heart that something smaller won't be enough, I won't sell it to them. That would be doing them a disservice.

The clean no

A clean no is a good ending, and for most of us the hardest of the three to give or to take. It comes in two kinds.

The first kind is yours: don't pitch someone you can't help, or someone whose priority isn't there. Usually you'll know before the pitch, often within the first 25 minutes, so pause the call there and say it rather than pitching to be polite. Below 7 on the temperature check, give no price: go straight to the kind exit.

The second kind is theirs: a no they bring you, at the end of the call or on Thursday. Either way, the words are short.

> SAY IT LIKE THIS
>
> *If the no is yours:*
>
> "Can I be honest with you? I don't think we're going to be a good fit."
>
> *If you know somewhere better for them:*
>
> "Based on where you're at right now, I don't think working together is going to be the best next step for you. But here's where I would go …"
>
> *If the no is theirs:*
>
> "I respect that. I'd rather have a clear no than a slow fade. If anything changes down the road, I'm here."

Whichever kind it is, close warmly: "Glad we got to clarity. I'm rooting for you."

After their no, one question is worth asking: "Can I ask what made it a no? Not to change your mind, just to understand." Then take the answer as it comes, without reframing it.

Keep your own no brief. At that event it took me a few sentences. I've been in the long, drawn-out version of this conversation, and I wouldn't

recommend it. The moment you start explaining why, you invite more conversation, so end it like a good breakup: clean and quick.

Don't make one more try, and don't go quiet either: silence after a no tells someone you were only ever interested in them as a sale.

A clean no serves them better than a maybe. They leave with an answer they can act on and their attention free for whatever they choose instead. So do you. A maybe would have cost them weeks of carrying the question, and very likely the same conversation later, from exactly where they are today.

Before we'd finished talking at that event, a name came to me: someone I know whose work sits much closer to his. I told him they'd be a really good person to talk to, and offered to introduce them personally.

The best next step I had for him wasn't mine.

IN SHORT

- **The next step:** a clear one, either a close with payment on the call, a booked follow-up, or a no.
- Book the decision call before you hang up, and make a no safe.
- The decision call still aims for a decision, even a no.
- A smaller offer only after a clear no, only when money is the blocker, and only if it still helps.
- A clean no is a good ending, for them and for you.

CHAPTER NINETEEN

The objections you'll hear most

"An objection is not a rejection."

THE PHYSICAL THERAPIST'S CALL WENT WELL. One fear came up, the two of you looked at it, and she paid before you hung up. Plenty of your calls won't go that cleanly, so let's go back to the moment just after the price, when someone tells you why they can't.

A while back, about 45 minutes into a sales call, the man I was talking to said it flat out: "Man, it sounds great. I don't have the money. I can't do this."

I got curious and started asking him questions, and it became clear he had a credit card with room on it.

The card didn't make it a yes. It only told me money wasn't what stood in the way. What he didn't have yet was certainty, so I asked about that.

"Okay. Well, you have a credit card. So if you were fully convinced, in your heart of hearts, that this was a good investment, then you have the resource to be able to do it. So what's holding you back from feeling 100 percent that this would be a solid investment for you to make?"

We had that conversation, I offered him a different way of looking at it, and he signed up before the call ended. This was a man who had told me he did not have the money.

Story or condition? That one was a story, and the only way to find out was to get curious.

Four objections come up more often than any others. Each usually means something more specific than its words. Whichever comes first after the price, you start the same way, with pacing: set it aside and ask the certainty question.

Then it's usually one more question, and if that doesn't land, their own words from earlier, handed back. Each can also be headed off earlier in the call. The rarer ones are in Appendix C.

"It's too expensive"

Usually it isn't about money. It's about value, priority or trust: right now, the number looks bigger than what it's for. Sometimes it is a real limit.

Here the certainty question, money set aside, is the whole first move. Only after two yeses do you sort out the money.

Say you're a consultant. In discovery, the woman on your call told you her referrals dried up last spring, and worked out what that's costing her each month.

"It's too expensive."

"Totally fair. Money aside, are you 100 percent convinced the process is what you need to get to where you want to be?"

"I don't know. Maybe not 100."

"What do you mean?"

"It's a lot of money right now."

"Yeah, I get that. If you don't see this creating substantially more value than the investment, I wouldn't do this either. Do you mind if we take a closer look at that for a second?"

"Sure."

"Earlier, you worked out what losing those referrals is costing you each month. Over the next year, what does that add up to?"

She works it out. You say nothing.

"More than this."

"Setting the money aside again, do you feel this is the right next step for you?"

"Yes. I want to do it."

"So to be 100 percent clear, what I'm hearing is that you're in. You just need a way to make it work financially."

"Yes."

"And when you say it's too expensive, is it more that the money isn't available right now, or that it would be a stretch?"

"It's a stretch. Do you have a payment plan?"

The number that changed her mind was her own.

If it hadn't, the next question would have been, "What specifically would you need to believe or see for this to feel like an obvious investment?" That usually brings out the doubt about whether this will work for her, the last of these four.

Once someone is certain, one question does the sorting: is the money not there right now, or is it a stretch? Sometimes it turns out they can make it work, and you go straight to payment. Otherwise you'll hear *it's a stretch and I need a payment plan*, or *I literally don't have the funds*, and those are two completely different conversations. A plan is something they ask for, never something you volunteer.

Hers is a stretch, so now you're in the money conversation (Chapter 17). If the number still feels big once there's a responsible path, I'll say, "Of course it feels stretchy, and that's exactly the reason you need to do this." Say it only if you believe it.

If the money isn't there, don't decide for them that they can't find it. The man with room on his card had said the same. Ask as someone who believes they can: "I hear you. You want this, and I know you're creative and resourceful. How do you feel you might be able to get the funds to do this?"

Then, with permission, have the money conversation. If there's no responsible path, say so, and put a date in the calendar to look again.

Never argue with the number, or answer it with a cheaper offer. A smaller offer comes only after a clear no (Chapter 18).

INSTEAD OF	"It's actually not that expensive because …"
SAY	"What do you mean when you say it's too expensive?"

The first argues, and puts you on the other side of the table. The second asks, after the certainty question, never instead of it. It's the "What do you mean?" you asked her, made specific.

Prevent it in discovery by landing what the gap is worth to them and what it's costing them, in their own words.

"I need to think about it"

Most of us hear this one as a kindness and answer with one of our own: "Of course. Take all the time you need." It's almost never about thinking. It's about not feeling clear enough to decide.

It's fog.

Underneath, there's usually a gap or an urgency they never quite felt, something they haven't said, or a part of them that doesn't feel safe enough to say it. Sometimes it's genuine, and they do need time.

Once you've paced it, ask what specifically they want to think about. The answer shows you what needs clarity, or shows them how they're getting in their own way.

Say you're a life coach, and early on the man on your call told you he's been stuck for two years, thinking about doing this.

"I need to think about it."

You set the thinking aside and ask the certainty question. He isn't sure.

"Totally cool. Just curious, what specifically are you wanting to think about?"

"I just need to sit with it."

It's the same fog. As his advocate, you ask permission before you hand him back his own two years.

"Can I share an honest observation?"

"Go ahead."

"You told me early on in our conversation that you've been thinking about this for the last two years. Are we going to do another two years of this? Tell me what's on your mind."

A long pause.

"I don't think I want to do it. Not now. It's a no."

"I respect that. I'd rather have a clear no than a slow fade. If anything changes down the road, I'm here. Can I ask what made it a no? Not to change your mind, just to understand."

"When I say it out loud, it's not what I want to put first right now."

You don't reframe that, argue with it or offer him something smaller.

"Glad we got to clarity. I'm rooting for you."

He leaves with his answer, and so do you. Two more years of thinking would have cost him more than the no.

Telling a real need for time from a polite no is a judgment call. I keep exploring until I feel someone putting up a barrier, and then I look at what's left. Someone who has said everything on their mind and still needs a night to sleep on it gets a decision call, booked before you hang up (Chapter 18). Fog gets named.

Not the right time, or *after the holidays*, is usually the same fog with a date on it. Pace it with the date set aside, then bring back the stakes they named.

Say someone told you early on that they have six months of runway, and that if nothing changes they'll go back to a nine-to-five job. Now they want to wait a couple of months.

"Cool. We can definitely do that. But you told me earlier on in our call that you've got six months of runway to work with, and I'd love to help you get this moving so you don't have to go back to a nine-to-five. So we can hold off on this. But I'd rather see you moving forward more quickly."

It agrees that waiting is possible, hands back their stakes and says what you'd rather see, so the urgency is theirs. Six months of runway is a reason to move. No runway at all calls for an honest answer, never a push. And a later start that's genuinely right still gets its yes today, with a deposit.

Someone who feels their gap, and has told you why now, has less fog to clear at the end.

TRY THIS

Take one person who stalled on a recent call. Find something they told you in the first 10 minutes, in their exact words. Write the question that hands it back, starting "You told me earlier …," and say it aloud until it sounds like care, not a point scored.

"I need to talk to my partner"

Some people make their decisions as a team, and from them this means exactly what it says. From others it's a smokescreen: someone telling you, without quite telling you, that they have doubts.

Even when it's genuine, it's fragile. Sent home unequipped, someone shares a watered-down version, their partner asks practical questions they can't answer, and the whole thing deflates.

So pace it, with the partner set aside, and ask twice. A smokescreen turns into "not sure," and you explore it like any other doubt. A genuine one gets your respect and your help with the conversation at home, so a joint decision stays joint.

> SAY IT LIKE THIS
>
> "One question: if your partner is fully on board, are you in?"
>
> *If yes:*
>
> "Great. So the decision is about making sure they feel good about it. Can I help you with that conversation? What do you think your partner will want to know? Let's make sure you're equipped to answer their questions."

Say you're a relationship coach, and the woman on your call wants things to change between her and her partner.

"I need to talk to my partner first."

"Of course. Partner aside, do you feel this is the right next step for you, and that now's the right time to do it?"

"I'm not sure."

"What's on your mind?"

"The money, I think. It's a lot."

"Tell me more about that."

"And I don't know if it would even work for us. What if we put all this in and nothing changes?"

Under the partner was the money, and under the money, whether this would work for the two of them.

"What makes you unsure it would work for you both?"

"It only works if he's in it too. I can't decide that for him."

"If he's fully on board, are you in?"

"Yes. I want to do this. But it's for both of us, and I want him to hear it too."

"So to be 100 percent clear, what I'm hearing is that you're in, and you want him in on the decision."

"Yes."

"Great. So the decision is about making sure he feels good about it. What do you think he'll want to know?"

"Whether it'll work for us. And what it costs."

It's genuine. So you suggest a call on Thursday with him there, where he can put both questions to you himself, and you send the invite to them both before you hang up.

If you're protecting your time, put the price on your application, so the partner conversation happens before the call.

What you never do is push a genuine joint decision into a solo one.

“Will this work for me?”

This one is fear voiced as a question, and it deserves an honest answer: no reassurance, and no pretending there won’t be obstacles. Your first move is to reflect it back and ask where it comes from.

On the recorded practice call I told you about, the one where the woman playing my prospect asked about payment plans, she also asked how realistic her goal was. My first answer came down to “I believe you can do it.” Watching it back, I could see how weak that was.

When she asked how long it usually takes, I told her instead about a client who’d started at almost the same stage. That answer had weight. I can’t promise someone an outcome, or tell them they’ll get there in three months. I can tell them what happened for someone like them.

No client stories yet? Tell your own: the mistakes you made, and what you learned. Lean on how closely you’ll work together, and where the concern is risk, a first-session refund can answer it.

Say you’re a health coach, and the woman on your call has one question left.

“What if I do all this and it doesn’t work for me?”

“So it’s a fear of, what if it doesn’t work? Is that what it is?”

“Yeah.”

“I appreciate you being honest with me. Was there something specific that we talked about that you were concerned about?”

“I’ve done three programs, and nothing stuck.”

“What do you think got in the way?”

“I’d hit a hard week and quietly drop off. There was no one to tell.”

“Well, look, I want to be straight with you. It doesn’t always work exactly as planned, and there are going to be roadblocks and challenges. The people who break through still hit those snags, but they’ve got someone in their corner when they do. If we’re going to move forward together, what I’m going to ask from you is that trust and that commitment, and that means we’re together on the same team.”

“And if I do all that and it still doesn’t work?”

She's stopped asking whether it can work. She's asking what happens if it doesn't, and that's a specific concern about risk. This is where a guarantee belongs, shaped to that concern.

> SAY IT LIKE THIS
>
> "Well, I can guarantee I'll give you everything that you need. And if you feel I haven't delivered on that promise, let me know within the first month of working together, and I'll give you your money back."
>
> *Then what you ask of her:*
>
> "Are you 100 percent committed to showing up and doing the work?"
>
> "And if you hit a snag or a challenge, which I can guarantee you is going to happen, are you going to raise your hand and ask for help? Or are you going to bury your head in the sand and disappear?"

The second question asks for exactly what was missing the last three times.

She answers both: "Yes. I can do that."

Then: "This is what my successful clients do. They get off the fence."

"Okay. Let's do it."

My view on guarantees has softened a bit, but fear that's only fear doesn't need one. It needs something like "If you weren't feeling that, I'd be concerned."

A close cousin is *I can do it myself*, which means the help belief never landed. Prevent both in discovery, where the help question and the trust question let them tell you why not alone, and why you.

When it comes anyway, start with their own words: "Thirty minutes ago you told me you've been doing this for the past three years, and there's been no traction. Do you really feel this is going to shift if you do this on your own?" Then, if you have one, a true story.

I've been the one saying it won't work, and I put it in writing.

Early in my coaching business, the idea of spending money on a coach was crazy to me. When it came to hiring my first business coach, I was

scared out of my mind. It was such a slog getting through that sales process, because I had so much resistance. On the call I gave him every reason his program wasn't going to work for me, and afterward I even emailed him: "I don't think this is going to work, man."

His reply: "Dude, if we're going to do this together, you got to trust me."

I spent a week overthinking it, so focused on what it cost and what would happen if it didn't work out that I was completely blind to what it could give back over the next year, or two, or five. I almost talked myself out of it.

I decided to trust him, scared as I was, and it was one of the best decisions I've ever made in my business. Looking back, I laugh at how worried I was.

It changed what I believed. I used to think, *if I can figure it out myself, I'll do it alone.* Now I think, *if I can get in the room with someone who's further along than me, I'll do that any day.*

When I'm on a call with someone who's thinking about doing it alone, I tell them that story.

• • •

Some of the people who say these things will say yes before you hang up. Some won't. I didn't, with my first coach. It took me a week.

Every one of them is someone at the edge of something they want.

IN SHORT

- "Too expensive" is a certainty question before it's a money question. Then sort a stretch from no funds, and never volunteer a plan.
- "Think about it" and "not the right time" need a "what specifically?" then their own earlier words, and sometimes the honest answer is no.
- Respect a genuine partner decision, and equip them.
- Answer fear with honesty and a true story; a guarantee only for a real risk that's still there.
- Prevent each one upstream.

CHAPTER TWENTY

Between calls

"The offer is never the re-entry point. The relationship is."

A COUPLE OF DAYS after a sales call, I wanted to check in with the woman I'd spoken to. She'd been running her business for several years, and the year before, it had taken a real dip. On our call, it had become clear why: her market had shifted.

The usual message at that point is "Just checking in," and then you watch your phone.

Instead, I went looking for something that might help her, and found government statistics on her market. "Hey, I was thinking about you this morning," I wrote, and told her I thought the numbers explained a lot of what she was seeing.

When someone writes back to a message like that, I ask one question: "Side note, how are you feeling about our conversation?"

That's the best message I know to send between calls: something genuinely useful, used to open the door back up. It only reads that way when you don't need the reply.

When a call ends without a yes, some of us chase. More of us, the ones who would hate to seem pushy, disappear. Neither is leading. The frame I hold says I lead the call from start to finish, never chasing. The finish isn't when I hang up.

Not chasing, not disappearing

Chasing is message after message, each one asking, underneath, *have you decided yet?* It follows the yes instead of the person, and people can feel the need in it.

I've heard it from coach after coach: follow up a million times, because the money is in the follow-up.

A while back, I went through every client we'd worked with: who we'd followed up with, and how many times. Almost everyone who signed up did so with one follow-up or none. Past that, following up added next to nothing. And the few who signed only after repeated follow-ups were my hardest clients: less likely to have a great experience in the program, and more likely to ask for a refund.

I never felt good about chasing, and I still follow up more than I need to.

Drag someone through your sales process and you've set the expectation for how they'll engage once they're in. How someone buys is how they'll show up.

What turns a follow-up into chasing is where it comes from. If I notice any gripping or anxiety in me, I don't follow up.

Most of us know that place. They haven't replied, and we're counting: *has it been two days or three? What do I do?* Whatever we send from there is for us, not for them.

When I'm relaxed, it's different. I'm walking down the street, someone crosses my mind, I realize I haven't heard from them in a couple of days, and I shoot them a quick text to see where they're at.

So before you send anything, ask yourself: *am I okay, whatever this person does?* If the answer is yes, send it. If not, hold it until you are. Holding it isn't the same as never sending.

Disappearing is the gentler mistake, and it comes from a good place: *I don't want to bother them. If they want it, they'll get in touch.*

It's a story we tell ourselves to avoid the discomfort of being direct. Most people who buy decide within hours of the call, and nearly all within a week.

Stay politely quiet past that and you haven't spared them anything. You've left them in limbo with nobody leading them out.

The way between chasing and disappearing is a message worth opening, sent in the first week. You'll need one when you couldn't book a call, when someone goes quiet before the call you did book, or when the sale is happening in messages. If a decision call is already on the calendar (Chapter 18), that call is the follow-up. One message worth opening in the meantime is welcome, never required.

What to send

Every message between calls should add value, ask a clear question, or close the loop. "Just checking in" does none of them. It feels needy, it adds nothing, and underneath it says only *I want an answer from you.*

> INSTEAD OF "Just wanted to follow up."
>
> SAY "I've been thinking about what you said."

Send each one while the decision is still alive, and never let a proposal or more information stand in for the conversation (Chapter 5).

> SAY IT LIKE THIS
>
> *A day or two after, something useful to them:*
>
> "Hey, I was thinking about you this morning. I just saw [something specific to their situation] I thought you might find interesting. I think it explains a lot of what you're seeing."
>
> *Or, with nothing to share, their gap in their own words:*
>
> "Hey, I was thinking about what you shared about feeling stuck at the nine-to-five, and the fact that that's been going on for the last few years, and it stayed with me. I'm curious, how are you feeling about our conversation?"

> *After about a week of silence:*
>
> "Want to be respectful of your time, so I'll close the loop on my end. Sounds like the timing might not be right, and that's completely okay. If anything changes down the road, I'm here. Wishing you the best with [something specific they mentioned]."

The first is the text I sent her: it gives before it asks. The second reconnects them to why they got on the call. The third ends the waiting, warmly, for both of you.

Come in neutral, because excitement leaves no room for someone to bring you their hesitation. "Are you still interested?" sounds needy, and it gives someone no space to be uncertain. Asking how they're feeling does, and *I'm not sure* is something the two of you can talk about.

Have that conversation on a call, and book it the way you'd book any decision call, for a specific day and time.

When they go quiet, or don't show

Most ghosting is prevented on the call, by making a no safe to bring you. When someone misses a booked call, or keeps rescheduling it, they get one message that reconnects them to what they wanted: "Hey, were you still looking for some help with getting clients?"

Someone who keeps pushing a call down the road usually isn't ready yet. Once, the only slot available for a call was 5 a.m., and the woman I was talking to said, "I'll wake up early. I'll do whatever it takes." That's what ready looks like.

So after that one message, for the most part, I let them go. I've done my part by then, and the next move is theirs.

The door stays open

Inviting someone again later, with something new, isn't chasing. Scott Oldford makes offers all the time. Every two or three months he pitches me something new, and I'm thinking, *thank you for selling to me, because I want help.* I say no to a lot of it, yes to some, and we still have a really good relationship.

With people you already know, skip the small talk that only leads into a pitch. Someone who had a great conversation with you three months ago doesn't feel the gap today, so reopen the relationship, then their gap, before any offer.

I might write that I've been thinking about what they told me, that it had been a long time since they'd signed a client, and ask, "Are you still in that place today?" If they are, I say I have something that could help and ask whether they'd like to explore it on a call. Calls always convert better.

Not enough new people reaching your calls?

When too few new people are booking, every call starts to feel like it has to close, and that's when following up turns into chasing. The fix usually isn't the follow-up. It's your lead flow.

If you want help bringing more of the right people to your calls, book a free 20-minute business assessment call with me. We'll take a personal look at where your calls come from and figure out what needs to shift.

BOOK YOUR FREE ASSESSMENT CALL

A renewal is a new sale

The door works the same way for the people already working with you. A renewal needs a new gap the client can feel, usually the next place they want to get to, and finding it takes a call of its own.

At the end of our last session, we celebrate their biggest wins. Then I float one question, “Are you wanting to continue working together?” and leave it there. If they’re open to it, we book that call.

On that call, I run a shorter discovery toward their next point B, then prescribe one next step at my current rate. Sometimes I keep someone on their old rate, but I don’t build a cheaper custom deal to hold on to them. A text with the terms will do only when the new goal is obvious to both of you and the sale is already made.

TRY THIS

Go back through your last ten sales calls and mark each person paid, booked, no or limbo. For each one in limbo: if it’s been under a week, send one message that reopens their gap in their own words. Past a week of silence, close the loop. Months on, reopen the relationship and their gap before any offer.

A message between calls tells someone one of two things: that you're still thinking about them, or that you're waiting on them. My text to her said the first.

IN SHORT

- Following up is leading: neither chasing nor disappearing.
- One or two messages worth opening, in the first week, each reopening their gap or adding something real.
- Never "just checking in," and never from anxiety.
- Close the loop warmly, keep the door open, and have the real conversation on a call.
- A renewal is a new sale with a new gap, on a call.



PART SIX

The seller you become

How do I get good at this, and what if it still doesn't work?

CHAPTER TWENTY-ONE

Getting better

"The only way you learn how to not be needy is by being needy a bunch of times."

THE FIRST TIME YOU say the agenda to a real person, you'll hear yourself reading. You'll fill a silence you meant to hold, and you'll replay the call for the rest of the day.

How do you get good at this?

• • •

In college, I canvassed in New York City. I was one of those people with clipboards who stop you on the street to ask for money, and I'd stand out there for hours.

You get yelled at. You get rejected all day long, one person after another.

At a certain point it just becomes: *okay, it's no big deal.*

It was one of the best experiences I ever had, because it taught me so much about getting over fear.

The fear of your first sales calls fades the same way, call by call. Nobody is born knowing how to sell. You get good at this by doing calls, by practicing the hard moments out loud before you need them, and by reviewing each call against the seven, one change at a time.

Everyone bombs calls

I sucked at sales calls when I started. I stumbled through them, and on some I was needy and said things I still feel terrible about. I left so many calls thinking, *what just happened?*

One of the things that really helped me was recording my calls. I learned a lot from listening back. It wasn't comfortable. More than once, all I could think was, *oh my God, that was a train wreck.*

But it takes those calls to get you to *oh, I see. This is not the way.*

Then I did them again, and again, and again. It took a long time, and a lot of awkward, weird calls, before I felt I knew what I was doing. I'm still learning every day, and I still make mistakes on calls all the time.

If your early calls go the way mine did, you're right where you need to be. What slows you down is punishing yourself, because guilt and shame make it harder to learn.

After a messy call, change the sentence you say to yourself. Instead of *I failed*, try *these are some things I might do differently next time*, and name what went well, too. None of this is failure. These are tweaks and improvements.

Look back at a call the way you'd lead one: curious and detached, with no verdict on yourself.

The words, then the beliefs

There are two ways to get the words wrong. One is to wing it: hop on the call and go with the flow. With no agenda and no order to your questions, you skip beliefs without noticing, and the call ends in "I need to think about it" from someone you never hear from again. The other is to read the script like a robot, asking the next question straight over someone's tears because it's next on the page.

Use the script in Appendix A as training wheels while you learn. It holds the order of the call for you, so more of you is free to listen. Never let the process get in the way of the person in front of you.

Once the structure is part of you, navigate by the beliefs, in your own words. These days I hold the script loosely, but I still follow its structure. That never goes away.

When you look back over a call, rewording isn't a miss. Skipping a belief or a step is.

Practice before the call

I've found that one of the best ways to get better is to practice, out loud, the moments that scare you most.

This week, practice the conversation with at least one other person: your partner, a friend, anyone willing to play the person on the call. Book an hour, sit down together and say, "I'm going to walk you through this conversation. I want you to pretend you're a prospect of mine."

Say the agenda until it sounds like you. Then say the price: "Okay. So, the investment for everything we spoke about today is …" Hold a full minute of silence after it, so the first time you sit through that minute isn't on a real call.

Run the moment after the price twice: once where they ask whether you have a payment plan, and once where they tell you they need to talk to their partner. Each time, it's the first thing they've said, so pace it rather than answer it. Rehearse it enough, and "Do you have a payment plan?" stops sounding like a question you have to answer.

Practice the elephant line, naming what you're sensing and asking whether there's any truth to it. Then try the money conversation, the one most of us would rather skip. The words for all of these are in the script, in order.

Review every call against the seven

Listening back is what made my train wrecks worth having. Record your calls. At the start, ask, "Are you cool if I record this? It helps me learn from these conversations and figure out how to better serve people."

Most of the sale is made in discovery, so when you go back through a call, listen hardest there. For each belief that landed, ask who said it, you or them.

Someone I was coaching had done a good job illuminating something on a call, and I asked about the moment right after: "Did it feel more like you were telling him, or more like he was telling himself?" From the reply, it sounded like information handed to him, not something he'd revealed himself. Really good selling has them reveal the answer.

That's one moment. To judge the whole call, run it against the seven and look for the earliest miss: the first place it went off course, even when it seemed to fall apart at the end.

Walk the lovely call from the start of this book backwards through the seven. The next step: you hung up with nothing booked. Objections: she wanted to think about it, and you said, "Of course." The offer: the price came out too fast, and the payment plan before she'd said a word.

The pitch: a 10-minute tour of your program. Discovery and the gap: half an hour in, you solved her problem for free, and before that you'd soothed her pain with "lots of practitioners feel this way." The frame: 20 minutes on her kids before you asked why she'd booked.

And the frame slipped even earlier. She'd booked a free strategy session, so the call was framed as free help before anyone said hello.

That call was lost in the middle, at the moment you made her feel better. But its earliest miss was the frame.

A call booked as free strategy invites you to give strategy away, and half an hour in, you did. So the one change that review hands you isn't a better answer to "Let me think about it." It's the name of the call, and what it tells someone they're booking (Chapter 10). Fix that, and the next review moves

on: first to the 20 minutes before you asked why she'd booked, then to the middle, and the reframe you gave away.

Most objections come from a less-than-stellar first half of the call: you didn't dig deep enough, or you missed the pain or the cost of inaction. Do the first half really well, and the back half is a piece of cake.

THE POINT

Trying to fix a call at the end is mopping up the floor. Asking better questions at the start turns off the faucet.

When an objection keeps coming back, don't hunt for better words. Trace it to the belief that didn't land. Most of the time, you'll find one.

If it's "too expensive" every time, look first at what the gap is worth to them and what it's costing them, back in discovery. If people keep needing to think about it, look at desire, why now and cost. If they think they can do it alone, look at help.

TRY THIS

The review, after your next call:

1. Pull up the transcript or the recording.
2. Score the beliefs: landed, half-landed or missing.
3. Run the seven, using *After the call* at the back of this book.
4. Find the earliest miss.
5. Choose one change for the next call.

Judge it on enough calls

I could go eight calls without closing anyone, and it wouldn't necessarily mean something was wrong. I see far more people change things too early than too late.

There are two kinds of change, and they run on two clocks. What you do on a call, a question you skipped or a silence you filled, you can start fixing on the very next one: work on one thing for five to ten calls, then look again. Your offer, your price and the method itself get at least 20 calls, ideally 30 or more, before you judge them, and then you change one thing at a time.

Change the offer and the price at once, and you'll never know which change mattered.

When you look at your close rate, read it against who reached your calls and how much you qualified them first. Never judge it against a single benchmark on its own, including the range I gave you in Chapter 10. Keep a simple count as you go: conversations, calls booked, calls held and clients signed. It shows you which link is breaking.

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After my own calls, I pull the transcript, put it into AI and ask for feedback. After every one of yours, ask one question: *what's the one thing I can do that would make the biggest impact on my next call?* One answer, one change, then the next call.

Every call you'd rather forget is you learning to sell, another brick on the castle, and nobody can take that skill away from you.

I didn't stop getting rejected on that street. It just stopped being a big deal. The price will go the same way, and so will the silence after it.

IN SHORT

- Everyone bombs calls early.
- The words first, then the beliefs; the structure stays.
- Practice the hard moments out loud, with another person.
- Review every call against the seven, and fix the earliest miss.
- Judge the method on 20 calls or more, and change one thing at a time.

CHAPTER TWENTY-TWO

The mirror

"Almost every objection you get on a sales call is going to be a mirror for something inside yourself."

EARLY IN MY BUSINESS, so many of my sales calls were beautiful conversations. People felt the gap. They wanted to change. Then, at the end of the call, they'd say, "I need to think about it."

After that they'd waffle for a week or sit in limbo land for weeks. It drove me crazy. I wanted to attract more decisive people: people who could feel in their body that something was right, trust themselves and go for it.

So I asked myself a question. *If all these people aren't being decisive, where in my life am I not being decisive?*

And I noticed it. I'd go into the grocery store for a new stick of deodorant and spend 10 or 15 minutes in the aisle, pulling deodorants off the shelf, reading the label on every single one, trying so hard to find the best possible one.

Then I saw that I overthought and overanalyzed everything in my life, business decisions included. I'd spend hours looking through data instead of asking myself one simple question: *does this feel right?*

Of course I was getting people like that on my calls. I wasn't being decisive in my own life.

Indecision in your life will always be mirrored in indecision in your conversations.

So I started cleaning it up. I practiced making quicker decisions, not on impulse but from something simpler: *this feels right, and I can trust that.*

That's what I mean by the mirror. When the same objection keeps coming back, even after you've reviewed your calls and fixed what you found, it's often your own pattern reflected back at you.

When the pattern is yours, no new line will fix it. The fix is in how you live.

Check the gap and the warmth first

The mirror is the second place to look. Most of the time, "I need to think about it" means someone doesn't feel the gap, and sometimes thinking it over makes sense. So look at the call first: whether the gap was felt, and who came to the call, because someone who barely knows you will hesitate where someone warm won't (Chapter 10). Fix what you find there.

The layers stack, though. A call can miss the gap and still mirror you. But when the gap is felt, the person is warm and the same hesitation keeps coming anyway, look in the mirror.

The mirror is a question you ask yourself after the call. It's never something you say to the person on it, and never a verdict on them. They came to talk about their gap, not yours.

If you look and find yourself there, nothing is wrong with you. I found myself in a deodorant aisle. You're normal, like the rest of us.

The five mirrors

Indecision isn't the only pattern that shows up this way. I see five again and again, in myself and in the coaches I've worked with.

THE MIRROR	IN YOU	ON YOUR CALLS
The lone wolf	You won't get help yourself	People who need help but won't claim it: "I can do it myself"
Scarcity	You'll invest once the money's there	"I really need help," then, at the end, "I don't have the money"
Safety	You need a sure thing before you move	People with five million questions, who need to be sure before they leap
Indecision	You overthink your own decisions	"I need to think about it"
Waiting to feel ready	You hold off until you feel ready	People who are almost ready

Take indecision. On your side of the call, it rarely sounds like indecision.

You hear it in the thinking time you offer before anyone asks for it. You hear it in a recommendation that wobbles: "We could do six months, or maybe three, whatever you think." And you hear it at the end, in a silence you fill before they've had a moment to sit in it. Someone at the edge of a decision borrows your certainty, or your doubt.

Whatever your mirror, when someone says out loud the thing you half believe, you can't lead them past it, because you haven't gotten past it yourself.

TRY THIS

Take the objections you wrote down in Chapter 16's exercise and pick the one that keeps coming back even after you've fixed the call. Find its row in the table, if it has one, and ask yourself: *where am I modeling the behavior I say I don't want from the people I serve?* Write down every place you find it, then choose the smallest and change it this week.

No tactic outdoes who you are

Belief is mirrored too, starting with what you believe about the people on your calls.

Say you walk into a call believing you're one of five options. You'll hear yourself saying, "Unlike other coaches, I …," to someone who never mentioned anyone else. The comparison was yours, and now it's theirs too.

That's a story, and we carry plenty of them onto calls: *they're just shopping around*, or *new people won't be ready to buy*. Expect new people not to be ready, and that's probably what you'll get.

So notice the story before the call, and ask it one question: *is it true?* Then replace it with a truer one.

There's also the story you carry about yourself: *am I any good at this?* If the question is when you'll finally know you're competent, the answer is probably never. I still have those thoughts.

On a call, I don't need every answer. I need to be confident, in my body, that if this person spends three months with me, they'll walk away better off.

Three swaps are worth making in your own head. The second borrows my colleague Kim Argetsinger's line from Chapter 7.

INSTEAD OF	"Am I competent enough?"
SAY	"What does this person need, and can I help them?"
INSTEAD OF	"I'm just an option they're testing out."
SAY	"They're showing up hoping I'm the real deal."
INSTEAD OF	"How do I fix this in my tactics?"
SAY	"What is this showing me about myself?"

The first two change your posture before you've said a word. The third changes what you do with a hard call afterward.

Tactics still matter, and they're worth correcting line by line. But your deepest work in sales is to become the kind of person you want to attract: not in how you dress or talk, but in your beliefs, your decisions and how you move through the world.

No tactic can outdo the identity you hold on the inside.

Walk the walk

Every call asks someone to believe in what you're offering, to invest and to decide. Ask that of someone only if you do all three yourself.

Sometimes part of you suspects you're selling a half solution. The words can be perfect and something still leaks: a hedge in the pitch, a wobble at the first sign of doubt. People feel it, and they hesitate.

The hedge can be a single line: "I think maybe this could help." Belief says it plainly: this is what I do, and here's how it works. That swap is worth making, but if the doubt is real, it will come through the new words too.

So fix the offer, not the script. Add what it's missing, or scale back what you claim for it, then tell the truth about it.

In the early days of my business, I wasn't walking the walk as a buyer. You've met my first coach, and the week I spent overthinking his offer. I was asking people to invest in themselves at a time when spending a few thousand dollars on a coach still seemed crazy to me, so I set out to become the buyer I wanted to attract.

Once I was investing at that level, it became much easier to ask someone else for that kind of money. Now, when I ask someone to invest thousands of dollars in working with me, I ask from a place of congruence. I've been on the other side of this conversation many, many times.

I'm not asking anyone to do something I wouldn't do myself.

The lone wolf and scarcity mirrors start here, in how you make your own buying decisions. Are you always looking for the cheapest option? Does paying a coach what you charge feel a little crazy?

If it does, there's no shame or judgment in that. It's just going to be really hard to charge high-ticket prices for what you do. The same scarcity tempts you to shrink your offer to whatever you guess someone can afford (Chapter 15).

Deciding is something you practice. Start in your own deodorant aisles, the small choices you turn over far too long, until deciding feels ordinary, even when you're the one being sold to.

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When you've checked your calls and you're still hearing "I need to think about it," ask yourself the question that found me in that aisle.

Where in my life am I not being decisive?

IN SHORT

- Check the gap and the warmth first.
- A repeating objection is often a mirror.
- The mirror is for you, never for them.
- No tactic outdoes who you are.
- Walk the walk: decide like the buyer you want.

CHAPTER TWENTY-THREE

Off the fence

I'LL NEVER FORGET the first sales call I got on after I started practicing being decisive. Someone was selling me a coaching program, and we had a good call. At the end, she shared the investment.

I sat there in silence with her.

In the past, I would have spent weeks thinking about it. This time I checked in with my body. *Does this feel right?* It did.

"Let's do it."

It was the first time I'd ever signed up on the call. I remember thinking, *okay, now I'm the kind of person who signs up on the call when it feels right.*

As I kept practicing, my own calls began to shift. People would reach the end of a call, I'd sit with them in silence for a few moments, and they'd say yes. They didn't overthink it, and they didn't spend weeks waffling.

It was because I had changed. I'd led myself, and now I could lead others.

You've been on a fence of your own. You've told yourself you'll say the price and stop talking, once you're more confident. You'll ask for the decision plainly, after a few more calls. You'll stop offering the payment plan before anyone asks, once it feels less awkward.

Every one of those is well meant. You don't want to get it wrong with someone who has trusted you with their problem, and waiting feels like the responsible thing. But each one is "let me think about it," said to yourself.

Readiness is not a feeling. It's a decision.

It's normal to stand at the edge of that fence. It's the same edge someone stands at on your call once you've said the price, and you feel it for the same reason they do: it matters.

Your decision

On every call from here on, you'll ask someone for a decision. You have one of your own to make first, about the way you sell.

It's the same choice they face. Yes is fine, no is fine, and limbo is the one place that doesn't serve you. Just as their yes isn't real until they've put money down, yours isn't real until your next call.

A yes looks like that call, led. You say the agenda at the top and wait for their yes, then ask your questions one at a time and hold the silence after each, until they feel their gap. You say the price in one sentence and go quiet. You ask for the decision plainly, and the call ends paid, booked or with a clean no.

You've already seen a call like that all the way through. After a year of leaving that email in her drafts, the physical therapist got off the fence on the call.

Your no would be just as clear. You decide this way of selling isn't for you, close the book and keep selling the way you have been. That's a clean no, and it's fine, because you'll know where you stand.

Limbo sounds like "I'm going to get to it next week." It's what people told me, week after week, when I gave my course away. For you, it looks like agreeing with every page of this book and running your next call the way you ran the last. It's the most comfortable of the three, and the only one where nothing changes, for you or for the people on your calls.

Carry one question into every call: *did this person leave with a clear decision, or a day booked to make one?* If they did, whichever way they went, you've done your job. If they didn't, go back through the call and find the earliest moment it slipped.

Somewhere on your next call, the old way will be right there. The silence after the price runs long, or someone says they need to think about it, and "Take all the time you need" is already on your tongue.

That moment is your decision: the old line or the leader's. Leave the silence alone. If they need to think, pace it first, and if they're still not sure, say the line I gave you at the start of this book: "Totally cool. Just curious, what specifically are you wanting to think about?"

I've sat in that silence myself, as the buyer. It's where I decided.

So find your next call on your calendar and decide, today, how you'll lead it.

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This is how I see selling.

Imagine you have a backpack full of water bottles, and you're walking through the desert. Up ahead you see a man sprawled out on the sand, looking up at the sun. You can tell he hasn't had a drink of water in three days.

You wouldn't walk past him for fear of being annoying. He can't know you have water unless you tell him.

It would be of service to walk up to him and say, "Hey, I've got a backpack full of water bottles. Do you want a water bottle?"

Want help with the rest of your business?

Better sales calls are one piece. If something else is standing between you and more clients, it's usually in your marketing, your offer or your lead flow. Book a free 20-minute business assessment call with me, and we'll take a personal look at your business and figure out what needs to shift.

BOOK YOUR FREE ASSESSMENT CALL

After the call

DID IT FEEL MORE like you were telling them, or like they were telling themselves?

Ask yourself that first, while the call is still fresh. When someone tells themselves, they hear their own gap in their own voice. When you tell them, they can agree with every word, feel nothing and still need to think about it.

Then go back over the call: the recording if you have one, your notes page if you don't.

Run the seven

Under all seven sits one test: *did this person leave with a clear decision, or a day booked to make one?*

Here they are again, each with the questions I'd put to your call and the miss I see most often. Wherever you answer no, the call slipped.

1. **The frame:** the coach leads the call from start to finish: curious, detached, never coaching or chasing.
   Did you state the agenda and wait for their yes? Did you keep leading to the end, without coaching, chasing or thanking them for their time? The usual misses are mistakes 1 to 3 below. The first shows most at the money, where staying detached is hardest (Chapter 11).
2. **The gap:** surfaced clearly and felt emotionally.

Could you write their point A and point B now, in their own words? Did they feel it, and answer your recap with an emphatic yes? The usual miss is a gap they understood but never felt, like my slippers (Chapter 4).

3. **Discovery:** surfaces the core beliefs and connects the prospect to them emotionally, not just intellectually.
   Score pain, desire, help, trust, why now and cost as landed, half-landed or missing. For each that landed, who said it, you or them? Did they do almost all the talking, and did you hold the silences? The usual misses are mistakes 4 and 7 to 9 below (Chapters 12 and 13).
4. **The pitch:** simple, brief and compelling, presenting the offer as the bridge to what they want.
   Was it built from their words, and over in a minute or two? Did it show one clear way across, without promising results or giving away the how? The usual miss is mistake 10, *pitching the weeds* (Chapter 14).
5. **The offer:** one clear offer, with the price stated.
   Was it one offer, sized to what they need? Did you say the price in one sentence and hold the silence until they spoke? The usual miss is filling that silence with a payment plan or a list of what's included (Chapter 15).
6. **Objections:** explored, not just accepted.
   Did you pace the first one and confirm their certainty before any logistics? Did a question come before any reframe? The usual miss is mistake 12, *taking the first objection at face value* (Chapters 16 and 19).
7. **The next step:** a clear one, either a close with payment on the call, a booked follow-up, or a no.
   Did the call end in payment, a decision call in both your calendars, or a clean no? The usual miss is one of the last three mistakes below (Chapters 17 and 18).

What to fix first

Before you rank what you found, check one thing that has nothing to do with skill. Did you promise a result, push past a no, or pitch someone you couldn't help? Any yes is a line crossed (Chapters 8 and 9). Fix that before you change anything else.

Then the skill. You'll often find more than one miss, and that's normal. Fix the earliest first.

A call that came apart at the price usually started coming apart in discovery, and the price is only where it showed. Turn off the faucet before you mop the floor.

Last, write down one change for your next call. One is enough.

The mistakes I see most

There are fifteen, in the order they happen on a call. Most are the pleaser's, made out of kindness. A few are the pusher's. Where a fix needs words on the call, Appendix A has them word for word.

1. *Going in to close.* "I really think this is perfect for you," said a little too fast. People feel the need and pull back. The attachment is what creates the pushiness. Go in to understand them and assess the fit, glad either way (Chapter 3).
2. *Playing one-down.* "Thank you so much for taking the time." It's people-pleasing energy that does a disservice, because you can't be someone's advocate while you need them to like you. Assess, don't impress, and save your appreciation for when they open up (Chapters 7 and 11).
3. *No sales frame.* The call was booked as "a free strategy session," like the one at the start of this book. With no agreed purpose, there's no frame to sell in. Name the call for what they'll get (Chapter 10).

4. *Pitching before the gap is developed.* One surface answer at minute five, then "I can totally help with that." You're not getting deep enough. Give discovery 20 to 25 minutes (Chapter 12).
5. *Coaching on the call.* "Here's what I'd do." Solve someone's problem and they have no reason to work with you: the air has gone out of the balloon. Build the tension with questions, and keep the how for the work (Chapter 5).
6. *Softening the pain.* "It's not that bad. You're not alone." It's misguided care. You're taking their pain away, and the tension goes with it. Give one plain acknowledgment, then silence, then a question that goes deeper (Chapter 6).
7. *Staying in the head.* "I want to make $10,000 a month" goes down as desire, and every answer is a fact. The mind doesn't make sales; the heart makes sales. After every fact, ask its impact; after every number, what it would change (Chapter 12).
8. *Never hearing "I need help."* The need seems obvious, so nobody asks why they haven't solved it alone, and they never say it out loud. It comes back as *I'll try it myself first.* Ask what they feel has been stopping them, and listen for a first-person *I need help* (Chapter 12).
9. *Avoiding why now and cost.* The hard questions get skipped or apologized for, to keep the call comfortable, and come back as "It's not the right time." I care more about someone getting what they want than about making them feel good. Ask why now, then what happens if things don't change (Chapter 12).
10. *Pitching the weeds.* Modules, sessions and credentials, until they ask, "So how many sessions is that?" The more you tell people about your process, the more objections you create. Spending too long on the pitch has been one of my own biggest mistakes. Give them their A to B, built from their words (Chapter 14).
11. *Bulldozing to the price.* The pitch ends and the next thing they hear is the number. The doubts come out with the price already on the table, and

the end of the call gets weird. Skipping a temperature check isn't the mistake: the check is a tool, not a rule. Going to the price while someone is plainly unsure is. Find out where they are before you say the number (Chapter 15).

12. *Taking the first objection at face value.* Someone asks about a payment plan, you lay out three options, and they say, "I'm going to need to think about it." The first objection is rarely the real one. Answer its words, with options or with the rebuttals I was trained on and am still unlearning, and the fear underneath goes untouched. Pace it: certainty first, logistics after (Chapter 16).
13. *Never asking.* Someone is ready, and the call ends on an invitation to have a think and let you know. Looking back, I could have closed so many conversations just by asking. Ask, "Hey, would you like to sign up and get started together?" Then stop talking (Chapter 17).
14. *Letting them pay later.* "I'll send you an invoice tonight." A yes has a golden window before their fear talks them out of it. Until someone's paid, they haven't really committed. Take payment while you're both still on the call, and book their first session before you hang up (Chapter 17).
15. *Ending without a dated next step.* "Let's check in next week sometime." I've learned the hard way, many times, that without a date, deals drift. Suggest a day for the decision call two or three days out, send the invite before you hang up, and make it safe to bring you a no (Chapter 18).

When it keeps happening

When the same thing turns up call after call, look at the call before you look at yourself. Each row below runs in that order. For one objection you keep hearing, read Chapters 16 and 19, then Appendix C, then Chapter 22.

IF YOU KEEP SEEING	LOOK FIRST AT
"I need to think about it"	Why now, and whether the gap was felt (Chapters 12 and 13); your pacing (Chapter 16); your own decisiveness (Chapter 22)
"It's too expensive," every time	The number and the cost of inaction, in discovery (Chapter 12); warmth, and your belief in your price (Chapter 10); your own relationship with money (Chapter 22)
Lovely calls, and no sales	Coaching on the call (Chapter 5); softening (Chapter 6); never asking (Chapter 17)
Ghosting after a great call	Nothing booked, or a no that wasn't safe to bring you (Chapters 18 and 20)
"I can do it myself"	The help belief (Chapter 12); their own words handed back (Chapter 19); whether you get help yourself (Chapter 22)
Endless questions	Their need for certainty, and how steady you stay (Chapter 16); your own need for a sure thing (Chapter 22)
"I need to talk to my partner"	Whether it's a smokescreen for doubt: pace it, partner aside, and ask twice (Chapter 19); prevention is in Appendix C
No-shows	How warm they were, what you sent before the call, and how it was booked (Chapter 10); the one message to send after (Chapter 20)
A low close rate	Who reaches your calls, before your technique (Chapter 10); then the simple count (Chapter 21)

On your next call, when someone starts telling themselves, say less.

APPENDIX A

The call, word for word

THE FIRST TIME YOU say these words on a real call, they'll feel like someone else's. When I started doing sales calls, I used the scripts and was thinking, *what's my next question?* That's normal.

Here is the whole call in order, branches included, for your first 30 to 50 calls. I learned much of its structure, and many of its lines, from Cole Gordon.

The labels on the blocks come from the seven things that really matter on a call. The gap is the distance between where someone is and where they want to be. Inside the scripts, italics are what you do, and brackets are yours to fill.

Your close rate starts before the call

This script will help. But oftentimes, the biggest thing that influences your close rate is what happens before the call: your marketing, your lead flow and what people see before they get on the phone with you. If you want help figuring out where the gaps are, book a free 20-minute business assessment call with me, and we'll take a personal look at your business.

BOOK YOUR FREE ASSESSMENT CALL

The call on one page

The frame runs the whole length of the call: you lead from the first minute to the last. Before the call, take five minutes to read what they told you when they booked, ground yourself and start a fresh notes page. If you're unsure they're ready, a short assessment call comes first, on an earlier day (the last section of this appendix).

THE PART	HOW LONG
The opening	2 to 5 minutes
Discovery	20 to 25 minutes, done by about minute 25
Recap and permission	brief
The pitch	a minute or two, inside a conversation
The temperature check, if you use one	brief
The price, then silence	one sentence, then as long as it takes
The first objection, set aside for certainty; then the ask and payment	as long as it takes
A decision call, only if no decision is possible	booked before you hang up

The whole call runs 45 to 60 minutes, never over an hour, and ends paid, booked or with a clean no. Across the top of each notes page, write the six beliefs discovery lands, in this order, PAIN · DESIRE · HELP · TRUST · WHY NOW · COST: what's wrong and what it's doing to them, what they want, that they can't get there alone, that you're the right person to help, that now is the time to act, and what staying put will cost. The order is deliberate. Cost comes last, just before the recap, because it lands hardest.

The script, with branches

1. The opening · *the frame*

A minute or two of real warmth, no thanks for their time, then:

"Cool, so you ready to dive in and get started?"

"So my goal here is to help you get clear on what you need. And from there, if I think I can help, we can talk through what that looks like, and you can decide whether or not you want to move forward with that. Or if I think there's someone else out there who'd be better for you, I can do my best to point you in the right direction instead. Sound good?"

Wait for the yes. On video: "By the way, I'm going to be taking notes."

To record, ask first: "Are you cool if I record this?"

For someone long-winded, add: "If I feel like we're going off track, is it cool if I interrupt you and redirect us, so we can make this call as valuable as possible for you?"

If they ask the price early, never give a ballpark: "Awesome, we'll definitely get into that in a couple of minutes. But I guess before we get there, what I want to do here is get clear on what you need."

If they lead with questions about you: "Cool, those are great questions, and I'm happy to answer them. What I want to do first is learn a little more about where you are, and see if I can help you and what you need. Let's start there, and then if it feels like a fit, I'm happy to talk through the details and answer any questions you have. Sound good?"

> *If they arrive prescribing for themselves:* "Maybe that's what you need, maybe not. Let me ask a couple of questions first."
>
> *A real money red flag early on gets Appendix D's yes-or-no check, and no digging.*

2. Discovery · *the gap* and *discovery*

> *One short question at a time, then quiet.*

1. "What's your number one biggest challenge when it comes to [X]?"
2. "How's that been impacting you?"
3. "Where do you ultimately want to be?" *Then:* "Why is that so important to you?" *Then ask where they are now, and name the distance in their words.*
4. *(Where the outcome can be measured)* "What's a new client worth for you in your business?" *Then let them do the math.*
5. "What do you feel has been stopping you from solving this on your own?"
6. *(Where trust is in question)* "What was it that made you feel like I was the right person to help you with this?"
7. *(Unless they've already said it)* "What's making you feel like now is the right moment to solve this?"
8. "Before I move on, anything else you feel would be helpful for me to know?"
9. "What happens if things don't change?"

> *Move on from a belief when they feel it, not when they've answered it.*
>
> *From head to heart:* "Tell me more about that." "What do you mean?" "How long has that been going on for?" "Are you willing to settle for that?"

> *After a weighty answer, once:* "Wow, that's really tough." *Then four or five seconds of quiet.*
>
> *When their words and energy don't match:* "I'm sensing that there might be a little bit of [X] here. Is there any truth to that?"
>
> *When* "Why is that so important to you?" *keeps getting the same tidy answer:* "Can I be honest with you? Help me understand, because I feel like there's something I'm missing."
>
> *Tears:* "I see you. I see how hard this is. I see how much you're holding. How much you want this to work." *Then silence.*
>
> *Before the recap, ask yourself: can I help this person, and do I want to? If not, skip the pitch and take the kind exit (block 13).*

3. Recap · *the gap*, established

> *Appreciate their honesty, once, and don't thank them:* "I appreciate you being so honest with me."
>
> "Here's what I'm hearing. It sounds like your biggest challenge today is [their challenge]. And what you want is [where they want to be], but [what's in the way], and it's costing you [what's at stake]. And that's what made you want to reach out and ask for help. Did I get that right?"
>
> *Their words in every blank. A flat yes:* "Anything I missed there?"

4. Diagnosis, certainty, permission · *the gap*, established

> *Where it helps, a diagnosis: what's in the way and why, in their words, and never the how.* "Here's what I think is going on, and here's why." *The root cause in a sentence or two, then:* "How does that land for you?"
>
> *Once they agree, calmly:* "That's definitely something that I can help you with. Would you like me to show you how it works?"
>
> *To talk about outcomes without promising them:* "My work is a pathway to [what they want]. I can't promise [the result]. But if you show up and do the work, there's a pretty good shot [what's possible]."

5. The pitch · *the pitch*

> *A minute or two, in three or four steps:* "Remember how you told me [X]? In step one, we [what you'll do], so that [what changes for them]."
>
> *The logistics once:* "Over [twelve weekly calls] together, we're going to be focusing on [their outcome]."
>
> "I'm happy to answer any questions you have about how that all works."
>
> *Brief answers, and no money. If they ask the price first:* "Yeah, I'm happy to answer that in a moment. Before we get there, do you have any questions about the process and how it all works?"

6. The temperature check · *the offer*

> *If you use one: when they ask about the investment, or their questions run out.*
>
> "Money aside, how's the process feeling for you on a scale of 1 to 10, 10 being, this is exactly what I need to get to where I want to be, and 1 being, screw you, I want to hang up the phone?"
>
> A 10: "Any concerns you have?"
>
> A 7 TO 9: "What's holding you back from feeling more like a 10?" *Reflect it, address it, sweep for anything else, then ask for their score again.*
>
> BELOW 7: *no price, and the kind exit (block 13).*
>
> *Then:* "Cool, so you want to talk about the investment and what it looks like?"

7. The price · *the offer*

> "Okay. So, the investment for everything we spoke about today is [X]."
>
> *The number is always the pay-in-full investment, and nothing comes after it. Then silence until they speak. Left alone, people often solve it themselves.*
>
> *If they say it's a lot: stay quiet, or* "Yep, that's the investment."
>
> *If they ask whether you're still there:* "Yep, I'm here, just letting you work it out."

8. The first thing they say · *objections*

AN IMMEDIATE YES: *skip what follows. Stay calm and go to payment.*

Whatever else comes first, don't answer it yet. Agree lightly, set it aside and ask about certainty, because a plan solves a money problem, never a commitment problem.

A PAYMENT PLAN: "It depends. A lot of people take care of it up front. For some people it doesn't make sense based on where they are cash-flow-wise, so we'll look into splitting it up. But I guess the most important question I have is, financial logistics aside, do you feel 100 percent like this is the right next step for you, and that now's the right time to do it?"

A PARTNER: "Yeah, that makes sense. Partner aside, do you feel like this is the right thing for you, and that now's the right time?"

"IT'S TOO EXPENSIVE": "Totally fair. Money aside, are you 100 percent convinced the process is what you need to get to where you want to be?"

A START DATE: "Totally get it. Setting aside the date we get started, do you feel 100 percent certain that working together is the right thing to do?"

"I NEED TO THINK ABOUT IT": "Setting aside needing to think it through, do you feel 100 percent like this is the right next step for you?" *If they're not sure:* "Totally cool. Just curious, what specifically are you wanting to think about?"

ONCE THEY ANSWER THE CERTAINTY QUESTION:

Not sure: "Okay. What's on your mind around that?"

Yes: ask a second time, the double check. "So to be 100 percent clear, what I'm hearing is that you're in. There's nothing in you saying this isn't the right move. You just need a way to make it work financially." *(If what they raised wasn't the money, end on that instead.)*

A stall after two yeses: "You told me five minutes ago you were 100 percent in. What's coming up?"

9. The money · *the next step*

After two yeses, talk money only if it came from their side: they asked about a plan, or told you the price is a stretch. Never ask whether they need a plan. If money hasn't come up, go straight to the ask (block 10).

IF THEY CAN PAY IN FULL AFTER ALL: "Cool, why don't we do this? Let's take care of it up front, and then we can get you on board and ready to go."

IF IT'S A STRETCH: *one plan, named by you, in one of two ways.*

Either, if you're newer or help people with personal change, the simple split: "Cool, we can split it up into three payments, to keep it simple." *Then, once and flat:* "Three payments of [X]."

Or, with business clients and more experience, look at their numbers together: "Since this is something you're wanting to do, how do you feel about having an open and honest conversation about where you're at financially?" *Then one question at a time, writing the numbers down:* "What's your monthly income? What are your monthly expenses? Do you have access to any credit? What's the available balance? How much do you have in savings?" *For a business owner, add:* "What's your monthly revenue? What are you taking home?" *Then one plan, or pay in full:* "Based on where you're at, here's what I think we can do."

IF THE MONEY ISN'T THERE AT ALL: *don't reach for a split. Believe they can find it, and ask:* "I hear you. You want this, and I know you're creative and resourceful. How do you feel you might be able to get the funds to do this?" *Then, with permission, the same look at their numbers.*

IF THERE'S NO RESPONSIBLE PATH, *after either of those:* "Look, I don't see a pathway forward here right now. But I'd love to put together a game plan with you, so you can do this down the line." *Then a date to look again.*

IF THEY ASK FOR A SPLIT OR TERMS YOU DON'T OFFER: "No, sorry. Can't do that." *Once, and kindly.*

Any plan: six months or less, never longer than the work itself, and typically 15 to 30 percent above paying in full.

10. The ask and payment · *the next step*

Once the money is settled: "Hey, would you like to sign up and get started together?" *Then stop talking.*

A yes: "Why don't we go ahead and run that first payment on the call here?" *A checkout link in the chat while you stay on. Until someone's paid, they haven't really committed.*

A yes with a later start: "You already know you're going to do this. So let's put down the deposit now."

Reluctance at the card: "Totally cool. I'm just curious, I'm sensing there might be something deeper holding you back from feeling 100 percent sure about this. Is there any truth to that?"

"It looks like it just went through. Congratulations."

Nerves: "I think it's totally normal. You're on the edge of making a big shift in your life. I'd be surprised if you weren't."

"Cool, let's book in your first session." *Then exactly what happens next, and no more selling.*

Put your terms in a "sales are final" *checkbox they tick at checkout, and handle any dispute honestly, case by case. Where local law restricts taking payment on a call, follow the law.*

11. No decision possible · *the next step*

First ask block 8's "what specifically" *question. Then suggest the call rather than asking for it: two or three days out, about 20 minutes, with a seat for a partner who genuinely shares the decision.*

"So why don't we set aside some time to reconnect Thursday, and we can come to clarity on a decision. And if it feels like a yes, great, we can get you on board and get you enrolled. And if it doesn't feel like the right next step, totally cool, we can part as friends."

"I've got Thursday at 2 p.m. available. Does that work for you?"

Send the invite while you're both on the call.

"Short of getting hit by a bus, will you let me know if anything comes up before that call?"

"Write down the rest of your questions, and we can knock them out on our next call."

12. Second calls · *the next step*

What a second call is for depends on how much discovery came before it.

AFTER A FULL FIRST CALL, THE DECISION CALL: "So last time we spoke, you mentioned you were having [this challenge], and [this] is what you wanted. And we talked about the roadmap to get there. Has anything changed since our last conversation?"

Wait. Then: "How are you feeling about things today?"

> *If they stall again, keep it short and ask for a decision, a no included:* "We'll come to some clarity together on what the best next steps are for you. Even if that means no, we can at least walk away from this conversation clear together." *Then block 8's* "what specifically" *question.*
>
> AFTER A MARKET-RESEARCH CALL *(while you're newer, you never pitch on the research call): recap their problem, what they want and what's at stake, ask the same question, and if nothing has changed, pitch.*
>
> AFTER A MONEY HESITATION: "Setting aside the investment piece for a second, we talked about the process last week. How's that feeling for you, on a scale of 1 to 10?" *Then certainty again. You may not be able to save it.*

13. The kind exit · *the next step*

> IF THE NO IS YOURS: "Can I be honest with you? I don't think we're going to be a good fit."
>
> *Keep it to that. Explaining why only invites more conversation.*
>
> *If you know somewhere better:* "Based on where you're at right now, I don't think working together is going to be the best next step for you. But here's where I would go …"
>
> IF THE NO IS THEIRS: "I respect that. I'd rather have a clear no than a slow fade. If anything changes down the road, I'm here."
>
> *Then, once:* "Can I ask what made it a no? Not to change your mind, just to understand." *Take the answer as it comes, without reframing it.*
>
> *Whichever kind it is, close warmly:* "Glad we got to clarity. I'm rooting for you."

Say it close to word for word until the words are yours. Then hold the structure lightly, and let the human connection come first.

Before the full call: the short assessment call

When you aren't sure someone is ready to give you an hour, a call of 15 to 20 minutes comes first. It's there to uncover, not to solve, and it ends not fully resolved. If you stay on one too long, you'll be tempted to solve their problem, and they'll leave thinking, *great, I don't need you anymore.*

> "Cool, we've got 15 minutes here. What I'd love to do is take a closer look at the business with you. And then at the end of the call, if I think I can help you on a deeper level, I'll let you know, and we can talk through what next steps look like."
>
> *A handful of questions about why it's happening, not how to fix it. Then a minute or two of insight, without the how, because the value is in the diagnosis:*
>
> "Here's what I think is happening, and here's what I think needs to shift for you to get to where you want to be."
>
> IF THEY'RE READY TO CHANGE: "Would you like some help solving this?" *A yes books the full call.*
>
> IF THEY AREN'T READY: *part kindly, without a pitch.*
>
> *Either way, before you hang up, ask who else they know. Someone who isn't ready may still know someone who is:* "Is there anyone else you know who might be in a similar place to you? I'd love to have a 15-minute call with them, like we did today. Could you give me two or three names?"
>
> *On the full call that follows, don't start from scratch. Re-anchor:* "I know we started off a little bit yesterday. I'd like to dive deeper today and understand what's at the root of why this is happening." *Then go deeper on the impact, how long it's been going on, and the cost.*

APPENDIX B

The swaps

A CALL CAN TURN on one line. It's usually meant well, and it's out of your mouth before you notice. I've said plenty of the wrong things myself.

From pleasing to leading

INSTEAD OF	SAY	WHY	CHAPTER
"Book a free discovery call"	"Book a business breakthrough call."	It names your process, not their result	10
"Thanks so much for taking the time"	"I'm glad we had a chance to chat. I'm excited that we get to talk about how we can help you."	It says the favor runs from them to you	11
"A lot of people struggle with that"	"That gap is real. How's that been impacting you?"	It lets the tension out	4, 6
"Oh, that's totally normal"	"Yeah, that's a real challenge." *Then let it sit.*	*Totally normal* makes their struggle ordinary, and smaller	6
"What do you think you need?"	"Based on what you've shared with me, here's what I think you need to solve this."	It hands the lead to the one person who doesn't know the way	7

INSTEAD OF	SAY	WHY	CHAPTER
"You get twelve sessions, a workbook and …"	"Remember how you told me [X]? In step one, we …"	It could be said to anyone	14
"The cost is [X], and we have payment plans …"	"Okay. So, the investment for everything we spoke about today is [X]." *Then stop.*	*Investment* names what they get back; anything after the number says it's a problem	15
"Take all the time you need"	*Ask:* "Hey, would you like to sign up and get started together?" *If they want to think it over, pace it first (Chapter 16), then:* "Totally cool. Just curious, what specifically are you wanting to think about?"	It sends them off to think alone, where nothing gets decided	1, 16, 17, 19
"Let me know what you think"	*With the decision still open at the end:* "What's your honest reaction?"	Its default answer is no, because no requires no action	2
"I totally understand"	"What specifically concerns you about that?"	It leaves a vague worry vague	16
"I'll send you an invoice"	"Why don't we go ahead and run that first payment on the call here?"	Until someone's paid, they haven't really committed	17
"Would you like to book your first session?"	"How about we do this? Let's get your first session on the calendar for Tuesday at ten."	It asks permission to keep helping	7
"Would you like to book a follow-up?"	"So why don't we set aside some time to reconnect Thursday, and we can come to clarity on a decision."	Asking invites a no; suggesting a day leads	18
"Just checking in" or "Just wanted to follow up"	"I've been thinking about what you said." *Then name it in their words, and ask,* "I'm curious, how are you feeling about our conversation?"	It says only *I want an answer from you*	20

Save "no pressure" for an invitation to a call, or for asking how serious someone is. Never say it after the offer, the price or the ask.

After each step of a spoken pitch, a quick check-in keeps it a conversation: "What difference would that make for you?" At the end, skip "Does that make sense?" and hand it back: "I'm happy to answer any questions you have about how that all works."

From pushing to leading

INSTEAD OF	SAY	WHY	CHAPTER
"You're the perfect fit for my program"	*Once they've confirmed your recap, calmly:* "That's definitely something that I can help you with. Would you like me to show you how it works?"	They feel you wanting the yes, and their guard goes up	14
"The investment is [X], and we have a money-back guarantee"	*Nothing, unless they raise a real risk concern. Then a guarantee shaped to that concern.*	A guarantee nobody asked for is a push while they're off balance	15, 19
"It's actually not that expensive because …"	"Totally fair. Money aside, are you 100 percent convinced the process is what you need to get to where you want to be?" *If not:* "What do you mean when you say it's too expensive?"	It wins the point and loses the person	19
"If you sign today, I can give you a discount"	*Once they've asked about a payment plan:* "If you wanted to do a pay in full, I'd love to include an extra bonus session for you." *Nothing for signing today.*	Cutting the price says it was never real	9, 17

In your own head

Three swaps are never said aloud. You make them before a call, and after a hard one. The second borrows a line from my colleague Kim Argetsinger.

INSTEAD OF	SAY	WHY	CHAPTER
"Am I competent enough?"	"What does this person need, and can I help them?"	You don't need every answer, only to know you can help	22
"I'm just an option they're testing out"	"They're showing up hoping I'm the real deal."	Expect a shopper, and you'll usually get one	22
"How do I fix this in my tactics?"	"What is this showing me about myself?"	No tactic can outdo the identity you hold on the inside	22

• • •

When you can't tell whether you're pushing, pleasing or leading, listen to the last thing you said.

APPENDIX C

The objection field guide

MOST ADVICE ABOUT OVERCOMING objections rests on one belief: that the person on your call doesn't know the right timing for themselves, and your job is to convince, persuade, drag, manipulate or coerce them over the fence.

I'm still unlearning it myself.

Nothing here needs it.

The map

Unless the first thing they say after the price is a yes, agree with it, set it aside and ask whether they're 100 percent sure this is the right next step, and that now's the right time (Chapter 16). If they say yes, ask again.

THEY SAY	IT USUALLY MEANS	FIRST MOVE	PREVENT IT NEXT TIME
"It's too expensive."	Value, priority or trust	Not sure: "What do you mean?" Sure: no money, or a stretch?	What the gap is worth to them, and its cost, in discovery
"I need to think about it."	A gap not felt, or something unsaid	"What specifically are you wanting to think about?"	The felt gap, and why now
"It's not the right time."	Urgency never felt	Bring back the stakes they named	The cost of waiting

THEY SAY	IT USUALLY MEANS	FIRST MOVE	PREVENT IT NEXT TIME
"I need to talk to my partner."	A joint decision, or a smokescreen	If genuine: equip them, book the decision call and offer their partner a seat	The price on the application, if you're protecting your time
"I can do it myself."	The help belief never landed	Has doing it alone worked?	The help question
"Will this work for me?"	Fear	Reflect it; find the source	The trust question, and proof before the call
Question after question	A mind hunting certainty	Answer a few, then ask what's holding them back	A shorter pitch

The first thing someone says is rarely the real thing. In one role-play, I paced a partner objection and it turned into money. I paced the money and it turned into *is this actually going to work for me?*

Pace each new answer the same way. Before you talk money, one last sweep: "Is there anything else that's feeling like, I'm not totally sure this is aligned for me?"

The rarer moves

When it's the money

"Can you do it for less?" Once they're certain, hold the price, with a question I learned from Jeremy Miner: "Do you want the cheapest? Or do you want the best solution that's actually going to get you to [where they want to be]?" Paying in full can earn a bonus, and the price you stated is already your best rate (Chapter 17). Nothing earns a lower price.

"Can you split it into two payments?" The terms are yours to set, and no plan runs past six months. If you don't offer that plan, say so once, kindly: "No, sorry. Can't do that." Someone once asked me that. I said no, and he still signed up.

"It's so expensive," once the real issue is clear. Agree: "You're right, it is expensive. But you're actually going to make this investment either way." I learned it from Alex Hormozi. Use it only if you believe it.

"My employer would pay." Sell the person first. The boss comes after they've decided.

"Will you run another promo?" A man asked me that once, and I realized I'd trained him to wait for my next price drop. Stop discounting.

When it's trust or fear

"This sounds amazing," and nothing else. Interest isn't intent yet. One probe, with real permission to say no: "Any concerns you have?"

"How long will it take?" "It depends. And the biggest thing it depends on is you." Never promise a timeline.

"Can I talk to past clients?" Walk through your testimonials on the call.

"Can I pay monthly and stop if it isn't working?" That's fear asking for a way out. Make it normal, then lead: "You don't go into a marriage thinking about getting a divorce. You go in all in." A specific risk still standing after the fear is worked through can get a guarantee shaped to it (Chapter 19). With no testimonials yet, a first-session refund can answer that risk.

"I need to feel into it." Validate it, then ask what specifically they want to sit with (Chapter 16).

"I'm freaking out." "That anxiety, that excitement, is normal. I've been on the other side of this conversation too, many times." Only if you have.

When it's the decision

A couple, buying together. Two sales: find out what each of them wants.

"I'm talking to a few other coaches." "What do you feel makes this a better fit than the other programs you've explored?"

"Can you send me a proposal?" "You probably don't need more information. What you need is to make a decision." Then talk through what's on their mind. If no decision comes, book the decision call before you hang up. Keep written proposals for warm, high-trust or business-to-business deals.

"Can I try one session?" Go back to their words and their stakes, then the car with one wheel (Chapter 15). If a quick fix is all they want: "If you're just looking for a quick-fix, one-session kind of thing, I'm probably not going to be your guy."

Selling to a friend. Own the discomfort out loud: "A part of me is even afraid to say this, because we're friends and I don't want to compromise that." Then say the hard thing, and why.

When you don't know what to say

Name what you're wrestling with, both halves of it, then ask how that lands (Chapter 16).

Never, on a call or after it

- A rebuttal
- Justifying the price, or listing what's included
- Shame: "Can you afford not to invest in yourself?"
- A discount, or a payment plan they didn't ask for or that covers doubt or fear
- Deadlines, or "only three spots left"
- "Have a think and let me know."
- A "think about it" with no booked decision call
- A page or an e-guide instead of the conversation
- Pinning a hesitation on them ("you," "for you") when you name it
- Telling them how to feel
- Pushing a genuine partner decision into a solo one
- Telling them why you're better than other coaches

Every line on that list either pushes or pleases. Leave them out, and what's left is a question.

APPENDIX D

When the rule depends

MOST OF WHAT I teach holds on every call. A few rules move with where you are and who you're talking to.

When someone asks my price now, I just tell them. Earlier in my business, I'd invite them onto a call first, and that was right too. What changed was my calendar.

The first rows turn on a question from Chapter 10: do I have a lead-flow problem, or a protect-my-time problem? The more leads you have, the more friction you add.

A chapter number shows where a rule is taught, with its reason. A blank means it lives only here.

WHEN	THEN	CHAPTER
Lead volume		
You need every call	Remove friction: no application, no price before the call. Take nearly every call, and expect a lower close rate	10, 11
Some flow, but the price surprises people	Use the yes-or-no check below in your message before they book	
You're protecting your time: your calendar is full, or too many people on your calls can't afford you	Put your price on the application, with a yes or no. On the call, the same question can be one of your first (words below); still pace the first objection	10, 16

WHEN	THEN	CHAPTER
A money red flag early in the call, at any volume	Use the yes-or-no check below, then carry on or part kindly, without digging	11
Stage		
Your first 30 to 50 calls	Stay close to the script, nearly word for word and in order. After that, navigate by the beliefs and keep the structure	12
Your first six to twelve months in business	Hold the offer loosely, and treat early calls partly as market research: a way to learn what the people you serve really need help with	
No testimonials yet	Lean on how closely you'll work together and on your own story; where their concern is risk, a first-session refund can answer it	19
Unsure someone is ready	Offer a short assessment call of 15 to 20 minutes first, or a masterclass	10, Appendix A
Your one-to-one business brings in under about $10,000 a month	Design the offer with them, still as one prescription. Past about $20,000 to $30,000 a month, sell a fixed offer	14
They're certain and tell you they need a plan	If you're newer to selling, or sell personal change: one simple split. With business clients and more experience: the fuller money conversation	17
Price point		
Under about $1,000	No call needed. Under about $500, sell from a sales page or direct messages, where a money-back guarantee is fine; up to about $1,000, a masterclass can sell it	
Above a couple of thousand dollars, and almost always from $5,000	Sell on a call of 45 to 60 minutes	10

WHEN	THEN	CHAPTER
Warmth		
Cold: from an ad, through a webinar, to the call	Full discovery; warm them before the call where you can	10
Warm, from your marketing	A couple of questions to stretch the gap, then the offer; skip any belief they've already put in their own words	
Already sold: past buyers, referrals	You can share the price up front; a text offer can work, though a call converts better	
The buyer		
Good to great, high-end, or can't name a problem	Open on desire, back into what's in the way, and still name the stakes	12
Head-centered: weighs things logically	Impact questions, not feeling questions. Mid-pitch, check in with "Does it make sense to you?"; still close the pitch with "I'm happy to answer any questions you have about how that all works"	4
Intuitive: goes by feel	Mid-pitch, check in with "How is this feeling for you?"	
The setting		
Someone who messaged you	Desire first, a few questions, book in the thread; never an application	10
A client renewing	Prefer a call to a text: it's a new sale, with a new gap	20
A live launch or event, not a one-to-one call	A real one-off deadline incentive, framed as a bonus or special pricing; never extend it	
Who pays		
A company buying for its team	Find the decision maker first, and price on the value to the organization. Anything written builds on their numbers and never replaces the conversation	

The check in those rows is one plain question about the investment, answered yes or no. On a call, ask it early.

A money red flag is something someone tells you early on, like having no income right now, that makes the investment a real question. A hunch isn't one. Even when the flag is real, you don't decide for someone what they can afford. You ask.

> SAY IT LIKE THIS
>
> "Before we go any further, I want to be upfront about one thing. I don't know enough about your situation yet to say for sure whether I can help you. But if we do decide to work together, you'd be looking at an investment of [X]. Is that doable for you?"

It's upfront about the investment and admits you don't yet know whether you can help, which keeps it kind. If it's a yes, carry on with discovery and don't dig. The last two sentences, without the opening "But," also work on their own: on your application, before someone books, or early on when your calendar is full.

Every row changes how you reach the decision: how much friction, how many questions, when the number comes. None of them changes what the call is for.

APPENDIX E

Replying to applications

THIS ONE IS for you if people apply to work with you: through an application, an intake form, or any form they fill in on the way to a sales call.

When someone fills in your application, they're connected to their gap. They've just written down where they are, what they want and what's standing in the way. By the time you reply, hours or days later, that isn't present in their mind anymore. The pain or the desire that made them apply has slipped out of view. If you invite them to a call without reconnecting them to it, they're much more likely to ghost.

So I don't start with the call. I start by reflecting their gap back to them, in their own words. Once they've confirmed it, I invite them to the call as the next step, and I position it as the way to close that gap.

That simple shift has saved me a lot of ghosted calls, and you can use it on the next application you get.

The texts

I reply by text whenever I can. If someone lives in another country, I use email instead: one email that covers the same ground, reflecting their gap back as a question, inviting them to the call in the same words, and ending with the booking link.

By text, each line in quotes below is its own message: send it, then send the next. Brackets are yours to fill, and italics are what you do.

1. Reflect the gap

> SAY IT LIKE THIS
>
> "Hey [name], [your name] here."
>
> "Just saw your application come in on my site."
>
> "I appreciate your [something specific you liked about them or their application]."
>
> "For clarity, it sounds like you're [where they are today], wanting help with [their biggest challenge], so you can get on track to [their biggest goal]?"
>
> *Wait for their reply. It's usually some version of* "Yep, that's it." *Then:*
>
> "Got it."

Filled in for a coach who's just getting started, the two lines with brackets look like this:

> *"I appreciate your mission of helping women overcome burnout. That's important work."*

> *"For clarity, it sounds like you're just getting started as a coach, wanting help getting clients, so you can get on track to 10K a month and quit your nine-to-five?"*

If you need to qualify them further, this is the place. Ask a question or two, and keep them brief. If they don't know you yet, send them a masterclass or a long-form training first, and invite them to a call once they've had a chance to watch it. Otherwise, go straight on.

2. Invite them to close it

> SAY IT LIKE THIS
>
> "Based on all this, I definitely think it's worth us setting aside some time to chat."
>
> "I'd like to take a closer look at where you're at today and where you want to go."
>
> "And lay out a roadmap to get you on track to [their main goal] ASAP."
>
> "From there, if I think I'm the best person to help you get there, I'm happy to share the details."
>
> "Does that sound like a good next step for us?"
>
> *Wait for their reply. It's usually some version of* "Yes, sounds good." *Then:*
>
> "Great. Do you want to go ahead and book a time here?"
>
> *Your booking link.*

For the coach above, the roadmap line becomes "And lay out a roadmap to get you on track to that 10K-a-month mark ASAP."

3. If they don't book

They should book within 24 hours. If they don't, send one more text the next day, and make it reconnect them to what they wanted.

> SAY IT LIKE THIS
>
> "Hey [name], were you still looking for some help with [their biggest challenge]?"

If they don't reply to that, let it go. I haven't found following up more than once to be effective. If someone needs several follow-ups to book a call, they're probably not serious.

Not enough applications coming in?

These texts turn more applications into booked calls. If too few people are applying, or the wrong people are, the fix comes earlier, in your marketing. If you want help getting more of the right people to apply, book a free 20-minute business assessment call with me, and we'll take a personal look at your business.

BOOK YOUR FREE ASSESSMENT CALL

Why it works

The gap comes first. Before the call is even mentioned, they're back in touch with where they are and where they want to be. The words are theirs, not yours, so it lands as being understood rather than being sold to.

They confirm it. The reflection ends in a question, and you wait. When they write back "Yep, that's it," they've told you in their own words that the gap is real. Now the call has a reason to exist.

"Got it," and nothing more. No gushing. You're calm, and you're leading.

The call is the bridge. You don't offer them a call. You offer a closer look at where they are, and a roadmap to the goal they've just confirmed. Nobody wants to book a call with you. They want what the call gets them (Chapter 10).

The door is open, honestly. "If I think I'm the best person to help you get there" tells them you're assessing, not chasing. "I'm happy to share the details" tells them there'll be an offer if it fits, so nobody's surprised when you make one.

The yes comes before the link. "Does that sound like a good next step for us?" gets their agreement to the call itself. The link comes after that yes, so booking is simply the next step they've already agreed to.

One follow-up, then let go. The one message you send goes back to the gap. It isn't "just checking in" (Chapter 20). Chasing past that only tells them you need the call more than they do.

LINEAGE

Where this came from

FOR YEARS, the third belief I teach in discovery went by another name. I called it doubt. It wasn't a great word, and I said so when I taught it. But it was the best one I had.

These days I call it help. Pain and desire make a gap. Help is what makes it a gap they need you for.

But I didn't come up with the belief. I learned it from Cole Gordon.

Much of this book came to me the same way: through people I learned from, and above all through Cole. All of it is my method, because I lived it on my own calls until it became the way I sell. That's how it will become yours, too: on your own calls, not on the page.

Cole Gordon

Cole is a sales trainer, coach and consultant I worked with a while back, and he's the source of the core of my approach. I took more than tools from him: a lot of my philosophy around sales is the result of learning from him. You've met his ideas all through this book, each credited where it first appeared.

Start with the beliefs, because help is only one of them. The core beliefs I named in Chapter 2 and taught in full in Chapter 12 are a modified version of his framework, and he's the one who helped me understand them. They're the handful of things someone has to feel are true before they'll buy, and they tell me whether discovery has done its job. There are six, and they run

across the top of every page of notes I take on a call, in this order: PAIN · DESIRE · HELP · TRUST · WHY NOW · COST. I listen for each one to land.

Much of how I run a call came from him: the parts every call moves through, in the order I lay out in Parts Four and Five, and a good part of the script that goes with them in Appendix A. So did much of the conversation in Chapter 14 for designing an offer with someone, which suits a particular stage of business.

The 1-to-10 temperature check in Chapter 15 is his, down to the line that makes people laugh and keeps a heavy moment light: "1 being, screw you, I want to hang up the phone." When I teach it, I say so as I go: that's from Cole, by the way.

Pacing the first objection, in Chapter 16, is his, name and all, and it's my opening move once the number has landed. The phrase at its heart, "financial logistics aside," is his too. So is the open look at someone's numbers in Chapter 17, which I learned from him as the open-wallet conversation. So is much of my language around certainty and payment plans.

The temperature check, pacing and the open-wallet conversation have one thing in common: each puts the honest conversation first. The temperature check asks how the process feels before the number is on the table, while concerns are still easy to talk about. Pacing makes sure someone is certain, twice, before anyone discusses how they'll pay. The open-wallet conversation looks, with permission, at what comes in, what goes out and what they can draw on before any plan is chosen, because I won't put anyone in a position where they're not set up to win.

Some of it I've changed, and not just a name. I now use the temperature check as a tool, not a rule: I ask it when it helps, and I don't count it against a call that leaves it out.

When an idea changes how we sell, it's easy to start talking as if we'd thought of it ourselves. I'd rather you know where these came from.

I've used every one of them on call after call and seen what they do for the person on the other end. But they started with him, and I'm grateful. If this book helps you on your next call, some of that help is his.

The others

Keenan's book *Gap Selling* shaped how I see the gap as the engine of a sale, and it gave me the story of the two mechanics and the wedding in Chapter 4.

Assess, don't impress is Taki Moore's phrase, and the picture that goes with it in Chapter 7 is his too. Simon Cowell, in the judge's chair deciding whether the person in front of him is good enough, isn't trying to impress anyone.

Scott Oldford, one of my business coaches and a mentor, gave me two things you'll find here. One is his levels of consciousness: people decide from different levels, some by reacting, some by thinking it through, some by trusting their intuition. Pressure tactics are built for people who are only reacting, and they push thoughtful buyers away (Chapter 9).

The other is making offers often without harming the relationship, which I learned on the receiving end. He's the one in Chapter 20 who keeps pitching me, and I still get excited every time.

Keith Rosen taught me to call out the elephant in the room, the thing that's there but unspoken, instead of bulldozing through it. The words I use for it are his: "I'm sensing … is there any truth to that?" (Chapter 13).

The reframe I teach in Chapter 16 changes what an objection means to the person holding it, so the barrier becomes the reason. I learned it, I think, from Taylor Welch.

I've learned a few things from Jeremy Miner. When someone is weighing me against a cheaper option, the question I ask is his: "Do you want the cheapest? Or do you want the best solution that's actually going to get you to [where they want to be]?" (Appendix C).

One line I use quite often is Alex Hormozi's: "You're actually going to make this investment either way." Someone pays it now, to get where they want to be faster, or pays it over the next couple of years in all the time and money it takes to figure it out alone. I say it only when I believe it (Appendix C).

A few more things came from other people. One of my first sales coaches taught me that an invitation has to connect to what someone wants, not to the call itself (Chapter 10).

Somebody once told me that a person's best thinking got them to the call (Chapter 5). My colleague Kim Argetsinger says people show up to a call hoping you're the real deal (Chapter 7). And a mentor once asked me the five-million-dollar question, which I've since turned into a question to ask before you pitch someone (Chapter 9).

My own

The rest came from my own calls, years of them, and from other coaches' calls: the ones I've listened to with some of my one-to-one clients, and the transcripts I often analyze.

The course I gave away that nobody opened, the webinars where I was terrible at pitching, the man I signed in scarcity and refunded: nobody taught me those. I lived them. And it was in a deodorant aisle, not a training, that I finally saw why the people on my calls couldn't decide.

Most of the mistakes in this book, I made first. Someone I was coaching once told me the hardest part for him was sending me screenshots of his messages to people, because he was afraid he'd look like an idiot. I told him what I'd tell you.

I've made so many terrible mistakes with messages and with sales. I've screwed up so many deals. There's nothing you could send me that I'd look at and say: oh, I haven't done that before.

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To the people who taught me, thank you.

And to everyone who has been on the other end of one of my calls, thank you too. You taught me the rest.



About the author

I'M A BUSINESS COACH and a former Director of Sales. I work one-to-one with coaches, consultants and service-based business owners who have built something that works and want to grow it. That often includes reviewing their sales calls.

Selling didn't come naturally to me. I'm an introvert, and I started out teaching musicians to record and mix their own music.

I learned it from the teachers I name in *Where this came from*, and from years of my own calls, plenty of them bad ones. I still take sales calls, and I'm still learning.

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